First Edition

The Fantastic Book of Fretboard Diagrams for Bass Guitar

Rajiv Narang

The Fantastic Book of Fretboard Diagrams for Bass Guitar

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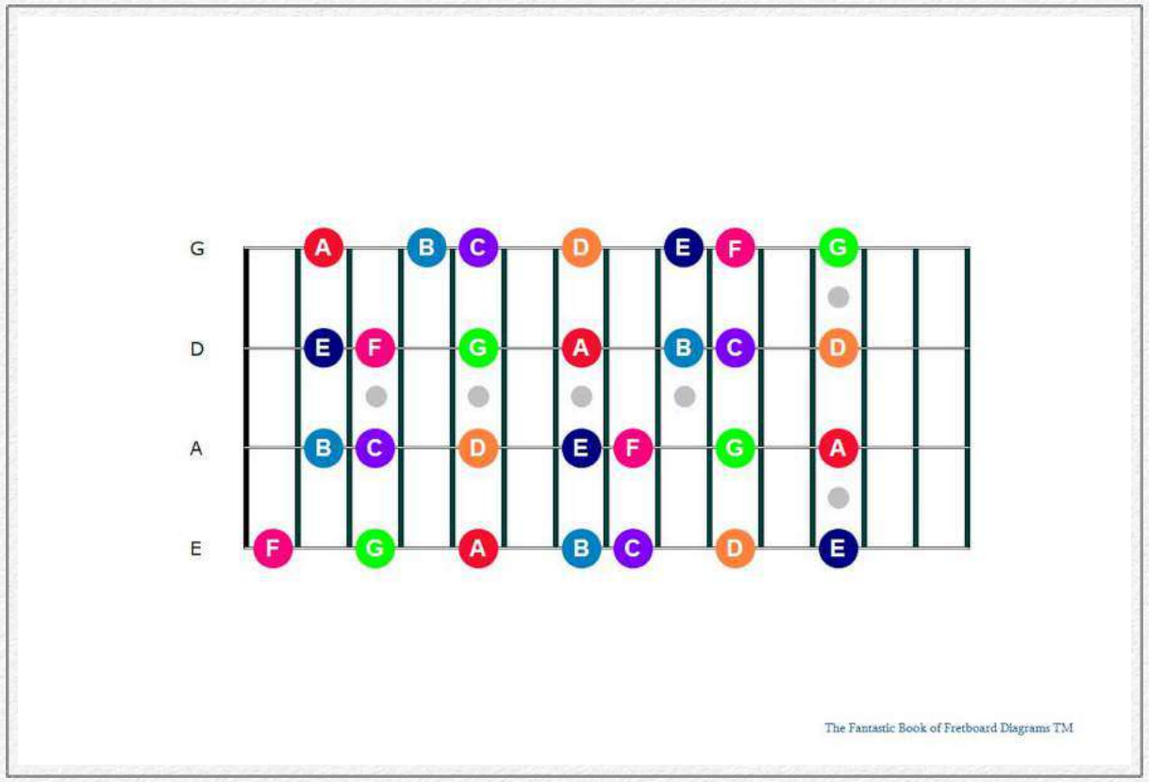
Natural Notes and Intervals

1

Preparation.

The Natural Notes

Fretboard Knowledge



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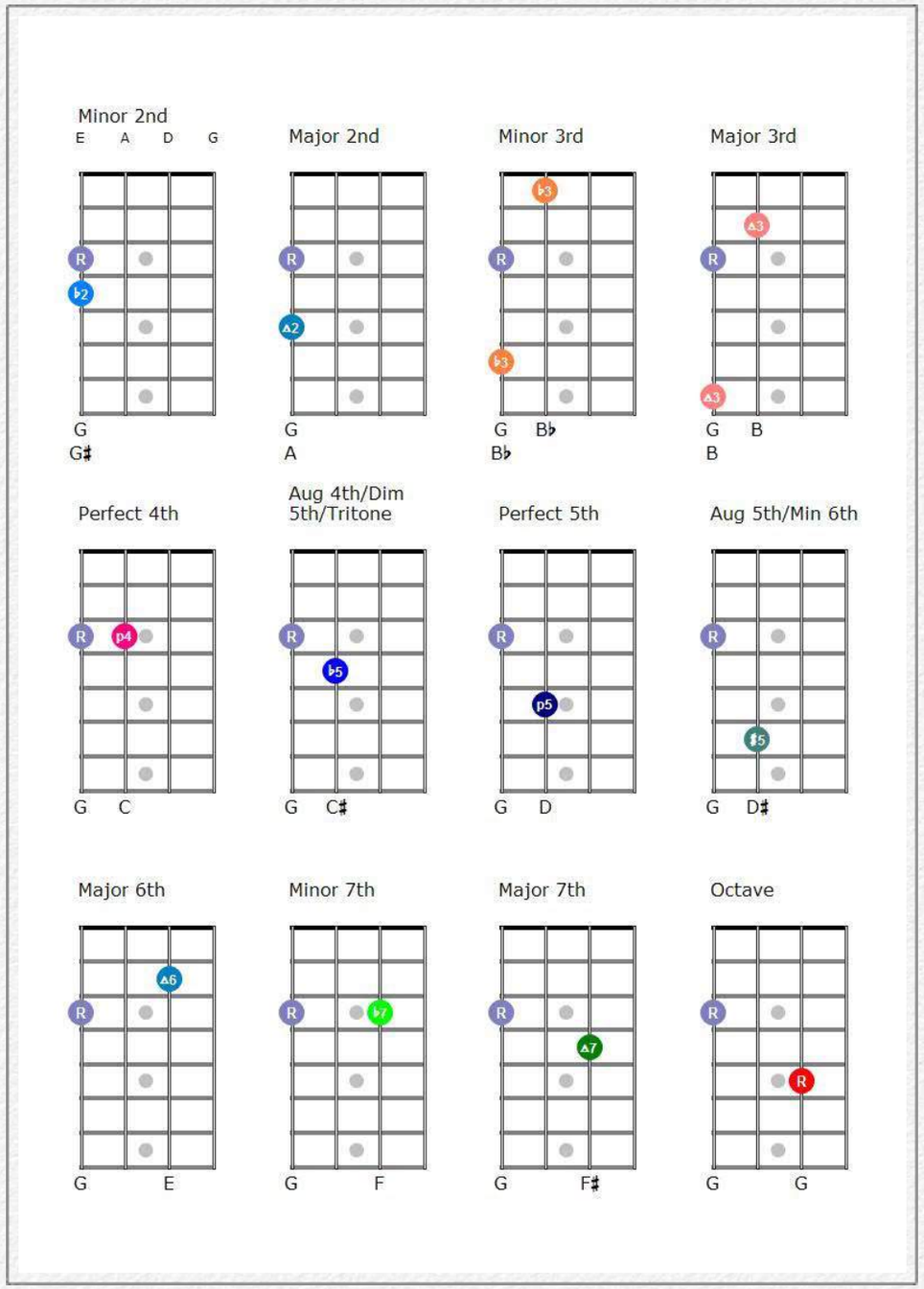


Music Theory

Fundamentals.

2

Music Theory I

Key Topics

1. **The Overtone Series**
2. **The Triad**
3. **The Major Scale**
4. **12 Notes**
5. **The Seven Natural Notes**

Music Theory I

Let's start with the simple concept, a beautiful concept. There's something called the overtone series (also known as the harmonic series).

The Overtone Series

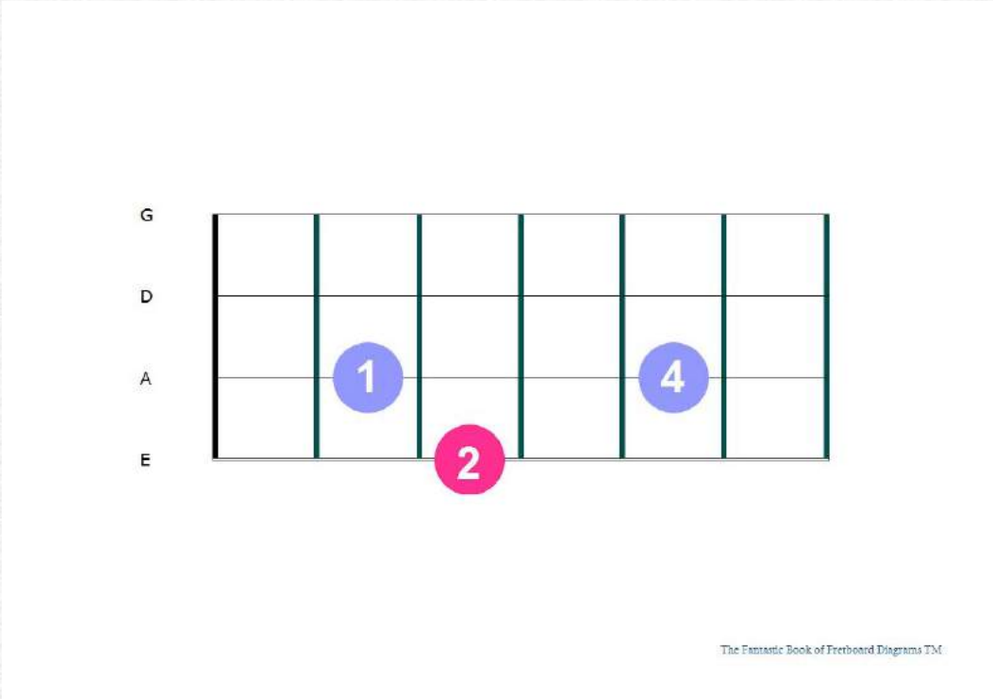
Whenever you play any note on an instrument, that note rings out, but it's not just that singular note ringing out. If you play a C, you hear that C, but if you listen much more closely, there are other tones, other pitches that are occurring within that one note.

When you play a C, (and I recommend you try this), there's the C that occurs at the lowest frequency. At the same moment there's a C that sounds one octave above that root. Above that there's a fifth that rings. Above that there's another octave. And then above that there's a third.
Stacked up, the overtone series looks like this:
E - 3rd
C - 2nd Octave

G - Fifth
C - Octave
C - Root Note (Lowest Note)
So, contained in any note that you play are three notes: the primary root note at the lowest pitch, with its octave and then an octave again, in this case C. But within this C, there are also the intervals of a fifth, which in this case is G, and above that the third, which in this case is a E. All three of these notes, the root, the 3rd and the 5th, are contained within any single note.
Above these notes in the overtone series is also a flat 7th, though whether this pitch can be heard has been a matter of debate.

The Triad
These three notes form the naturally occurring musical phenomenon called a triad. The triad identifies, informs, and builds all harmony. From any single note we play we have, naturally occurring within that note, a major triad.

You can play a major triad on the bass as follows:



The Major Key
If you were to take the major triad and then start on the fifth (the second strongest note in the overtone series) and build another major triad, you've added two notes to this growing musical universe: the intervals of the second and the seventh.
For example, we have the C major triad:
C E G
Build a triad on the 5th (in this case G)
G B D
And we have two additional notes, B and D

Now, we can fill in the largest remaining gaps by playing a triad on the 4th (a whole step down from the 5th). This adds two more notes to our growing musical group, the intervals of a fourth and a sixth.
F A C - Triad built on the 4th adding F and A

These three major triads combined, starting on one, four and five, give us all the notes found in any major (or minor) key.

The Major Scale
When we arrange these seven notes according to pitch, we have the major scale.
1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7
C, D, E, F, G, A, B

Starting with the fundamental triad, the major scale adds four notes: it adds a two (major 2nd), a four (perfect 4th), a six (major 6th) and a seven (major 7th). These notes have been added over time to fill out our scale, and form what we now call a key.

12 Notes
There are 12 notes that are used in Western music, as well as in several other forms of music. If you include every accidental (Sharp or flat) and take every semitone up or down, there are 12 notes before they start to repeat.

Let's take a close look at the 12 notes used in western music. Starting on A we have:
A, B♭, B, C, C#, D, E♭, E, F, F#, G, G#

If we go up semitone by semitone (these are half-steps played by moving up one fret at a time) we can cover all of these notes. There are two exceptions to make note of here. There is no half-step between B and C or between E and F. There is no sharp or flat between them. B goes directly to C and E goes directly to F.

These are all the notes used in Western music. You might be wondering why I called a note C sharp instead of D flat. C sharp and D flat are enharmonic. Enharmonic means they are the same notes, just named differently. So, C sharp is D flat. The name we give it depends on the key we are in — the context we are playing in.

I called it C sharp because C sharp tends to be a little more common. I called another note B flat instead of A sharp because B flat tends to be a little more common. But, again, it all depends on the key you're playing in.

Let's look at one more example so that we are perfectly clear. If we were playing an E, someone might call this note D double sharp (D##). Now, that would be a silly way to name the note and any arranger or composer might aggravate their musicians by doing so, but it is technically correct.

As you're exposed more to charts and key signatures it will become clear which notes are more common.

The Seven Natural Notes

Within these 12 notes there are accidentals (sharps and flats) and natural notes. There are 7 natural notes that exist in western music. Those 7 notes are:
A, B, C, D, E, F, G
Let's rearrange them slightly:
C, D, E, F, G, A, B

Here we have all the notes in the key of C major, which is the only major key that has no sharps or flats. If we play only these notes where C is the root (the tonal centre to which the music resolves) we're playing in the key of C major.

A scale is simply lining up all the notes in a key and playing them up and then down again. This is usually done to the octave.

C Major Scale
C D E F G A B C B A G F E D C

The C major scale includes all of the notes of the key of C major and arranges them according to pitch.

These are the fundamental elements that come from the overtone series. We have the **overtone series** that defines a root, a third and a fifth (as well as an octave). We have the **triad** formed from the notes generated by the overtone series. Extrapolated from the triad have the seven notes found in any **major key**. And when we arrange these notes according to pitch, we have **the major scale** for that key.

Terms:

Overtone - A tone that exists as part of the overtone series (also called the harmonic series) which rings out above the root tone being played.

Interval - An interval is a measure of the distance between two notes. For example, the note C to the note C# a half-step away is an interval called a minor second.

Semitone - An interval of one half-step between two notes (a minor second).

Whole Tone - A distance between two notes of two semitones or half-steps forming a major second.

Triad - A group of three notes forming stacked thirds with the intervals of a root, a third and a fifth.

Scale - An ordering of all the notes of a key in ascending or descending order of pitch.

Key - The seven notes with which a piece of music is composed. There is a major and a minor key for each of the twelve notes in Western music giving us twenty-four unique keys.

Diatonic - Of only the seven notes that belong to a given key (no altered notes).

Position - The placement of the fingers over a set location on the fretboard designated by the fret number under the index finger. The first finger over the first fret gives us first position. The first finger over the fifth fret gives us fifth position.

Music Theory II

Key Topics

1. **The Major Scale and the Minor Scale**
2. **Relative Keys**
3. **12 Major Keys, 12 Minor Keys**
4. **The Modes**

Music Theory II

If you were to just run notes up the neck playing whole tones so that you were only playing every second fret, you would be playing a whole tone scale. The whole tone scale doesn't have the same clear identity that a major or minor scale does.

The Major Scale and the Minor Scale

The major scale and the minor scale both have very clear characters formed by the placement and character of triads and by the placement of the two half-steps that function as leading tones.

The major scale — major triads built on the root, the 4th and the 5th intervals.

The minor scale — minor triads built on the root, the 4th and the 5th intervals.

The major scale has half-steps between the 3rd and 4th notes and between the 7th and 8th notes.

The minor scale, also known as the natural minor scale, has half-steps between the 2nd and 3rd notes and between the 5th and 6th notes.

These half-steps, occurring in exactly these places help define the character of the scale. So, in C major we have:

C D E F G A B C

This is the classic do-re-mi-fa-sol-la-ti-do sound from the solfège system.

If someone were to play these notes, we could identify the major scale.

Relative Keys

If you play the major scale, but start on the 6th (in this case on the A) and play all the same notes, you have the minor scale.

The C major scale:

C D E F G A B C

The same notes but with a different root, gives us the A minor scale:

A B C D E F G A

In this case, since we started on A, we have A minor.

These two scales share a special connection. They are relative. If you play the notes of any major scale starting on the 6th interval, you get the relative minor. Consequently, if you play the notes of any minor scale starting on the 3rd interval you get the relative major. To simplify, the relative minor is found three frets below the root of any major scale.

The relative minor of C major is A minor. The relative major of A minor is C major. These two keys share a common key signature, have all the same notes, and are therefore relative keys.

In defining whether we are in a major key or minor key, it is the tonal centre that changes. When the tonal centre changes, everything changes. If the music resolves to C -- we are most likely in C major. If the music resolves to A -- we are most likely in A minor.

12 Major Keys, 12 Minor Keys

So, we have major keys and minor keys. As there are 12 notes in total, and two types of keys, we have 24 keys in Western music: 12 major keys and 12 minor keys.

The Modes

If you were to start on any of the other notes of the major scale and play through to the octave, you are playing a mode. Modes are seven note scales built off of the major scale. There are seven modes in total, each with its own unique tonal character.

The seven modes are:

Ionian

Dorian

Phrygian

Lydian

Mixolydian

Aeolian

Locrian

Note that the Ionian mode is another name for the major scale and the Aeolian mode is another name for the minor scale.

With each of the modes, the two character-defining half-steps shift to different locations relative to the root of the mode.

Note also that each of these modes fits perfectly with one chord.

Terms:

Diatonic Scale - A stepwise arrangement of the seven notes of a major or minor key. The major scale and the minor scale are both diatonic scales.

Mode - Playing the notes of the major scale with a new tonal centre other than the original root. By making one of the other notes of the major scale the new tonal centre, new melodic characteristics take shape.

Mobile Scale - A scale that contains no open strings and can therefore be played anywhere on the neck.

Chromatic - Movement by a series of consecutive semitones. Moving by half-steps either ascending or descending.

Music Theory III

Key Topics

1. **Four Types of Triads**
2. **Chord Construction**
3. **Chord Inversions**
4. **Chord Order**
5. **Chords and Modes**

Test your ability to recognize all four triad types instantly by ear. You can begin with this free practice session.

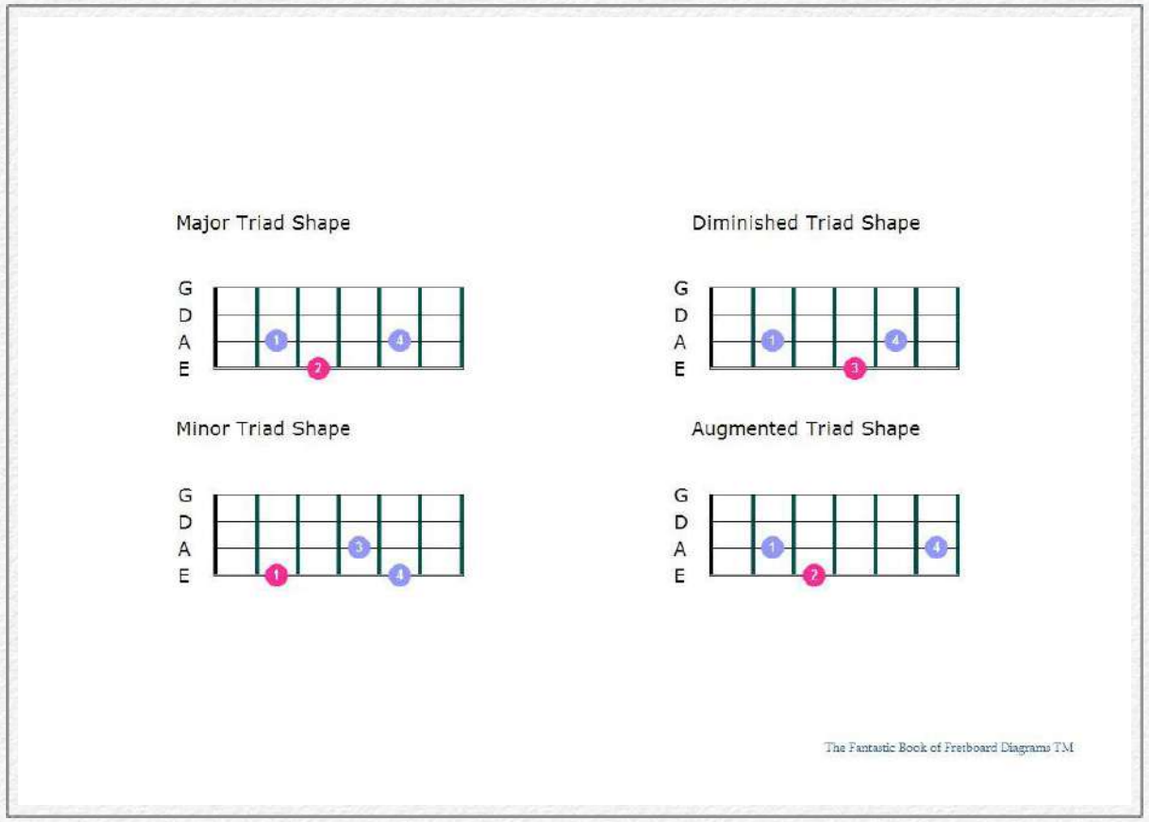
Four Types of Triads

Major -- made of a root, major 3rd, and a perfect 5th (1, 3, 5)

Minor -- root, minor 3rd, and a perfect 5th (1, ♭3, 5)

Diminished -- root. minor 3rd, flat 5th (1, ♭3, ♭5)

Augmented -- root, major 3rd, sharp 5th (1, 3, #5)



We will explore these four types and their variations in a later chapter.

Chord Construction

Chords are built with triads. Three-note chords are built using the notes of a triad. For example, a G major chord consists of just three notes, a root (G), a major 3rd interval above the root (B) and a perfect 5th above the root (D). These three notes can be repeated as many times as you like. A G major chord can be played with only the three notes of the triad on a guitar or the three triad notes can be played by 60 different instruments in an orchestra. So long as the G stays the lowest note, it remains a G major chord in what is known as "root position."

Chord Inversions

If the 3rd or the 5th of the triad is played as the bass note (lowest note) of the chord instead of the root, the chord is an inversion. There are three general ways to invert a chord beyond root position.

Root Position - the root is in the bass.

1st Inversion - the 3rd is in the bass.

2nd Inversion - the 5th is in the bass.

3rd Inversion - for chords of four notes or more, such as 7th chords, the 7th or another interval is in the bass.

For example, a G major chord in standard root position, has G as the lowest sounding note.

G, B, D

G major in 1st inversion has B as the lowest note.

B, D, G

G major in 2nd inversion has D as the lowest note.

D, G, B

G major 7th (G, B, D, F#) has the 7th (F#) as the lowest note.

To indicate that a note other than the root is in the bass, a slash is used:

G/B

The letter on the left indicates the chord and the letter on the right designates the bass note. Slash chord notation can be used to place any note in the bass, even notes beyond the triad.

The slash serves another purpose when it is used, typically with roman numerals, to analyze chord functions in a chord progression.

Chord Order

Building triads on each of the notes of the major scale gives us the seven principal three-note chords in any major key. They are, in order:

I - Major

ii - Minor

iii - Minor

IV - Major

V - Major

vi - Minor

vii - Diminished

It is important to note that these chords are made of <u>only the seven notes of the key</u>. The term for this is diatonic. If the notes used are diatonic, no accidentals (sharps or flats) have yet been added to alter or add notes to a given key.

In C major, the three-note chords are:

C Major

D Minor

E Minor

F Major

G Major

A Minor

B Diminished

Note that the I chord in the key of C major is the C major chord.

To generate all the chords for a minor key, simply start on the sixth of the major scale. This gives us the relative minor. The relative minor of C major is A minor. The chord order needs to be adjusted as A minor is the i chord in the key of A minor.

i - Minor

ii - Diminished

III - Major

iv - Minor

v - Minor

VI - Major

VII - Major

Constructing 7th Chords

A new colour can be added to these three-note chords by the stacking of another 3rd on top of the triad. This generates the interval of a 7th above the root note. These new chords are therefore built with the notes of a root, a third, a fifth and a seventh (1, 3, 5, 7).

There are four types of 7th chords that are diatonic to a given key:

Major 7th -- a major triad with a major 7th (1, 3, 5, 7)

Minor 7th -- a minor triad with a minor 7th (1, ♭3, 5, ♭7)

Dominant 7th -- a major triad with a minor 7th (1, 3, 5, ♭7)

Minor 7♭5 -- a diminished triad with a minor 7th (1, ♭3, ♭5, ♭7)

These diatonic seventh chords are ordered as follows:

I - Major 7th

ii - Minor 7th

iii - Minor 7th

IV - Major 7th

V - Dominant 7th

vi - Minor 7th

vii - Minor 7♭5

Note that these 7th chords are simply extensions of the triads.

Chords and Modes

Chords and modes have a particular fit. They can support each others function in a piece of music. Just like playing the C major scale with a C major chord, <u>each of the modes corresponds to diatonic chords that share the same root note</u>.

The modes fit with these chords as follows:

C Major or C Major 7th -- C Ionian

D Minor or D Minor 7th -- D Dorian

E Minor or E Minor 7th -- E Phrygian

F Major or F Major 7th -- F Lydian

G Major or G Dominant 7th -- G Mixolydian

A Minor or A Minor 7th -- A Aeolian

B Diminished or B Minor 7♭5 -- B Locrian

For minor keys, the modes stay with their same chords.

A Minor or A Minor 7th -- A Aeolian

B Diminished or B Minor 7 ♭ 5 -- B Locrian

C Major or C Major 7th -- C Ionian

D Minor or D Minor 7th -- D Dorian

E Minor or E Minor 7th -- E Phrygian

F Major or F Major 7th -- F Lydian

G Major or G Dominant 7th -- G Mixolydian

Notice that all the modes use the same notes as the major or minor scale from which they are derived. So, with a good ear, you could play the C major scale with all of the chords of C major, or the A minor scale with all the chords of A minor. It's the tonal centre that changes from one key to the next or from one chord to the next.

Playing just these diatonic notes is referred to as "playing inside." If you were to add or change notes beyond the seven notes of a given key, it would be referred to as "playing outside." Any of the modes can be modified by sharps or flats to change the character though this is more common for a lead part that is not functioning to support the melody.

Terms:

Arpeggio - The playing of a chord one note at a time rather than all at once. In an arpeggio, each interval of the chord is sounded independently.

Root Position - A chord that has its root in the base.

Inversion - A chord with an interval other than the root in the base.

Diminished Interval - An interval that is always one half-step lower than a minor interval of the same numerical name.

Augmented Interval - An interval that is always one half-step higher than a major interval of the same numerical name.

If you've enjoyed this brief introduction to music theory keep your musical momentum going with the companion course:

The Elements of Music

or with another top program

Music Theory Comprehensive.

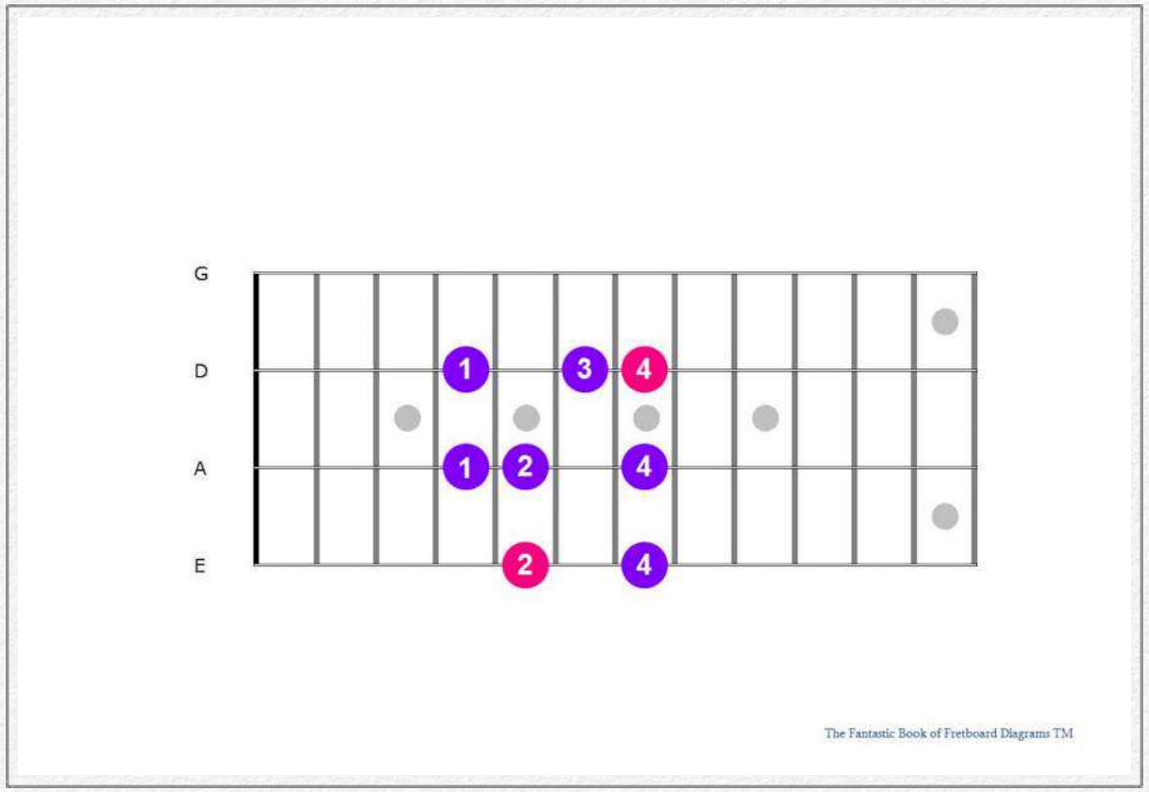
The Major Scale and the Minor Scale

3

The major and minor scales are built by playing all the notes in a given major or minor key in ascending and descending order.

The Major Scale

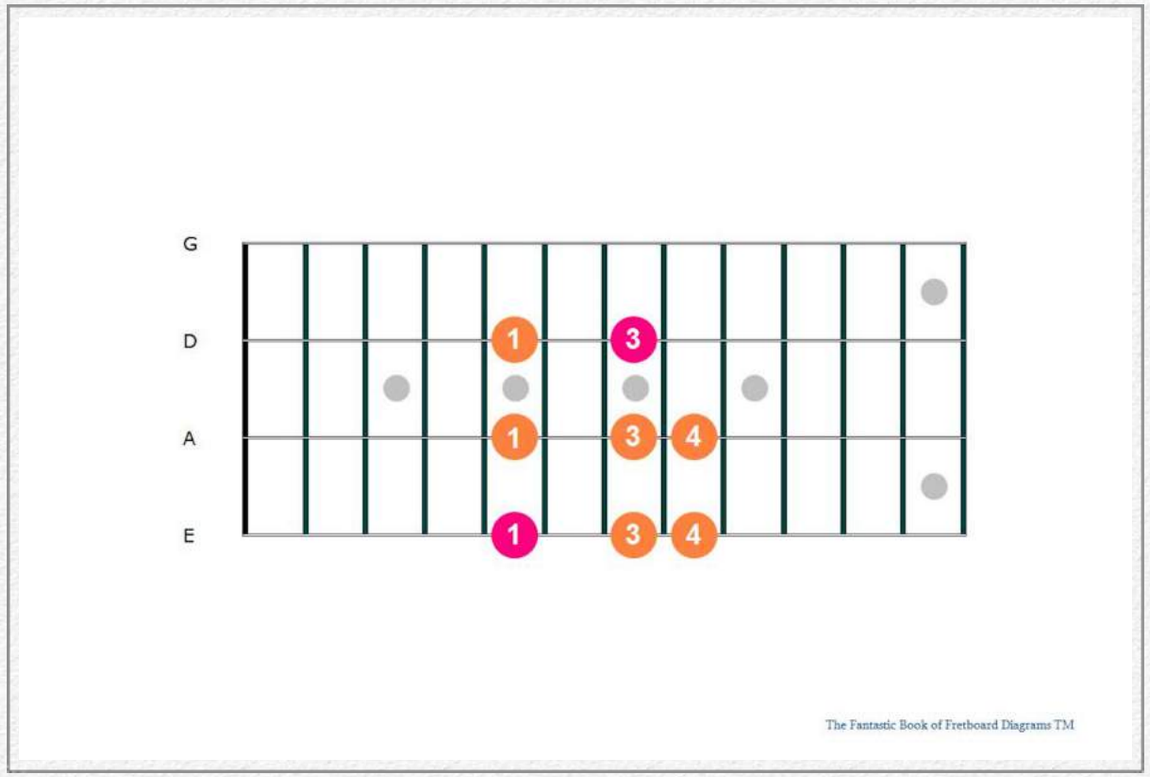
One Octave - The Mobile Form



This scale is mobile. The root placement determines the key. The root is highlighted in red. Here the root is on A, so this is A major. Move the pattern down two frets and you have G major. Move it up three frets and you know have C major.

The Minor Scale

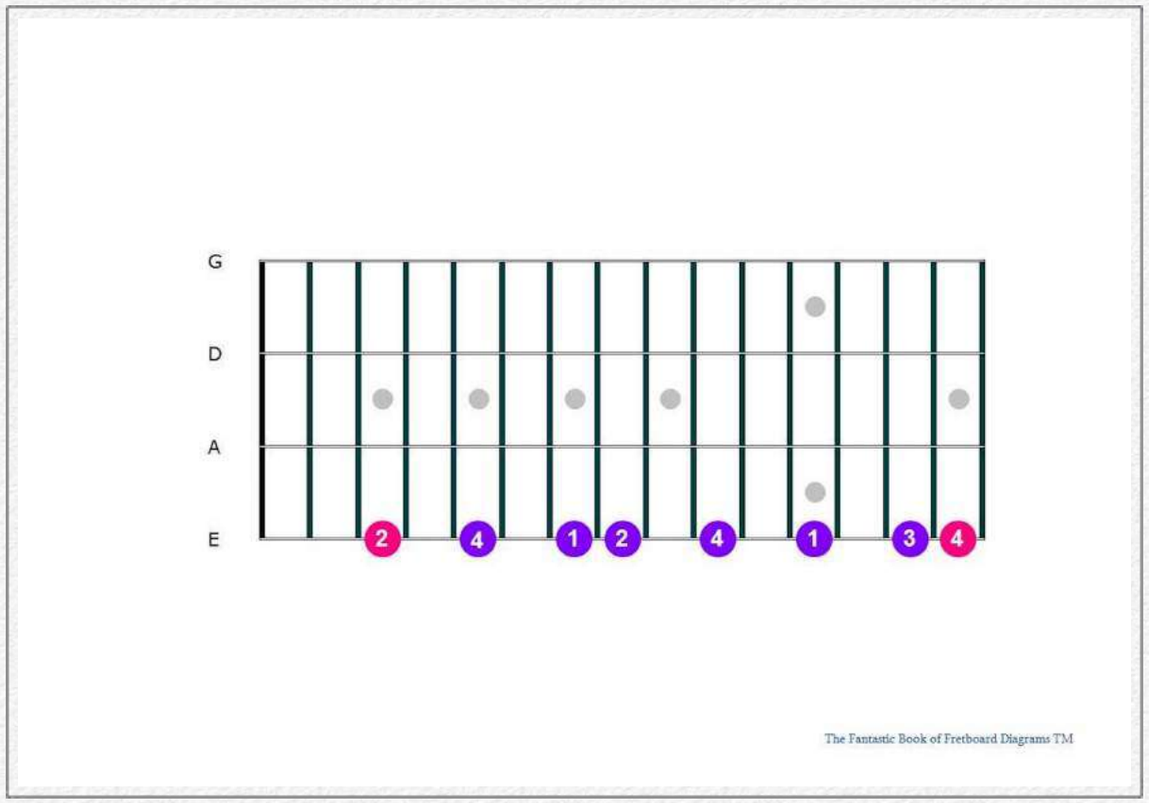
One Octave - Mobile Form



This scale is also mobile and the root placement determines the key. Here the root is on A so you have A minor. Move the pattern down two frets and you have G minor. Move it up three frets and you have C minor.

The Major Scale

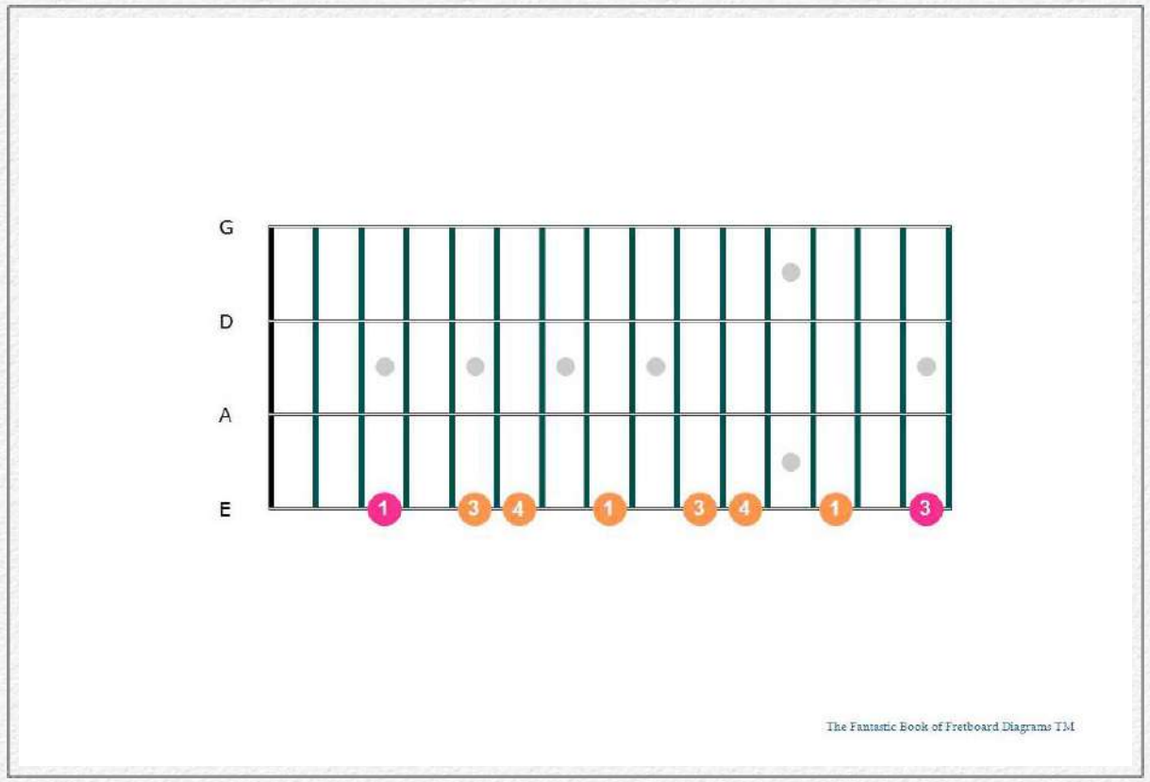
Linear



Here is the linear form of the major scale. Notice that the finger pattern is the same as the one octave mobile form except that movement is up the same string.

The Minor Scale

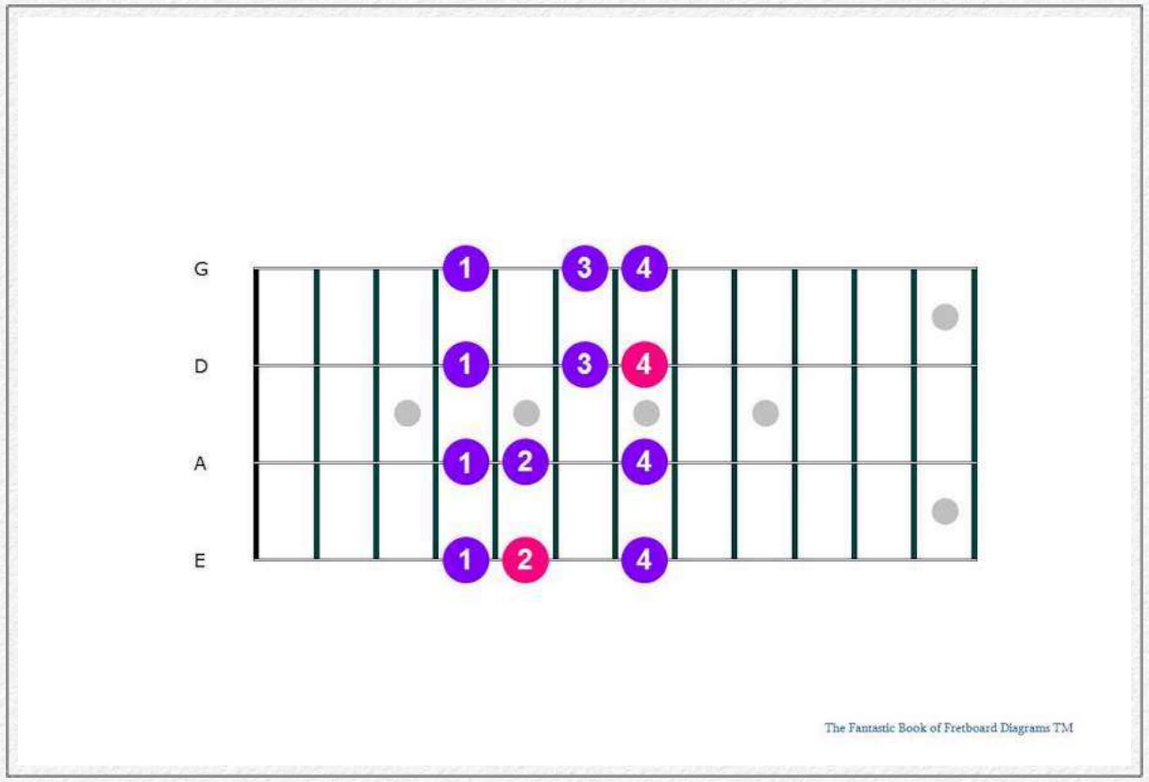
Linear



Notice that that finger pattern here is the same as the one octave minor scale mobile form, but the above version ascends a single string.

The Major Scale

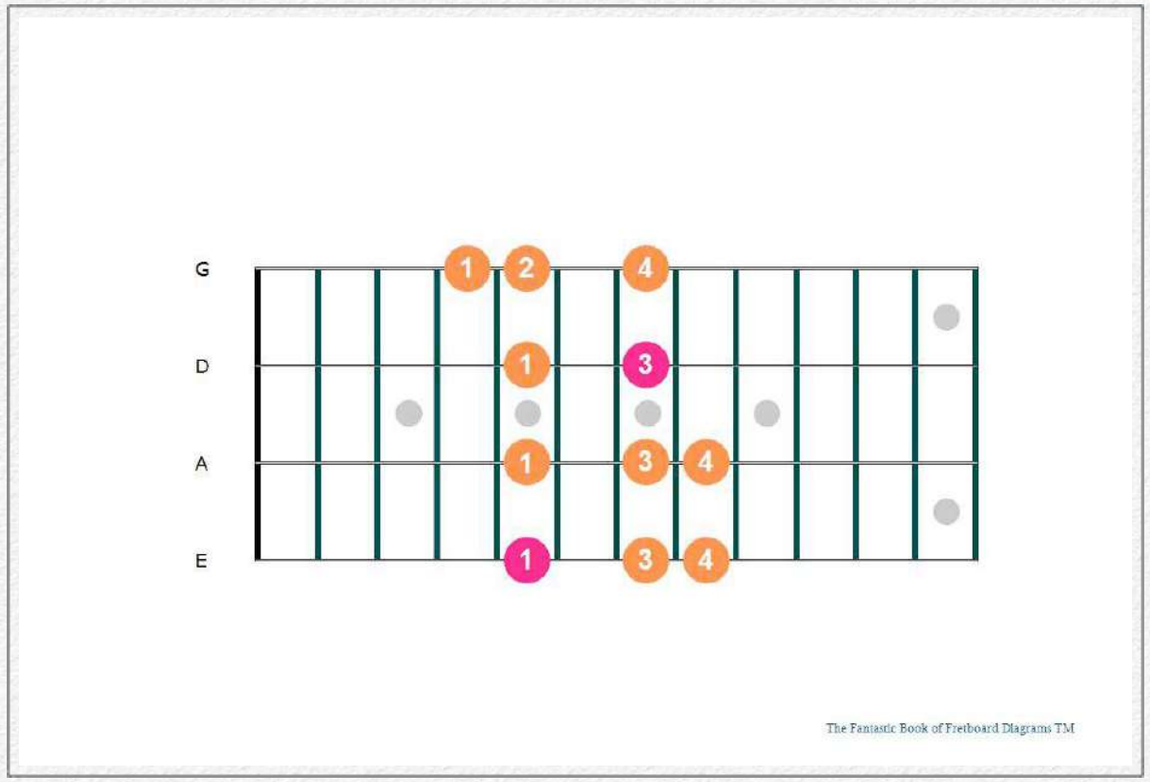
Expanded



This scale shape includes all of the notes of the major scale that are available in this position.

The Minor Scale

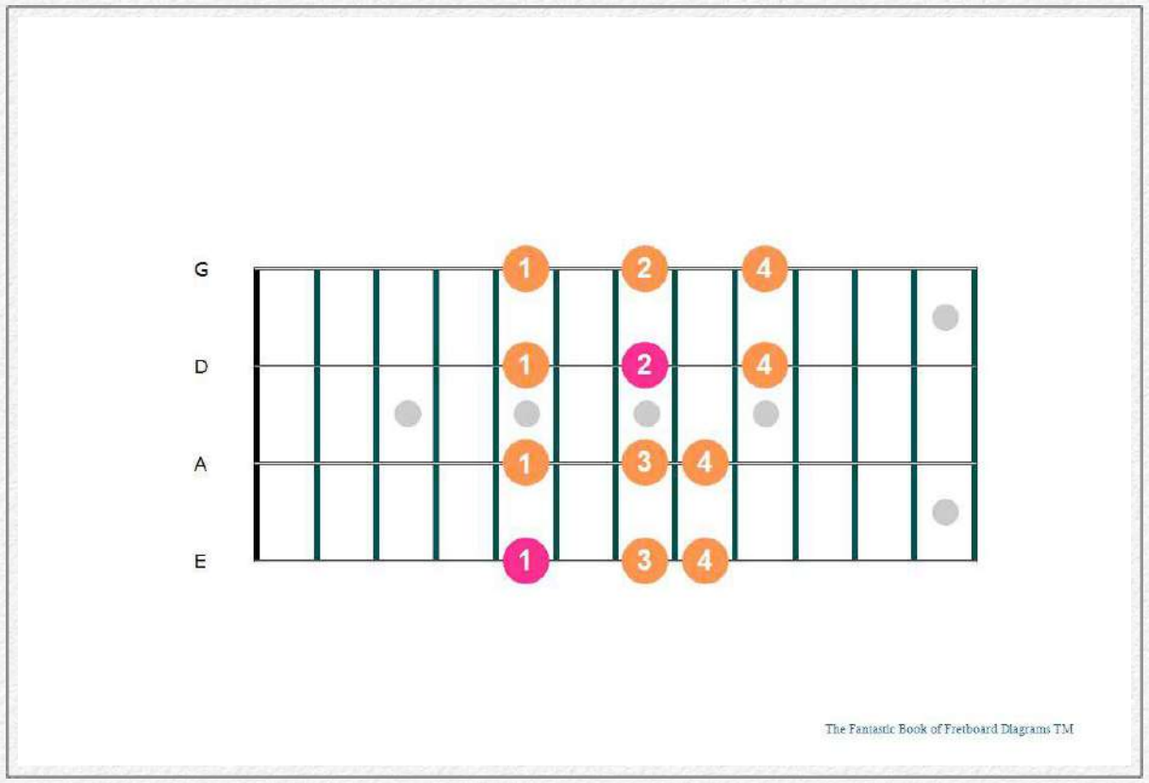
Expanded - Version 1



This scale shape includes all of the notes of the minor scale that are available in this position.

The Minor Scale

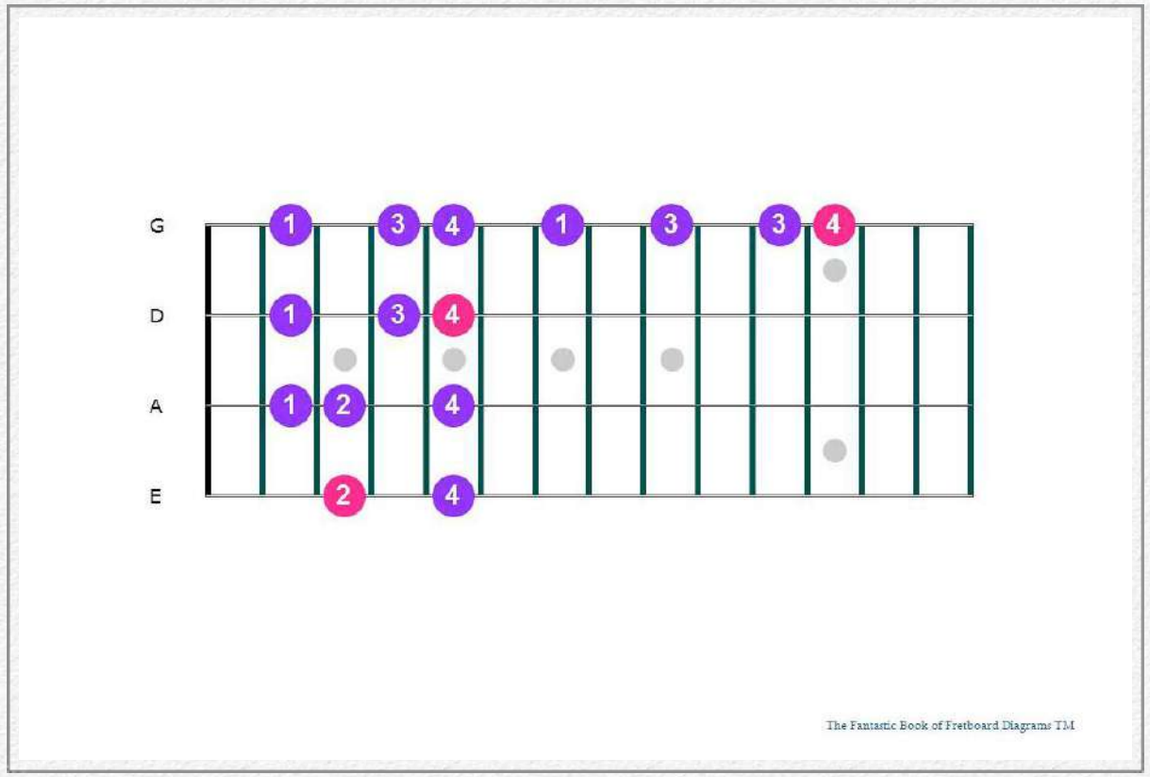
Expanded - Version 2



Remember, these are mobile scales. Any note you begin this scale with is the tonic or root of the scale. This diagram shows the scale starting on the A at the 5th fret of the E string, therefore the scale is A minor. Move the scale down one fret and you have A flat (G sharp) minor. Move the scale up two frets and you have B minor. You can move the scale anywhere you like.

The Major Scale

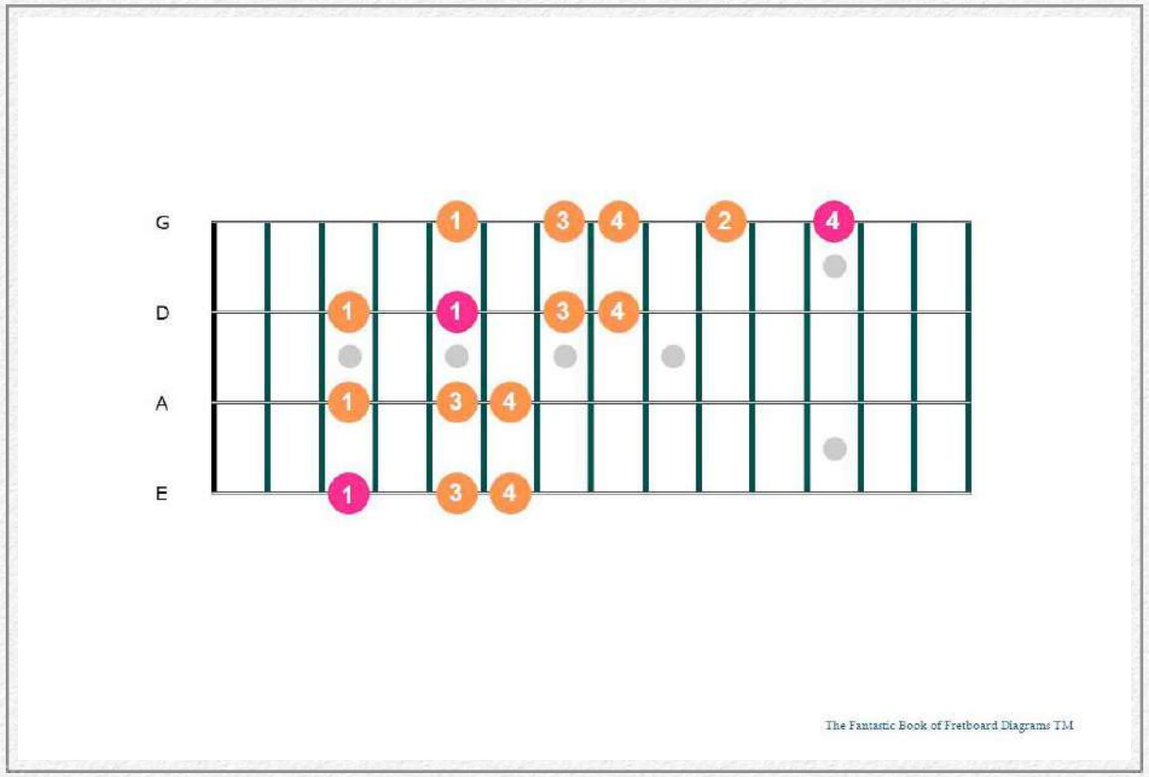
Two Octaves



Note that the highest two notes (shown above with a finger placement of 3-4) can also be played with fingers 1-2. Chose the finger placement based on what you want to play next. Generally, if you want to stay around the high notes, use 1-2 which sets up playing around the high G on the 12th fret (so, second finger is the root).

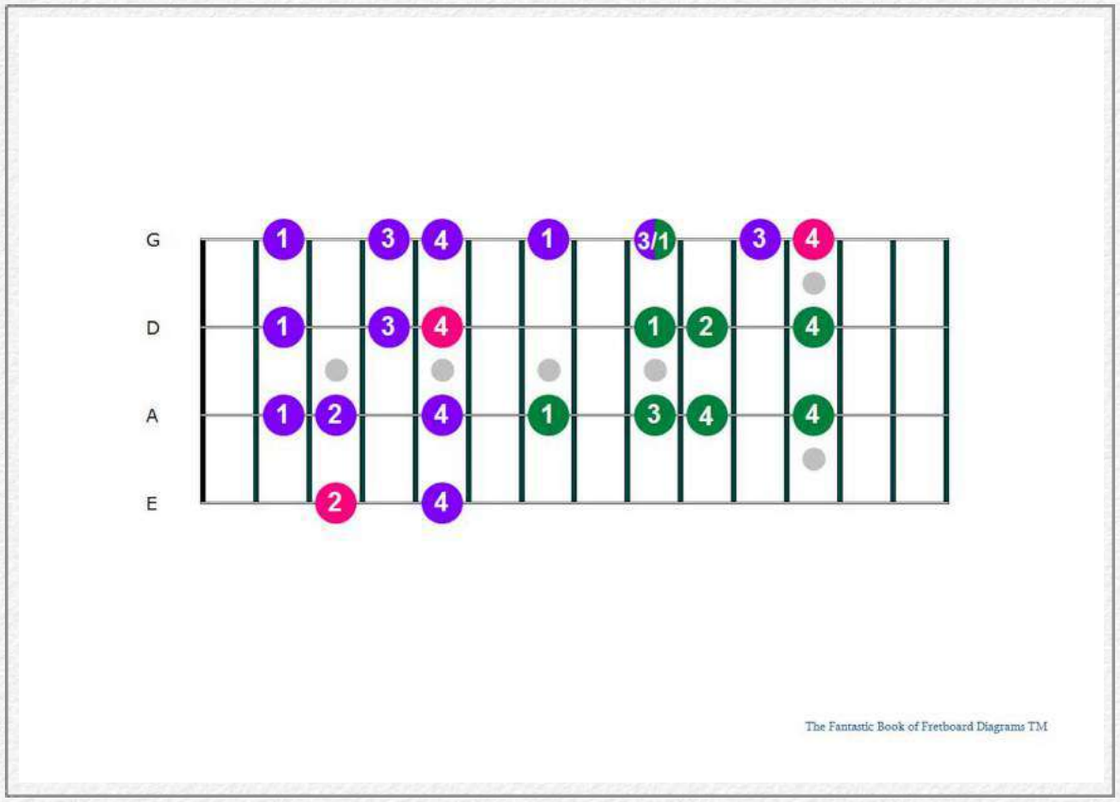
The Minor Scale

Two Octaves



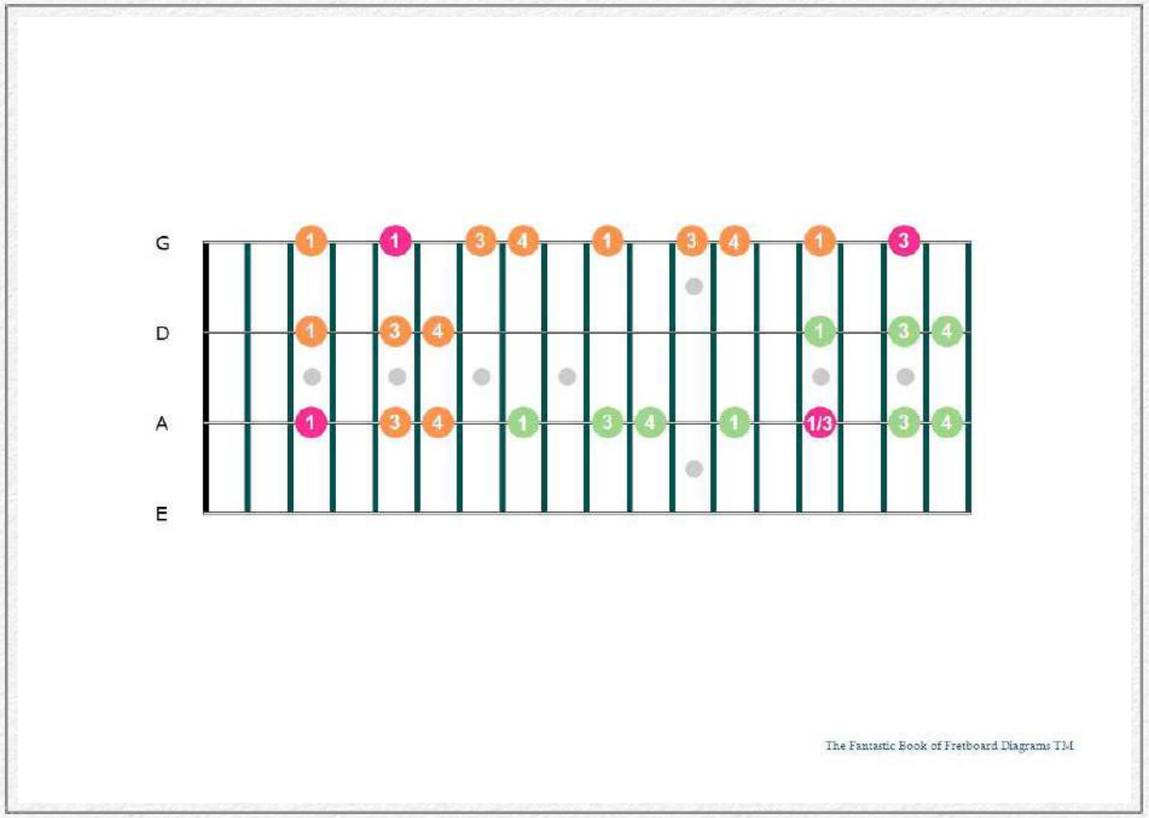
Notice the one octave minor shapes contained within this two octave scale.

The Major Scale - Options



This diagram shows one option for combining familiar shapes of one octave and linear major scales with the two octave version. The scale can be played by descending (or ascending) on the green notes. In this way, going up the scale can be played differently than coming down, providing new options.

The Minor Scale - Options



Here is the minor scale again. This diagram shows one option for combining familiar shapes of one octave and linear minor scales with the two octave version. The scale can be played by descending (or ascending) on the green notes.

Major Scale - A stepwise arrangement of the seven notes of a major key including five whole steps and two half-steps. The half-steps occur between notes 3 and 4 and again between 7 and 8.

Minor Scale - A stepwise arrangement of the seven notes of a minor key including five whole steps and two half-steps. The half-steps in minor occur between notes 2 and 3 and again between 5 and 6.

Diatonic Scale - A stepwise arrangement of the seven notes of a major or minor key. The major scale and the minor scale are both diatonic scales.

LEARN TO APPLY these scales in musical setting like playing with a band, writing, recording, and improvising with my **RIFF TRAINER FOR BASS GUITAR.**

The new way to learn to play and create riffs -- enroll my Professional Bass Masterclass to access now. Here is a discount code for you.

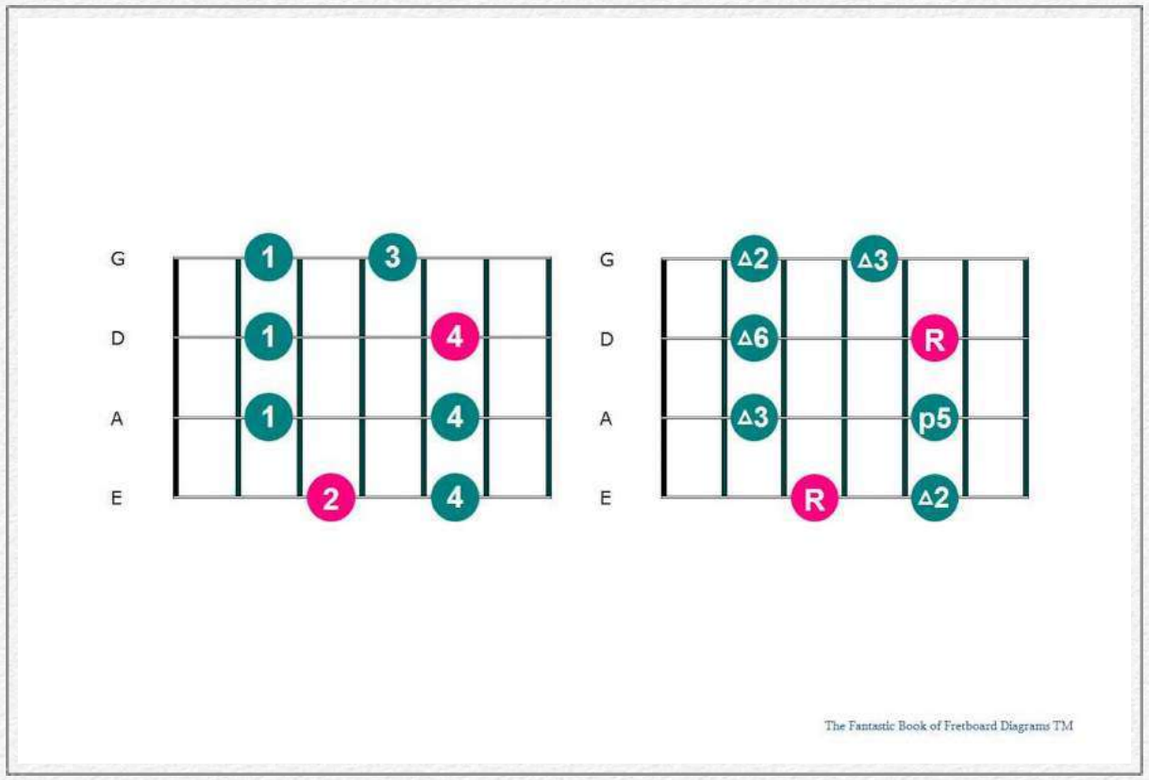
The Professional Bass Masterclass - Riff Trainer for Bass Included!

Pentatonics

4

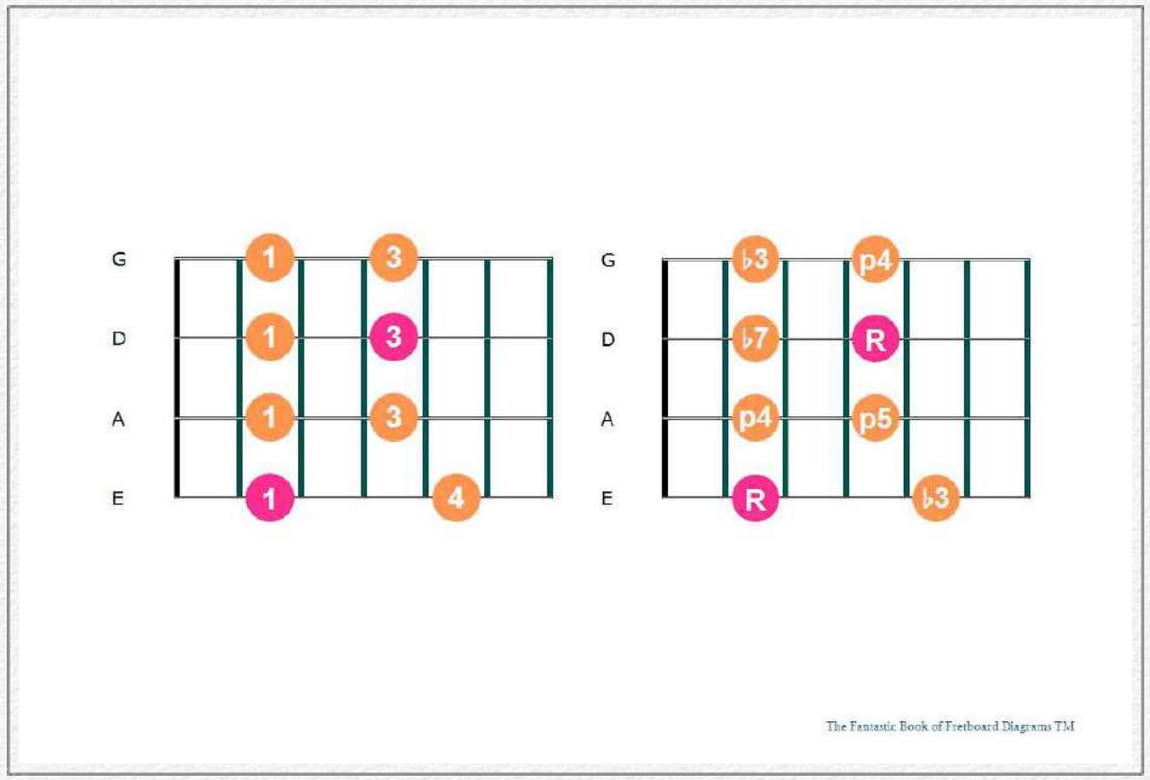
Pentatonic scales are five note scales. They are usually built without semitones. They are found in different musical forms around the world.

Pentatonic Major



The major pentatonic scale pictured above with the root highlighted. This scale is a mobile form and can be played anywhere on the neck. The root placement designates the scale. Place one of the roots over an A and you have an A pentatonic major. Place one of the roots over a B and you have a B pentatonic major scale.

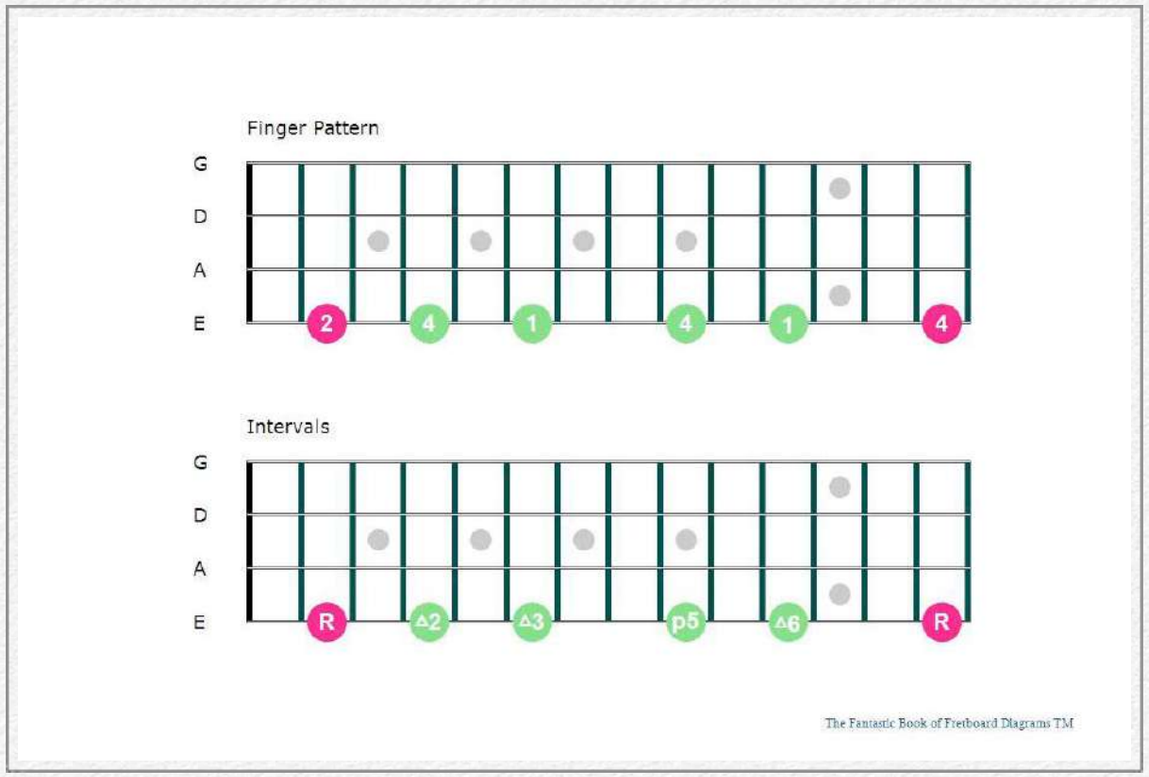
Pentatonic Minor



F# minor pentatonic is pictured above as this mobile scale has its root on F#.

Pentatonic Major

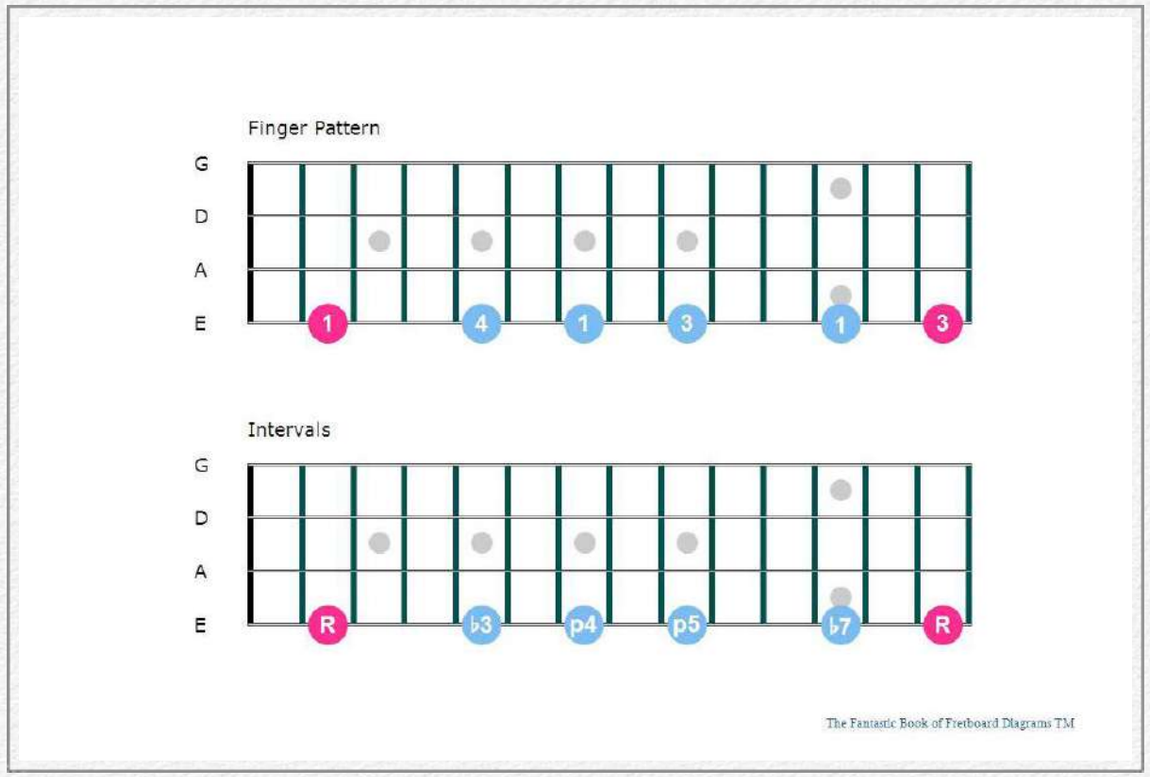
Linear



The linear forms show us how to easily change positions and open up the fretboard.

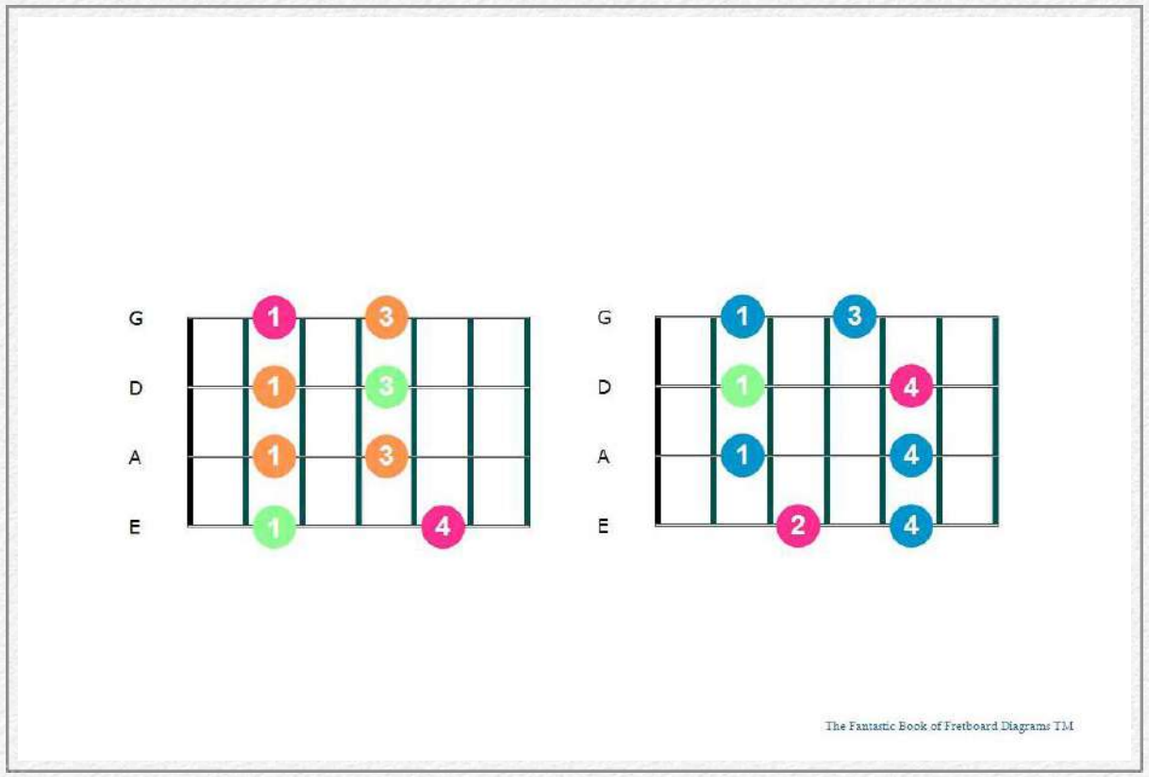
Pentatonic Minor

Linear



Major and Minor Pentatonic

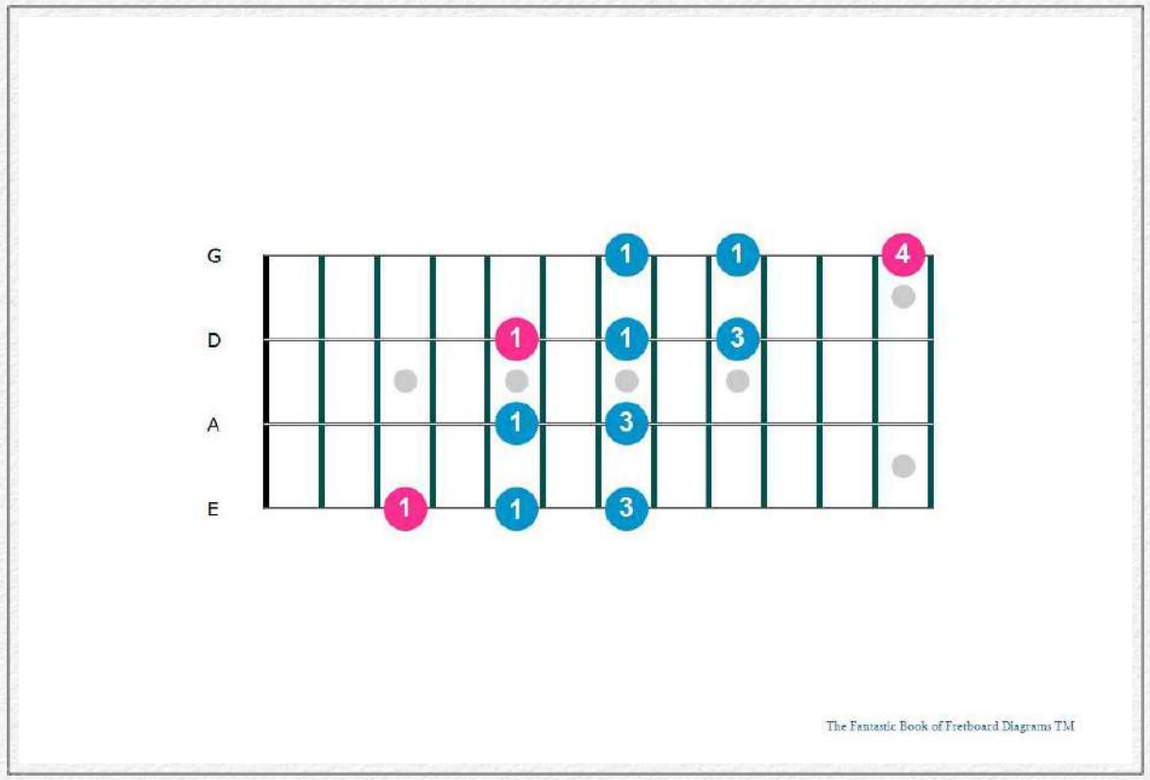
Together



Here we can see how the two scale shapes fit together. The 4th finger of the minor pentatonic plays the root of the major pentatonic. The two shapes fit together so that the high notes of the pent minor are the low notes of the pent major. Whether you are in the major or the minor depends on the notes you focus on as "home." The minor root is in green. The major root is in red.

Pentatonic Major

Two Octaves

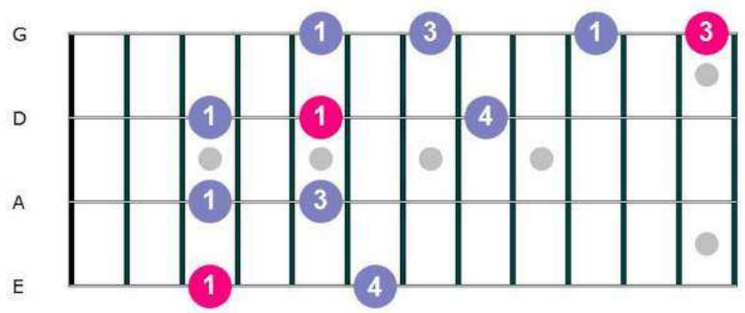


The shifts here occur on the first finger. Once this is comfortable learn to shift with the third finger ascending and descending to maximize the versatility of this scale. Let is serve how you want the bass line to sound.

This scale lends itself to sliding between notes and fits with major chords.

Pentatonic Minor

Two Octaves



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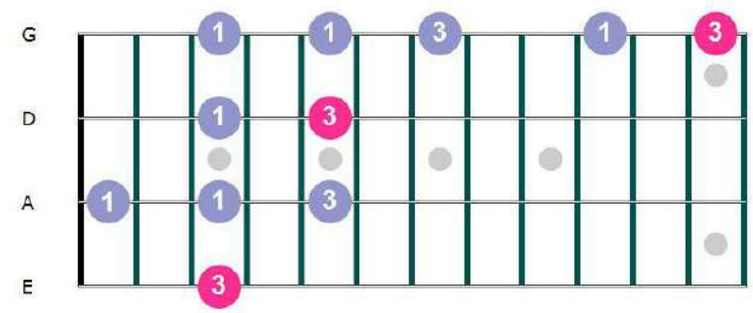
Pentatonic Minor

Two Octaves - Option 2



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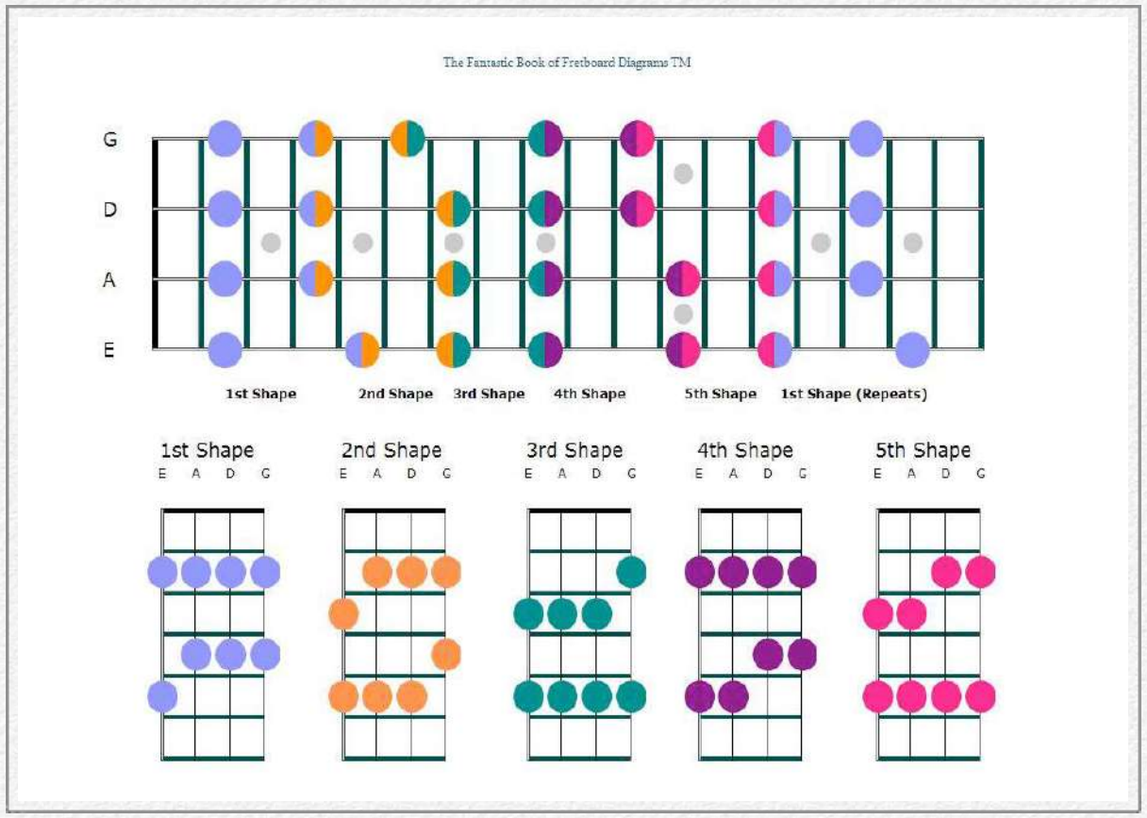
Pentatonics

The Five Shapes



Here we see how all five pentatonic scale shapes fit together. This knowledge can be used to fulfill functions over major or minor chords or keys. In the diagram at the top of the page, the pentatonic major scale has A as its root. This complete group of shapes can therefore be used with A Major. The pentatonic minor scale has F# as its root, so this complete group of shapes could also be used with F# minor.

Here is a helpful optional article for you:

Four Ways to Make Yourself Indispensable as a Bassist

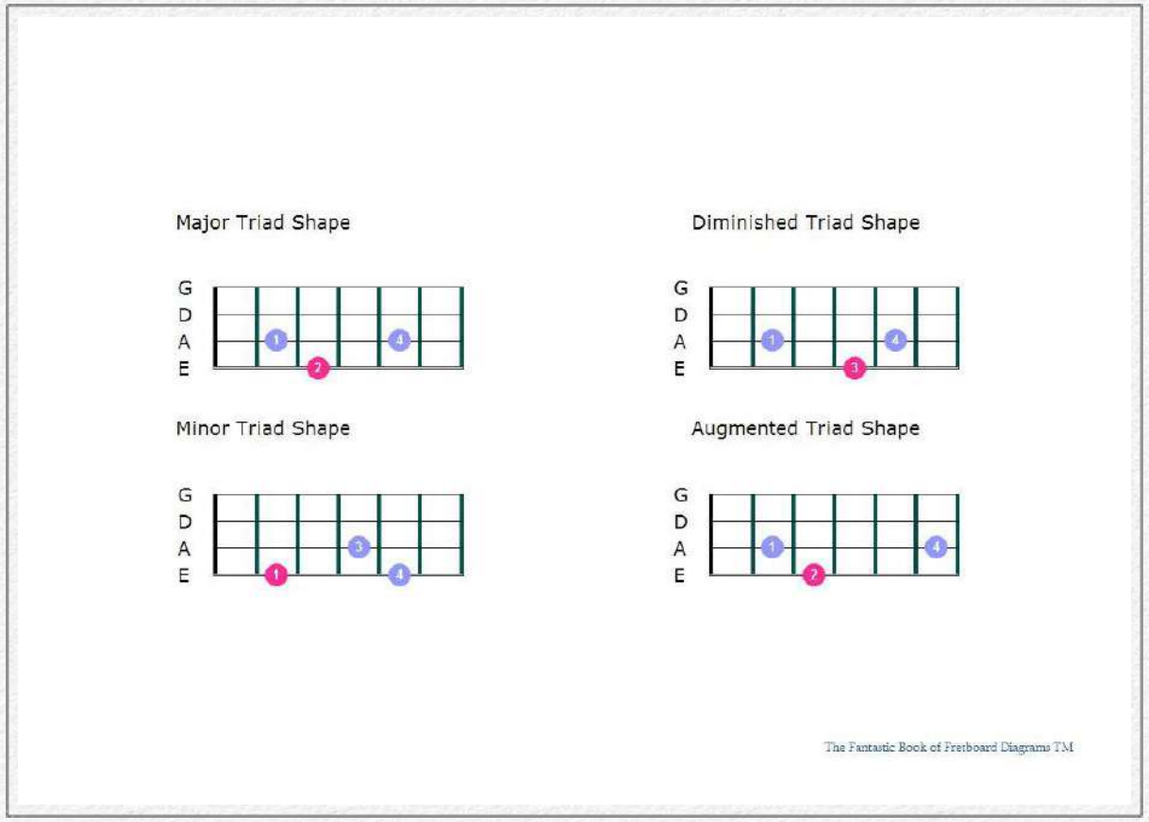
Triads

5

The triad is the fundamental building block in music. It is an expression of the natural laws in music.

The Triads

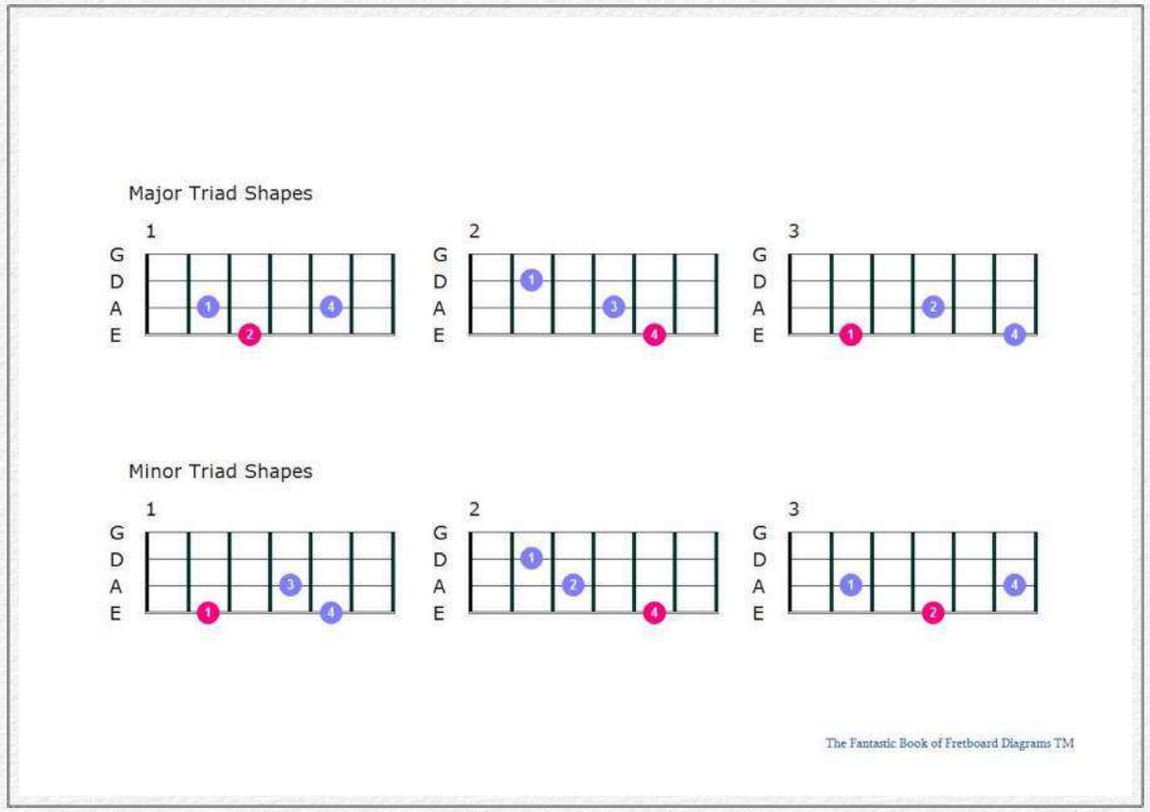
Four Types



These triad shapes can be played anywhere on the fretboard. The roots are in red.

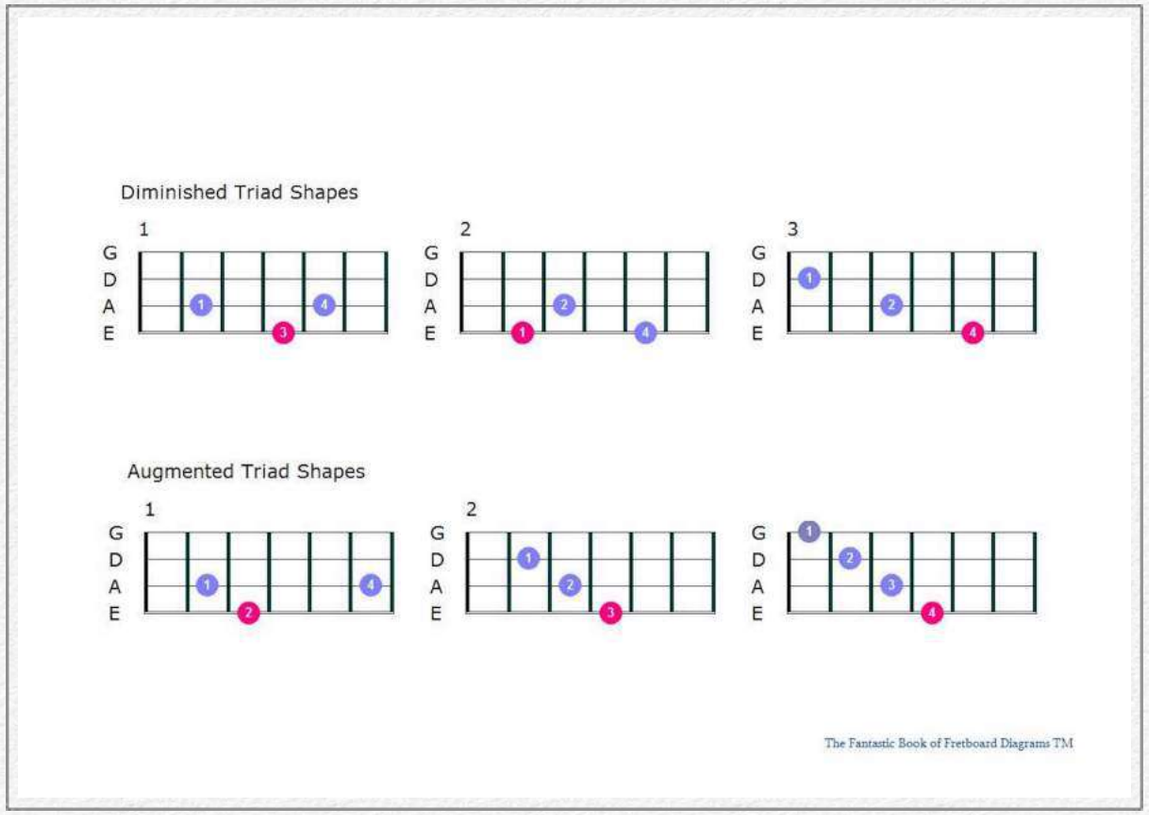
Triads

Versions - The Major and the Minor



Triads

Versions - The Diminished and the Augmented



Don't be left in the dark any longer! Learn to recognize <u>every triad type instantly</u> by ear with:

<u>The Elements of Music | Music Theory and Foundations.</u>

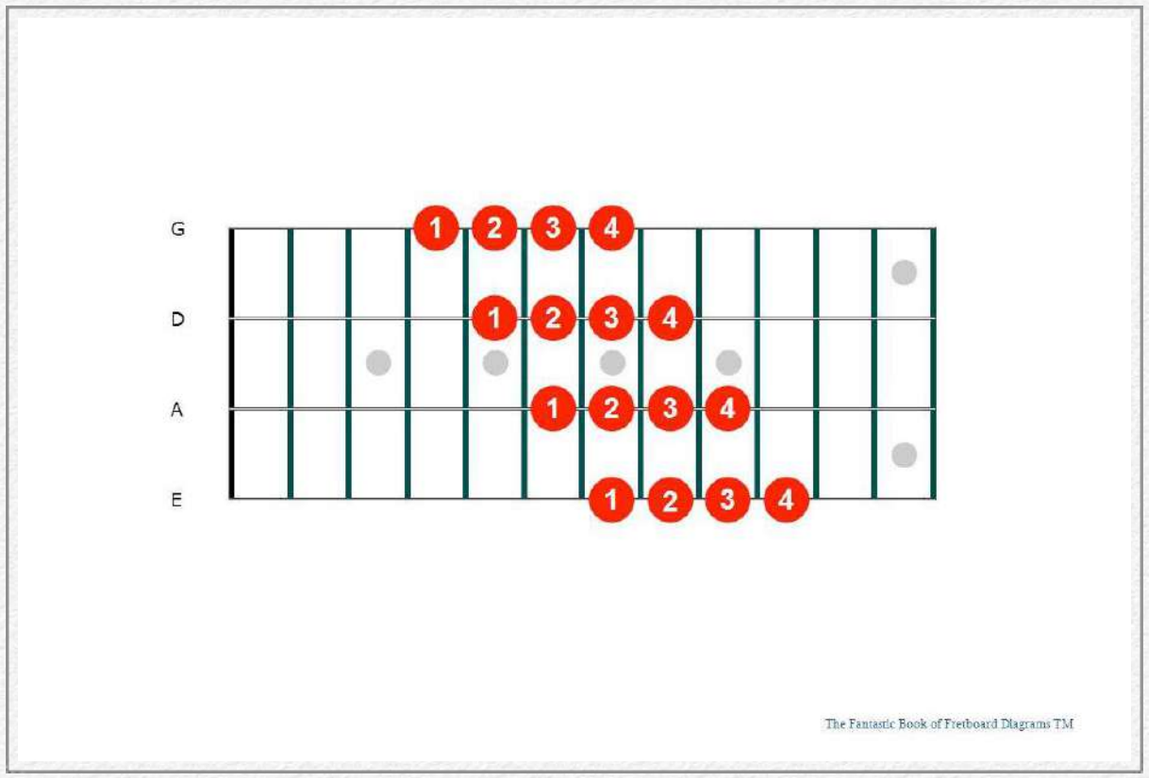
Chromatics

6

Chromatic movement is movement by a series of consecutive semitones.

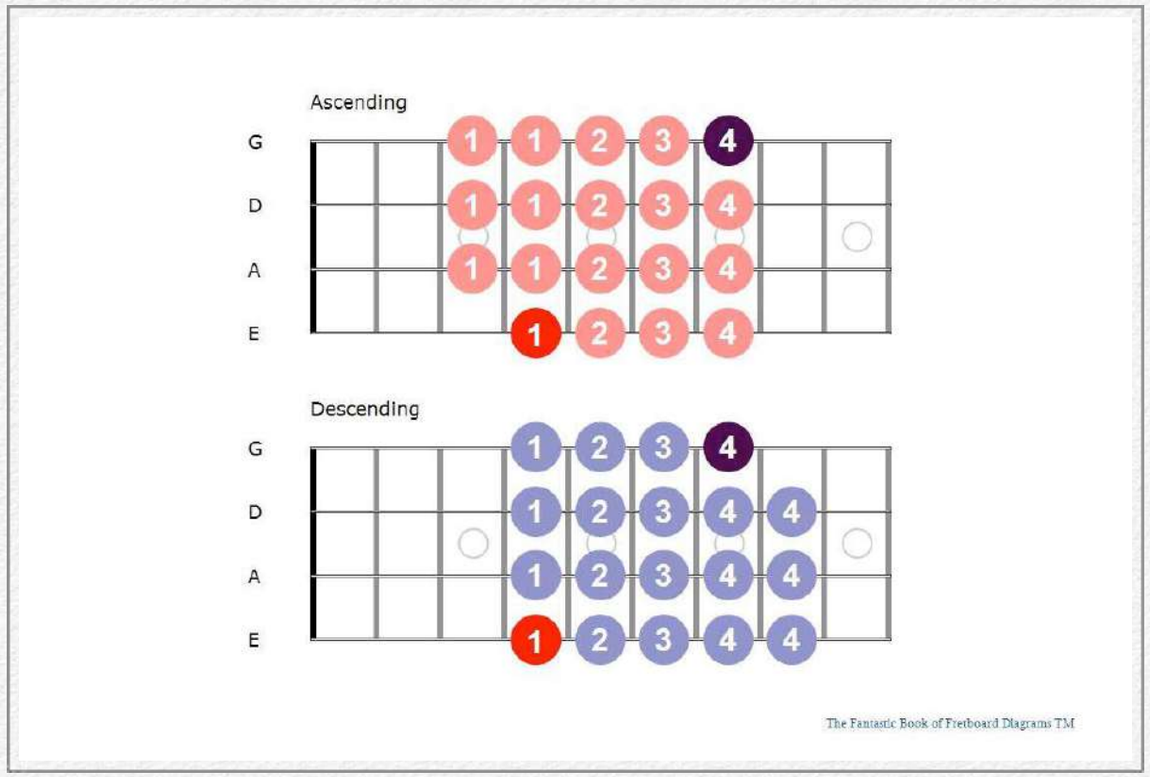
The Chromatic Scale

Standard



The Chromatic Scale

Modified

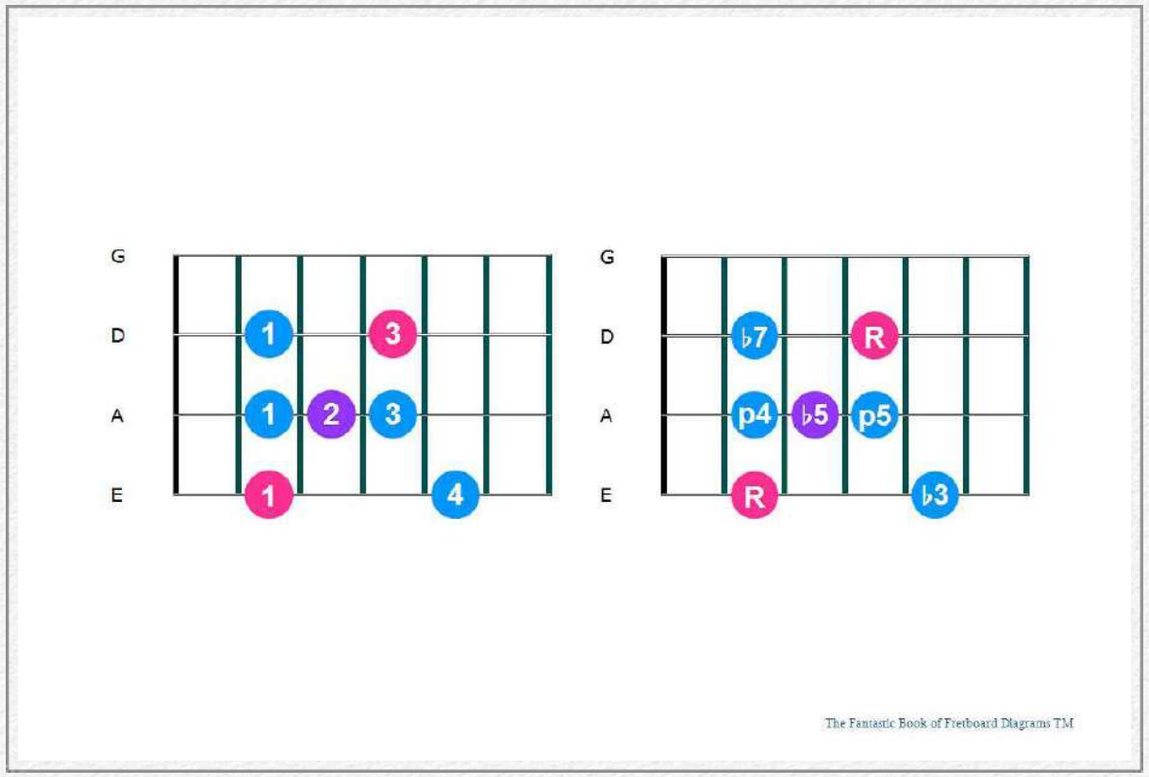


The Blues Scale

The blues scale is a hexatonic or six-note scale. It is built with the pentatonic minor scale plus a tritone.

The Blues Scale

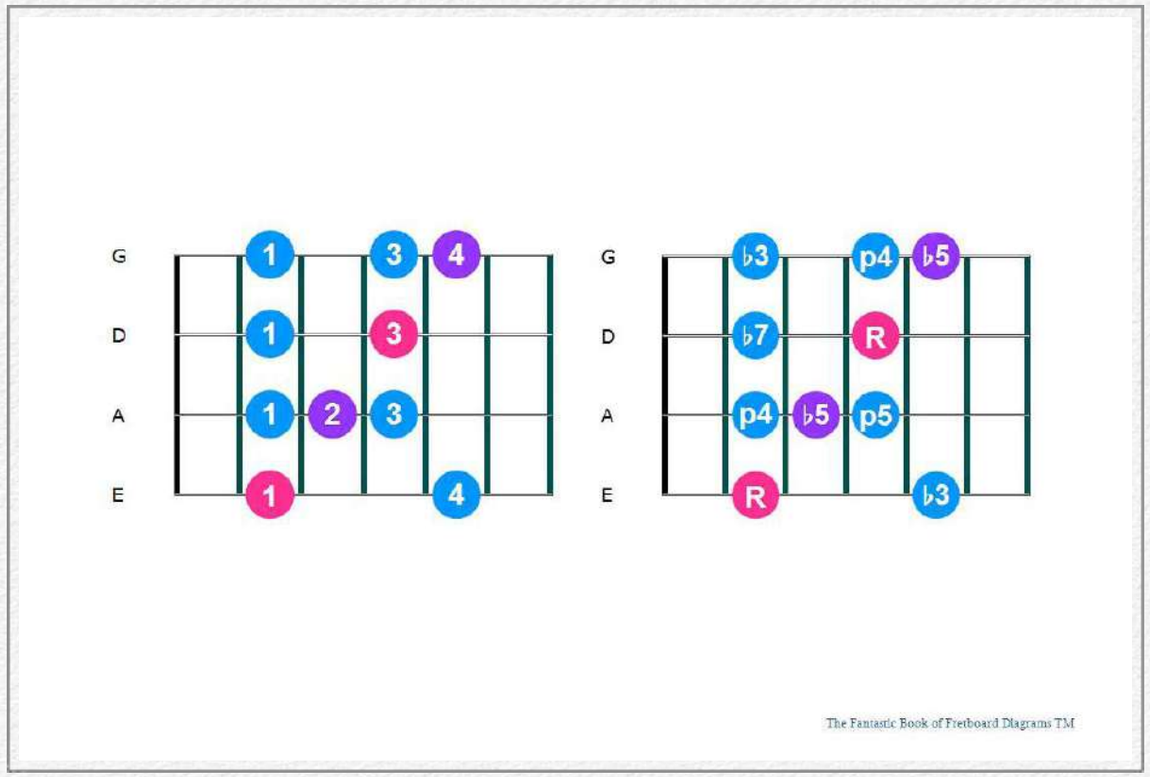
One Octave



This is one octave of the blues scale. Notice that this scale is the minor pentatonic scale with the addition of a tritone (a flatted 5th).

The Blues Scale

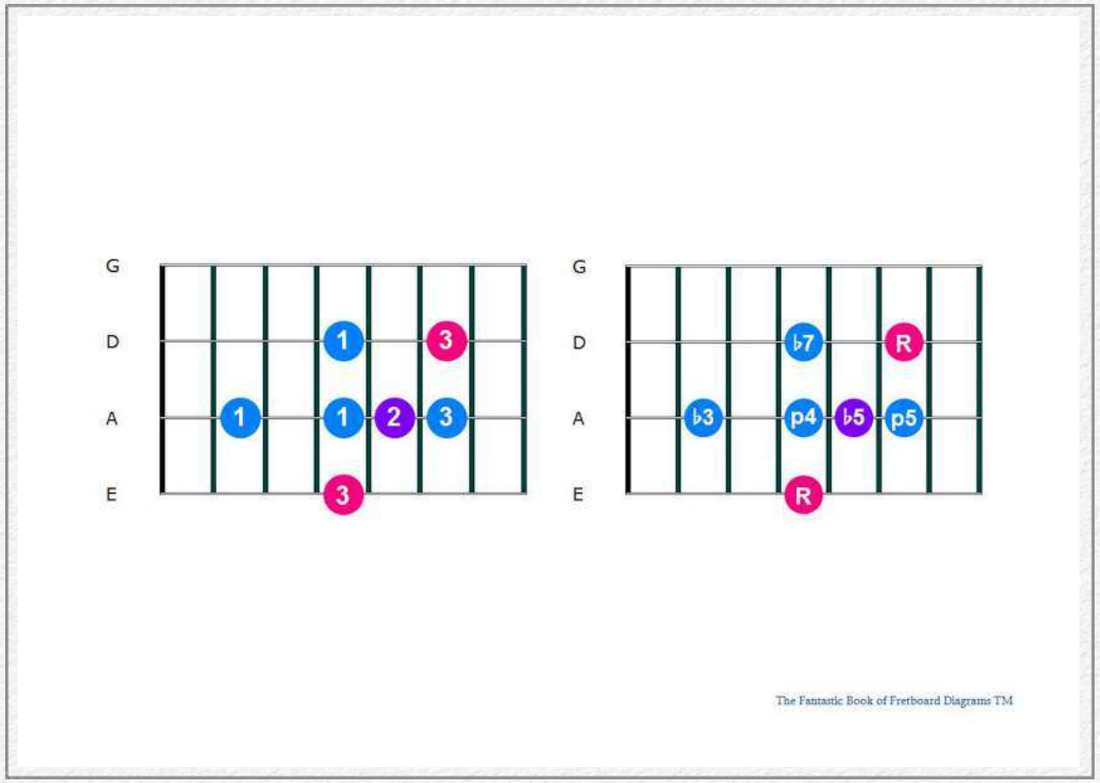
Expanded



This is the blues scale expanded to include all notes available in a given position.

The Blues Scale

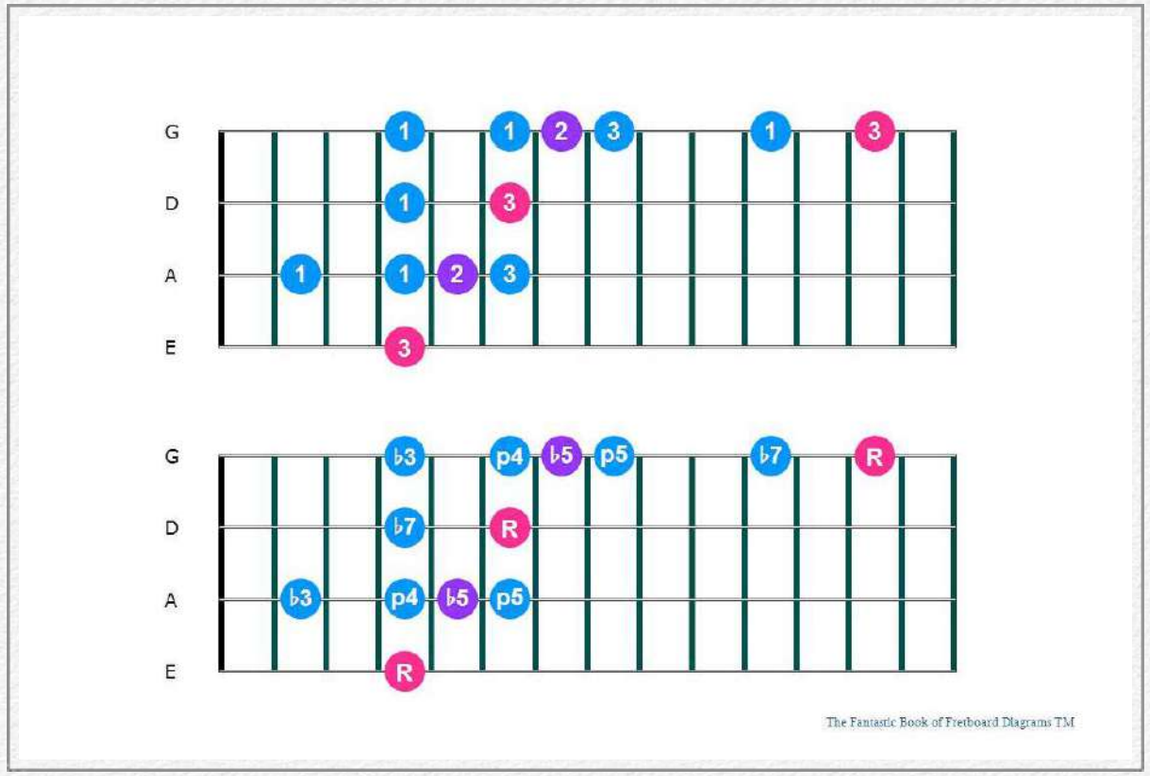
One Octave Alternative



Here is a common alternative finger placement for the blues scale.

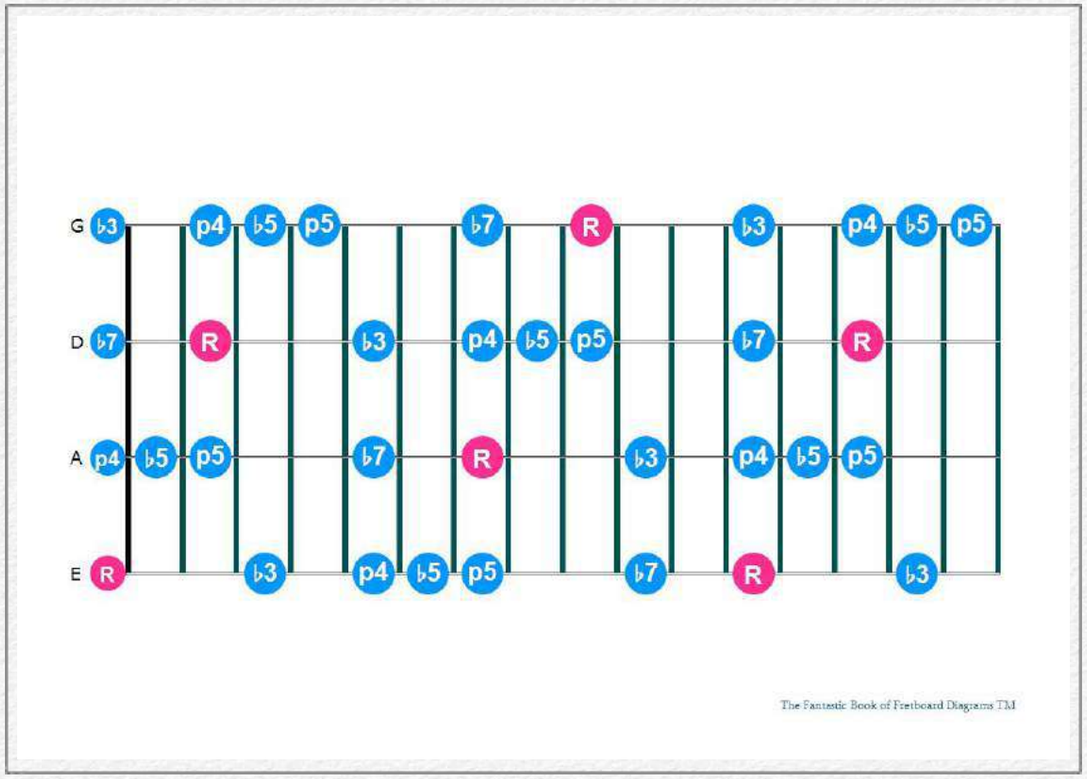
The Blues Scale

Two Octave Alternative



The E Blues Scale

Complete



This is the E blues scale as it occurs across the fretboard. The five pentatonic shapes are here with the tritone added. Learning this complete scale is very useful as the entire shape can be transposed to another key by simply shifting to a new position (moving the roots).

Learn to **apply** these scales with **Riff Trainer for Bass**, a part of The Professional Bass Masterclass. Enroll now. Apply what you're learning. Set it deep!

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Test your time now with my Ten Time Signatures Practice Module.

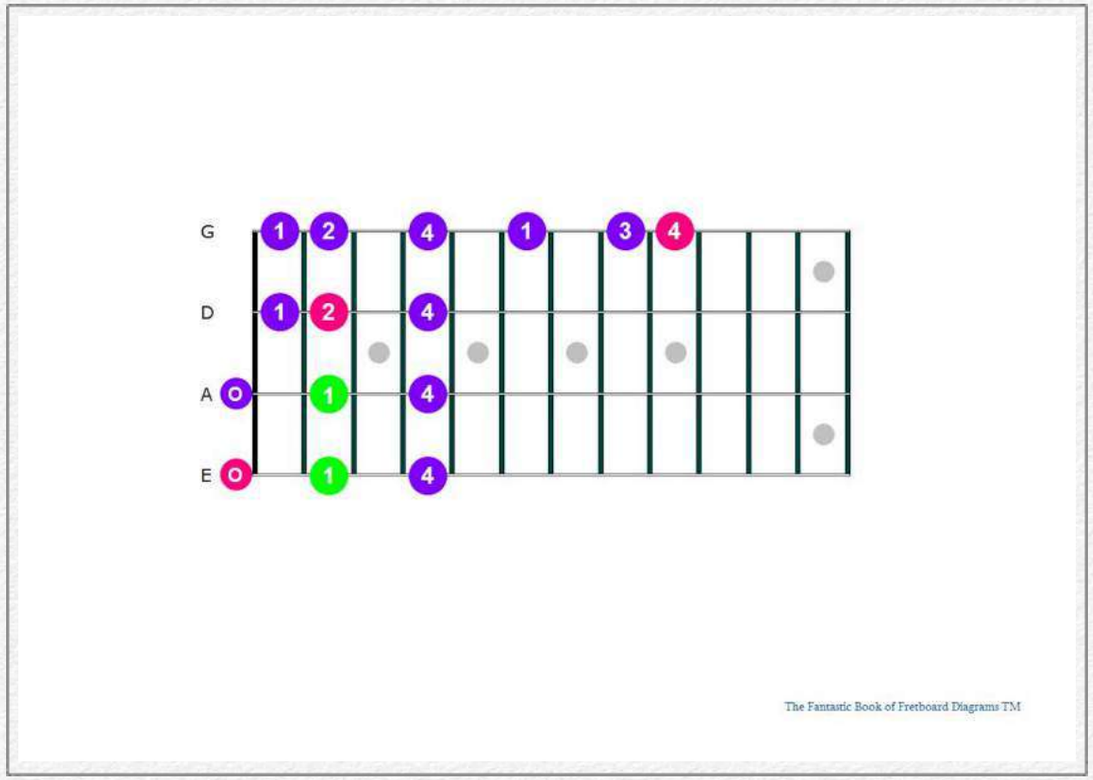
Scales with Open Strings

8

Learning scales with open strings increases fretboard knowledge. Using open strings increases ease of play and provides a rich tone.

E Major Scale

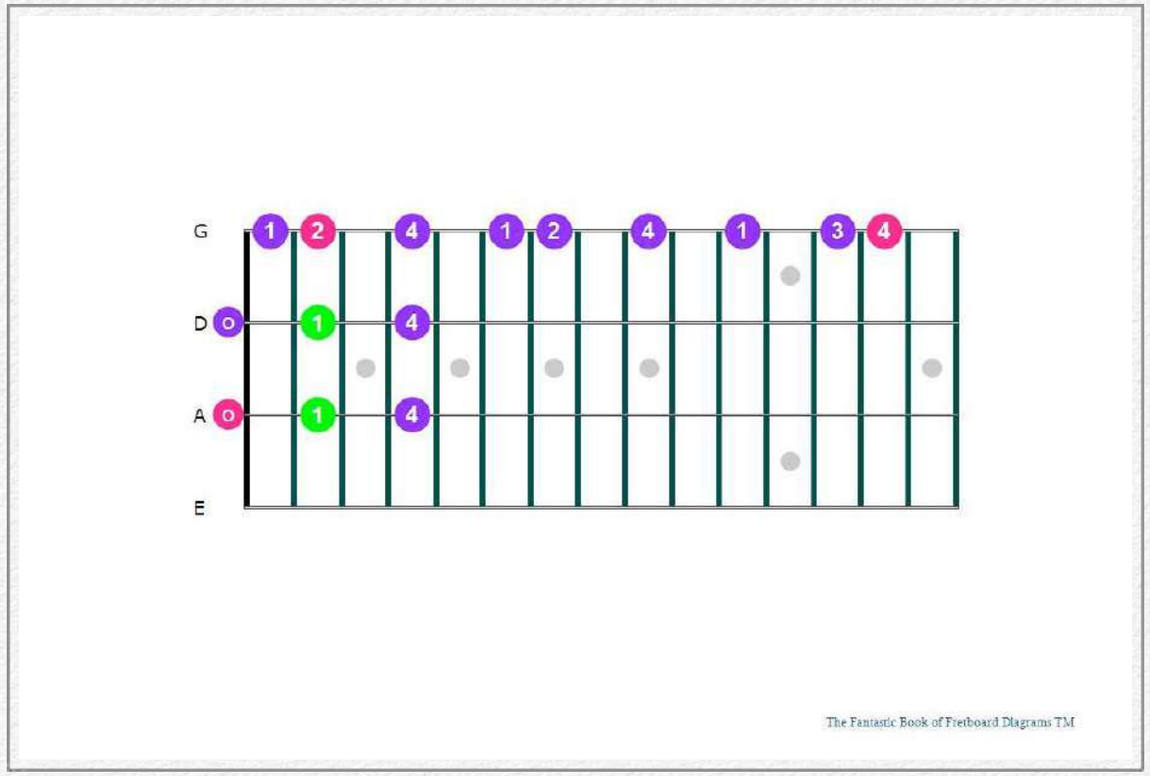
with Open Strings



Note the alternate finger placement as the 1st finger is used instead of the second (green). this allows for ease of play in the lower register. You can use the second finger here if you wish, or if it suits the passage better.

A Major Scale

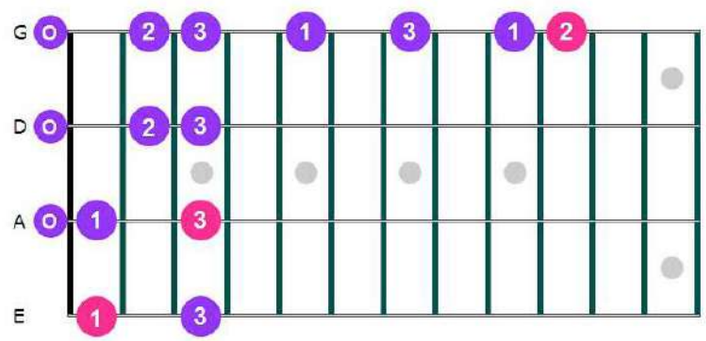
with Open Strings



Here again there is the option of using the first finger (green) for lower register notes.

F Major Scale

with Open Strings



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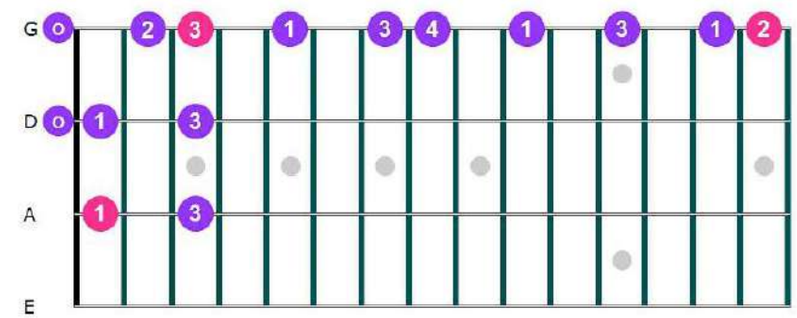
B Flat Major Scale

with Open Strings



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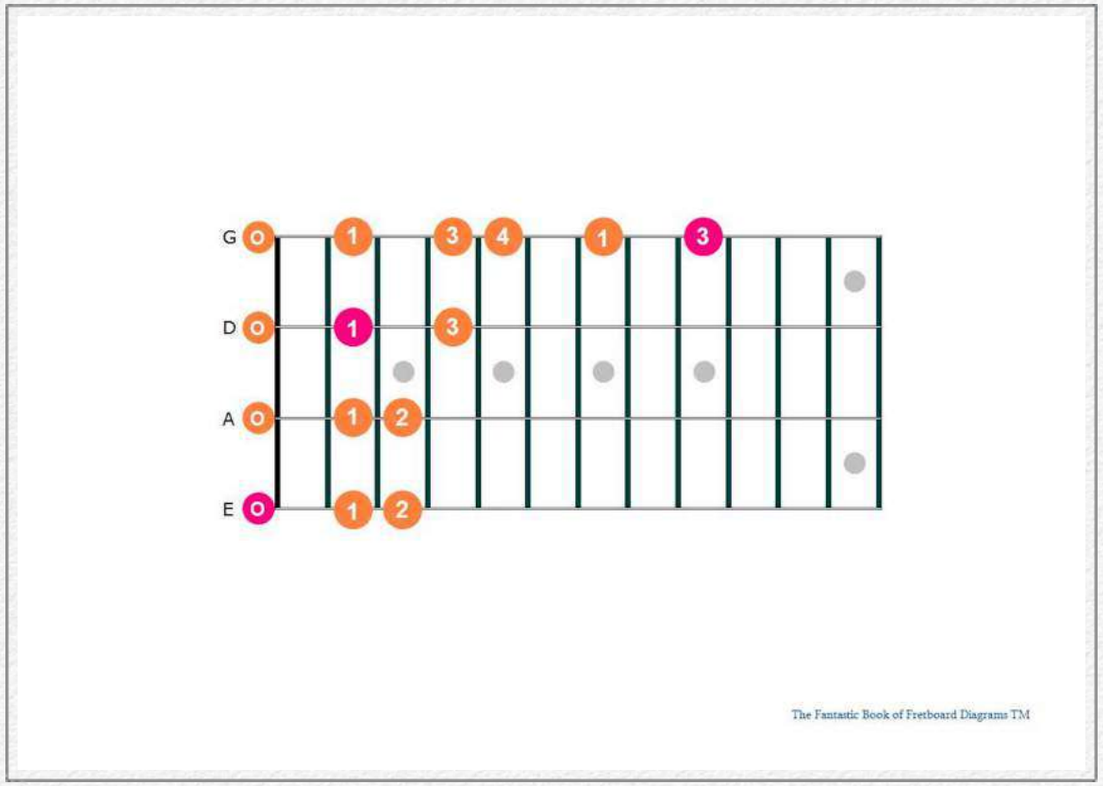
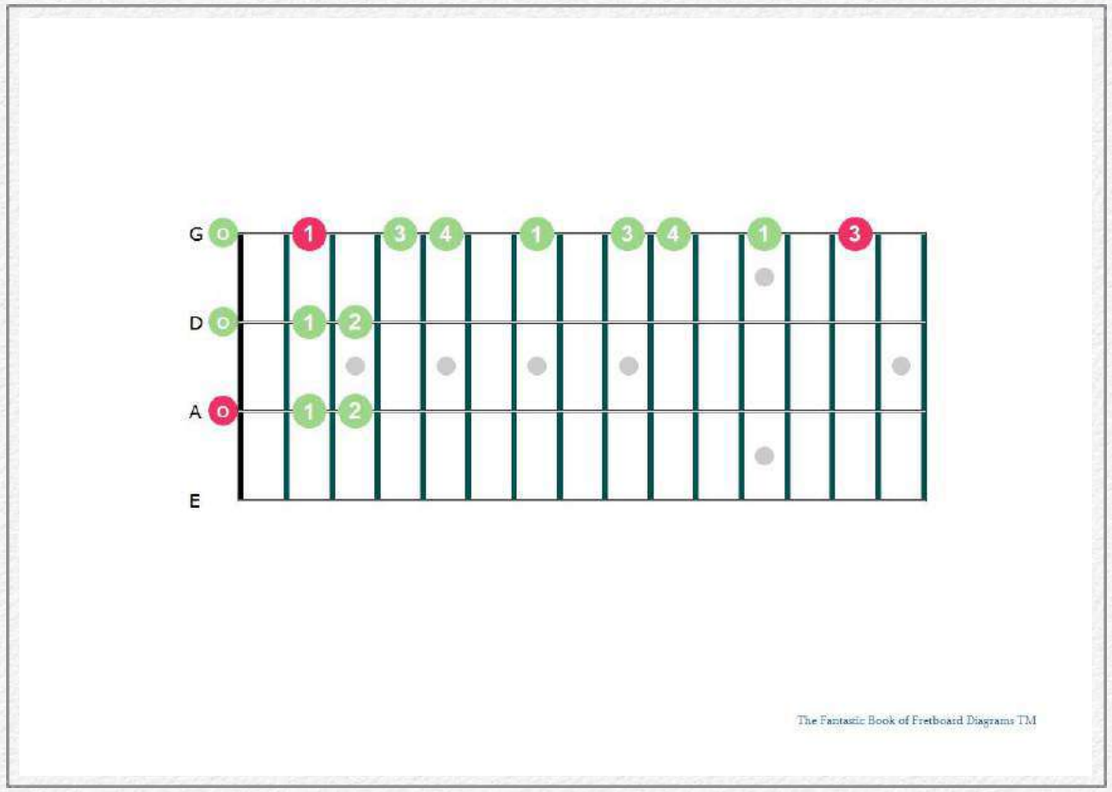
E Minor

with Open Strings



A Minor

with Open Strings



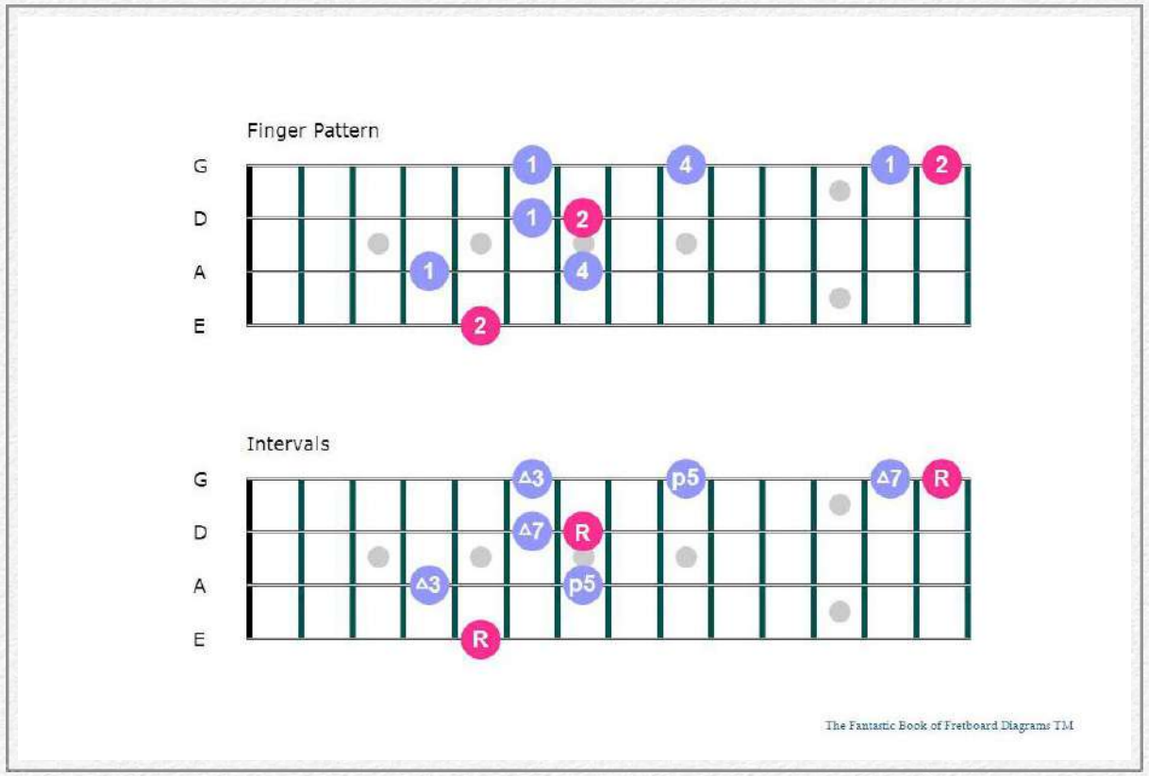
Arpeggios - 7th Chords

9

An arpeggio is the playing of a chord one note at a time rather than all at once. In an arpeggio, each interval of the chord is sounded independently.

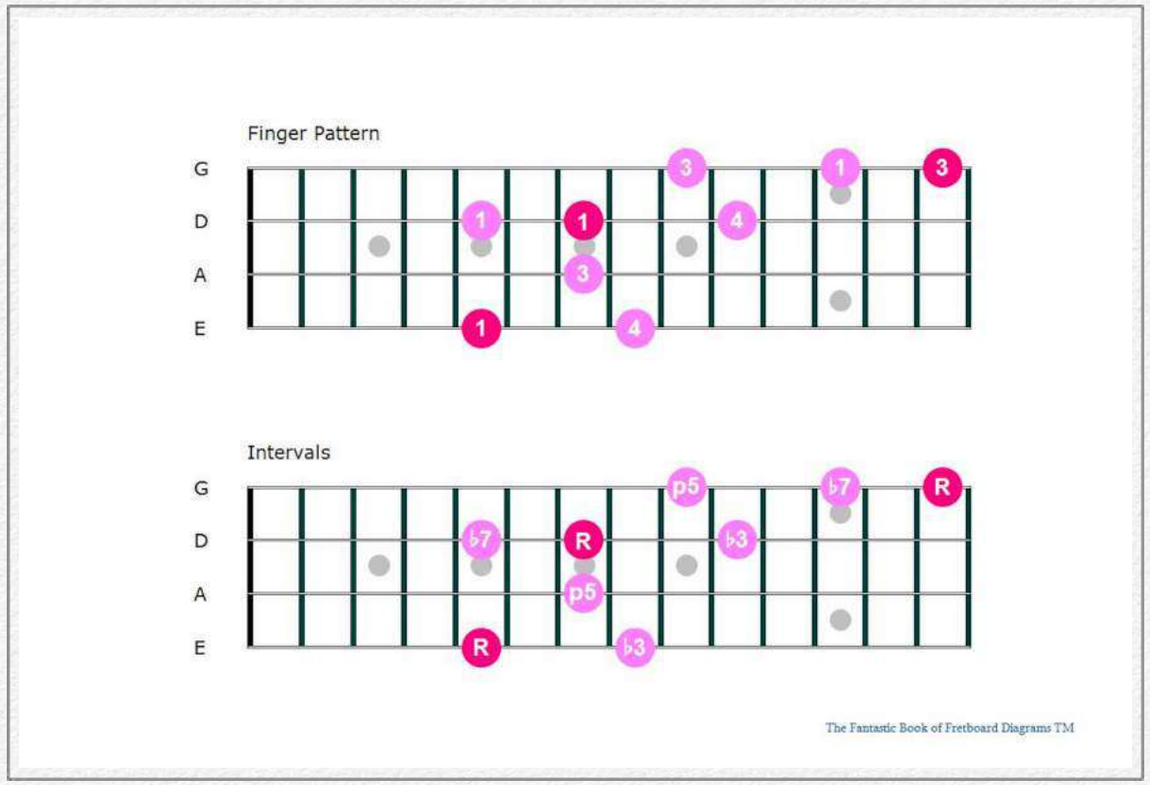
Major 7th Arpeggio

7th Chords



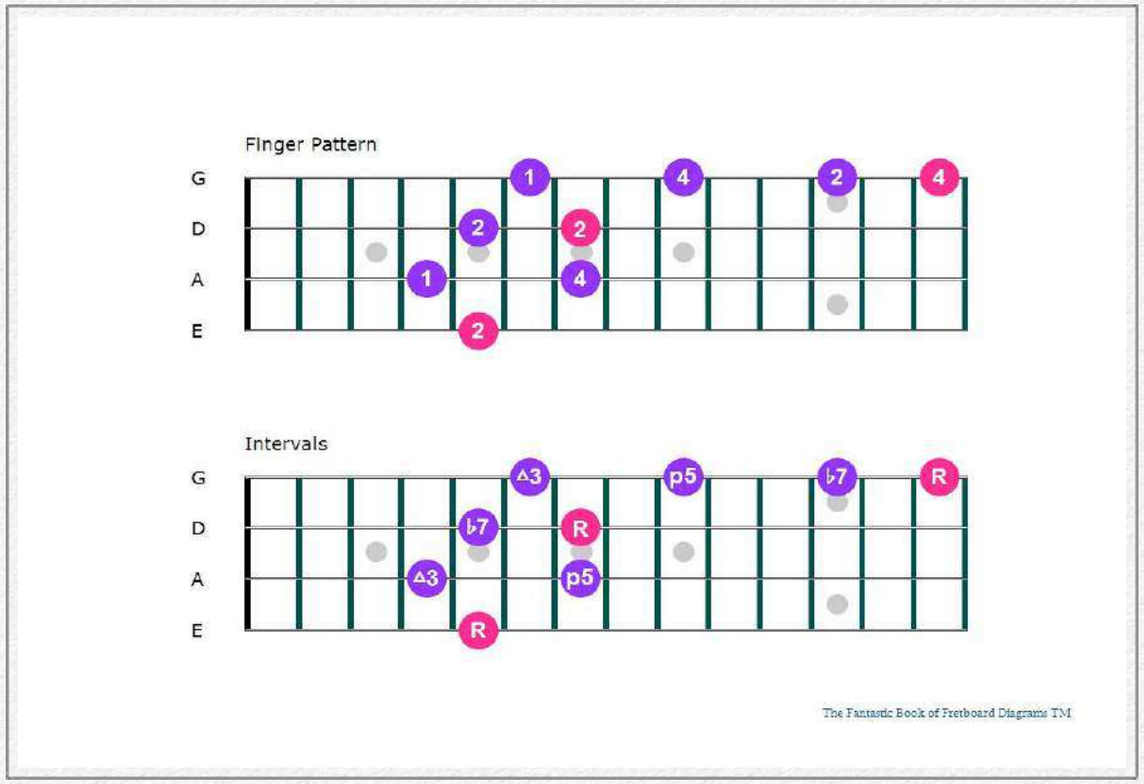
Minor 7th Arpeggio

7th Chords



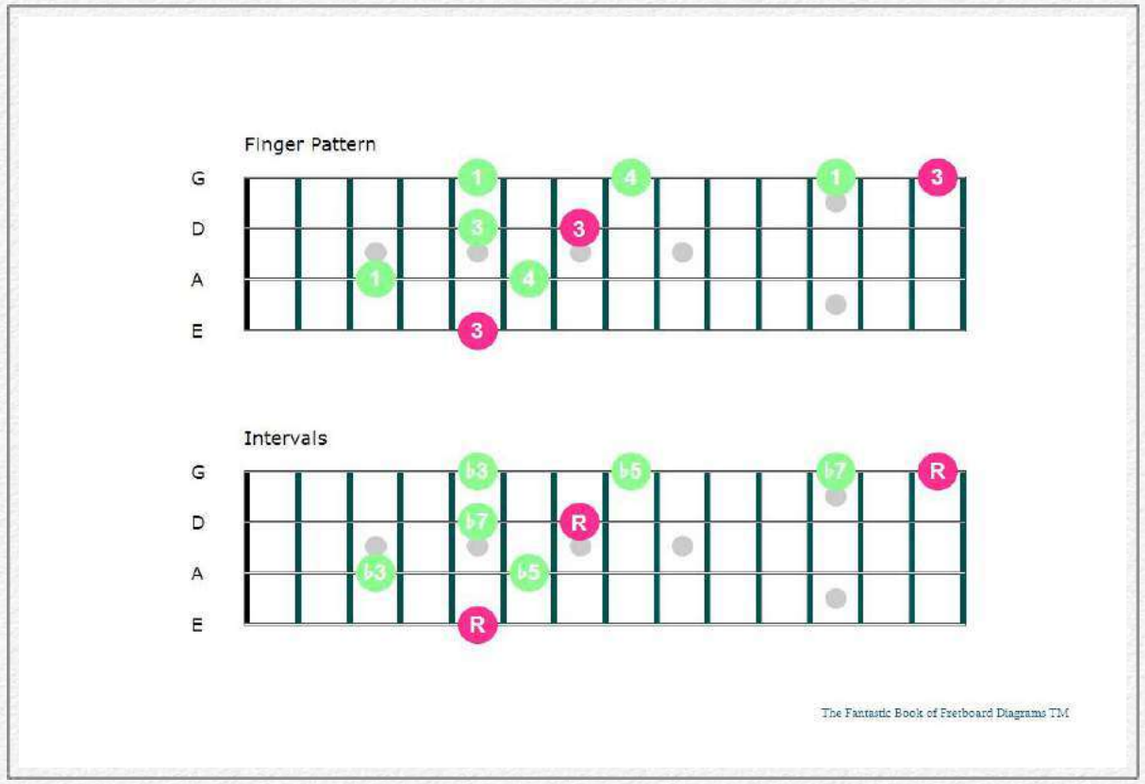
Dominant 7th Arpeggio

7th Chords



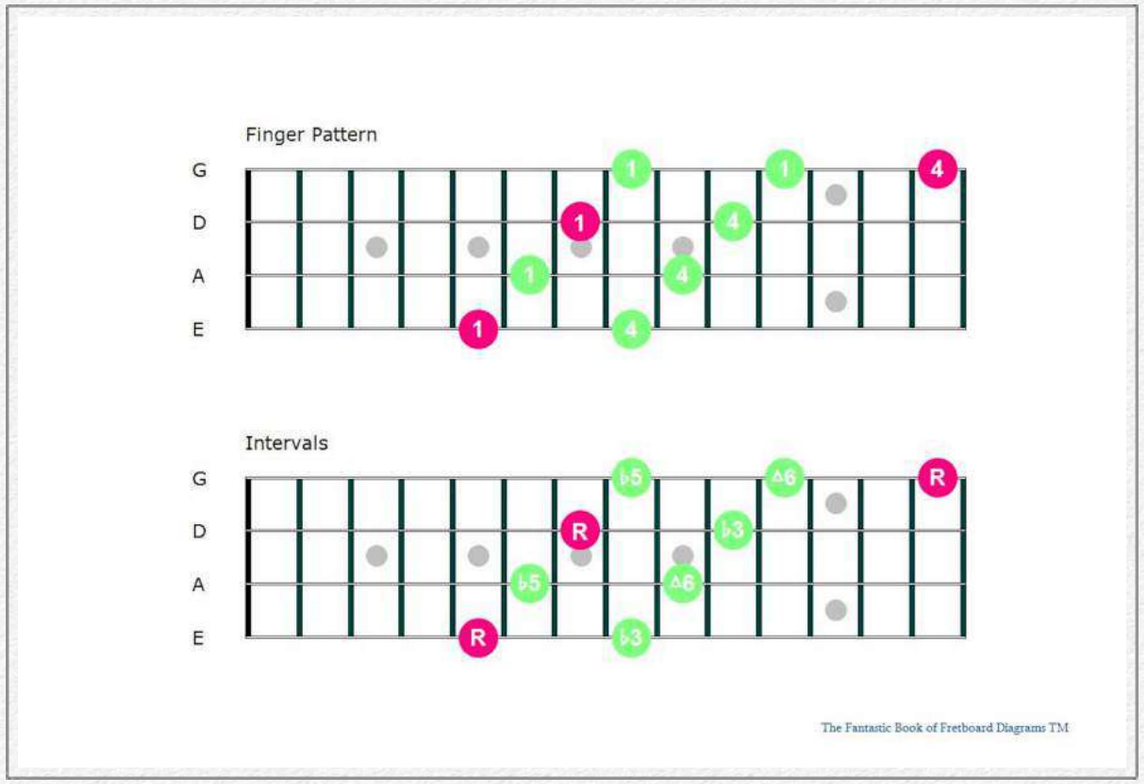
Minor 7 Flat 5 Arpeggio

7th Chords



Diminished 7th Arpeggio

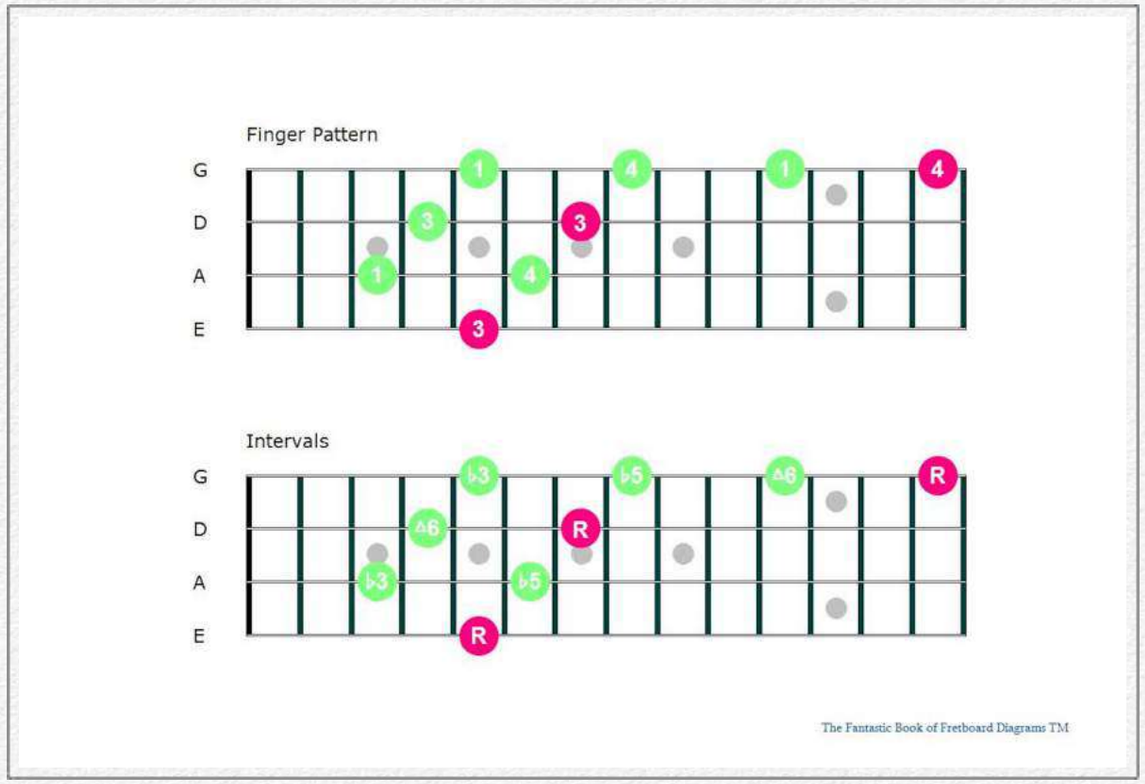
Option 1



Notice the diagonal shapes found in the diminished arpeggio. They are readily available notes when playing under diminished chords.

Diminished 7th Arpeggio

Option 2



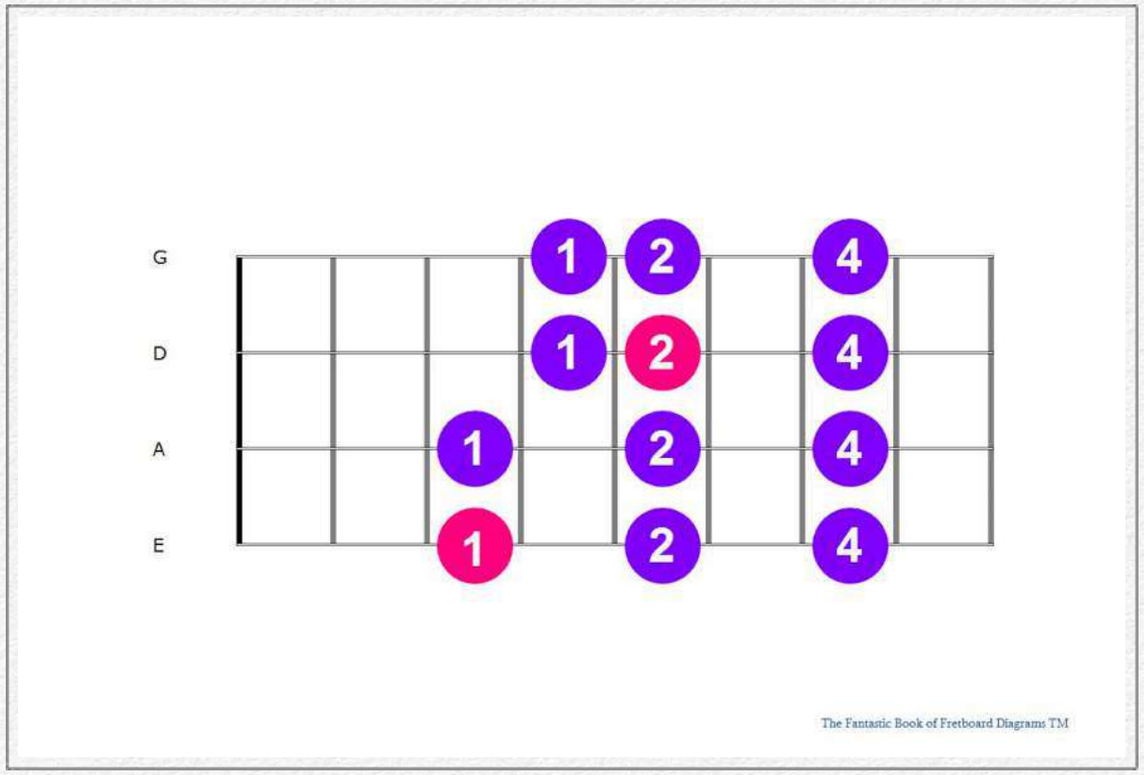
The Modes

10

Each of the seven modes has its root on one of the seven notes of the major scale. By playing the notes of the major scale with a new tonal centre, new melodic characteristics take shape.

Ionian

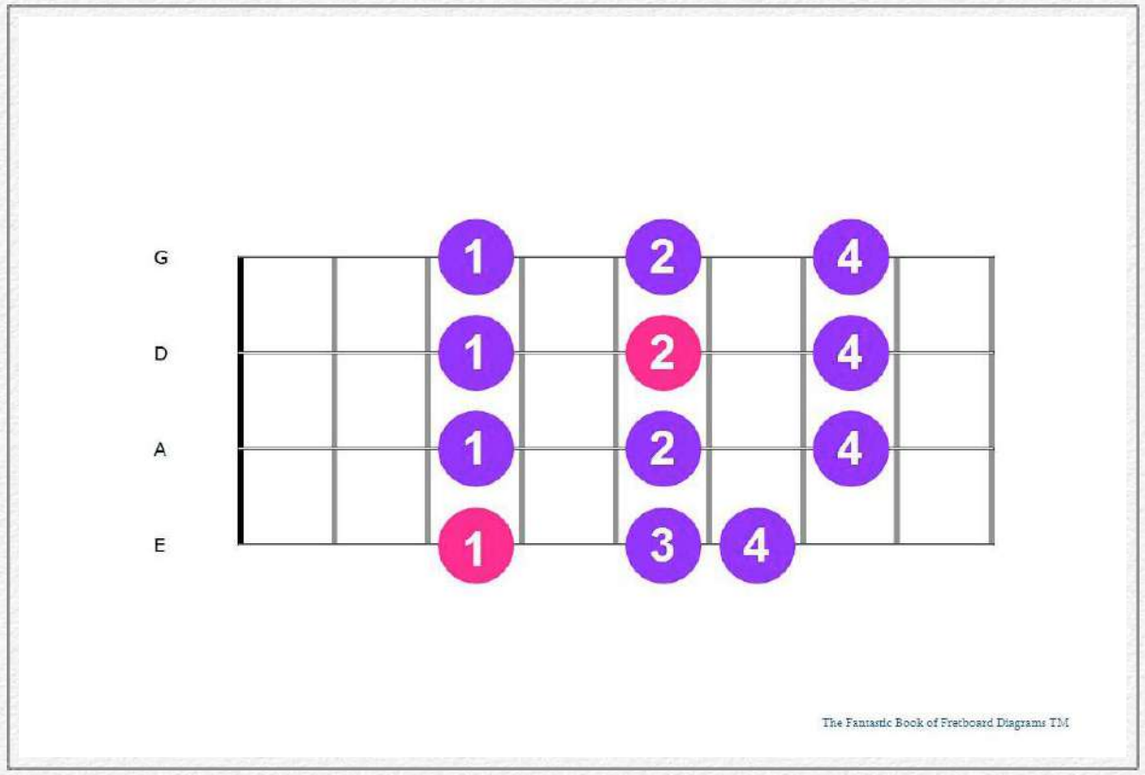
Modes



The Ionian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "one" or first note of the major scale. It is another name for and way to look at the major scale. It fits with I or I^7 in major keys and under III or III^7 in minor keys.

Dorian

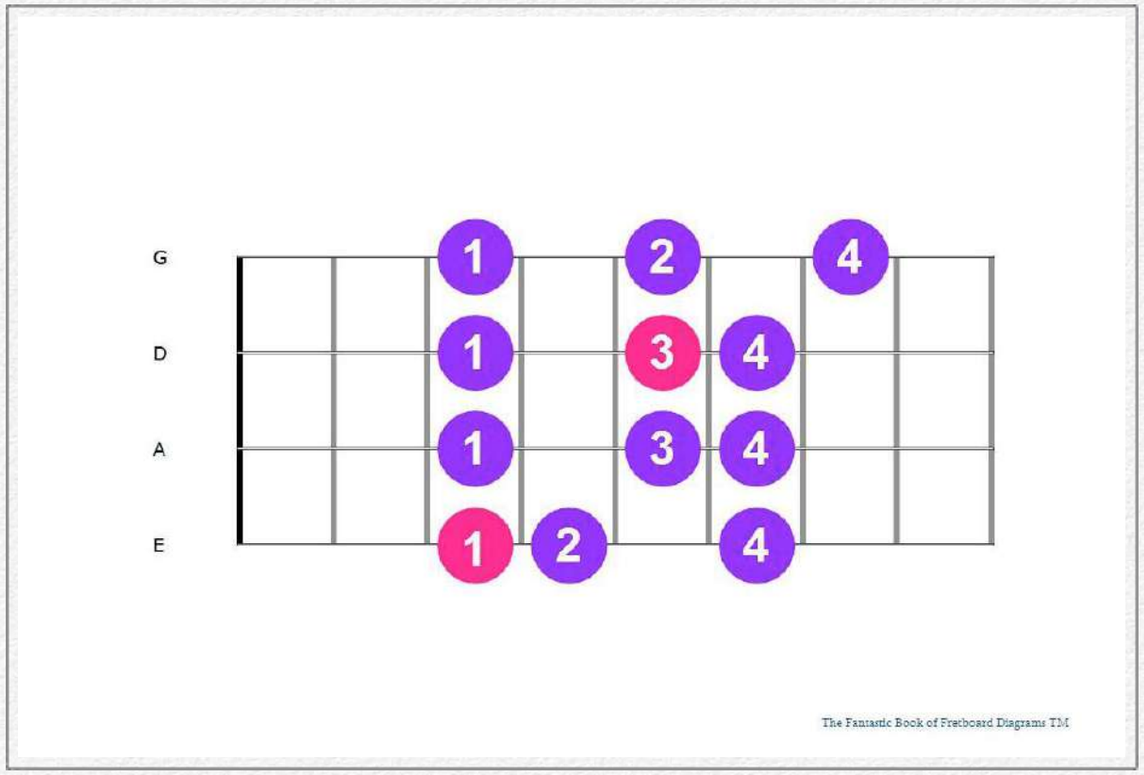
Modes



The Dorian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "two" or second note of the major scale. It fits with ii or ii^7 in major keys or iv or iv^7 in minor keys.

Phrygian

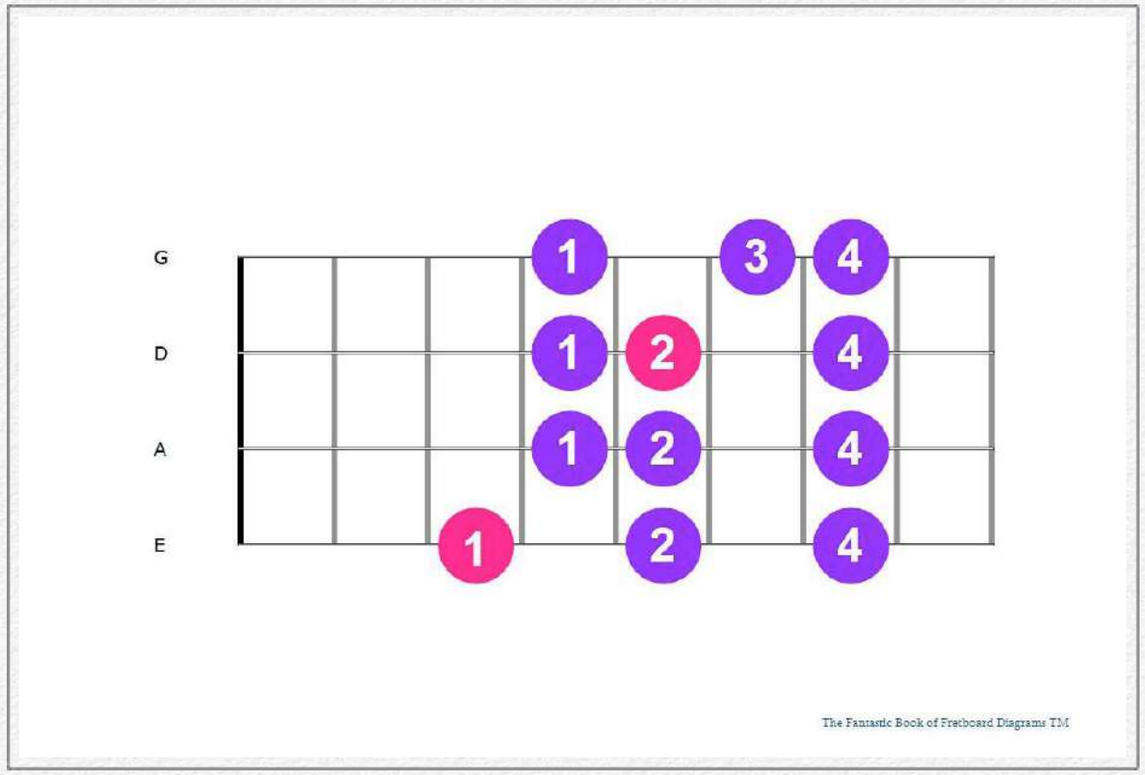
Modes



The Phrygian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "three" or third note of the major scale. It fits with iii or iii^7 in major keys and v or v^7 in minor keys.

Lydian

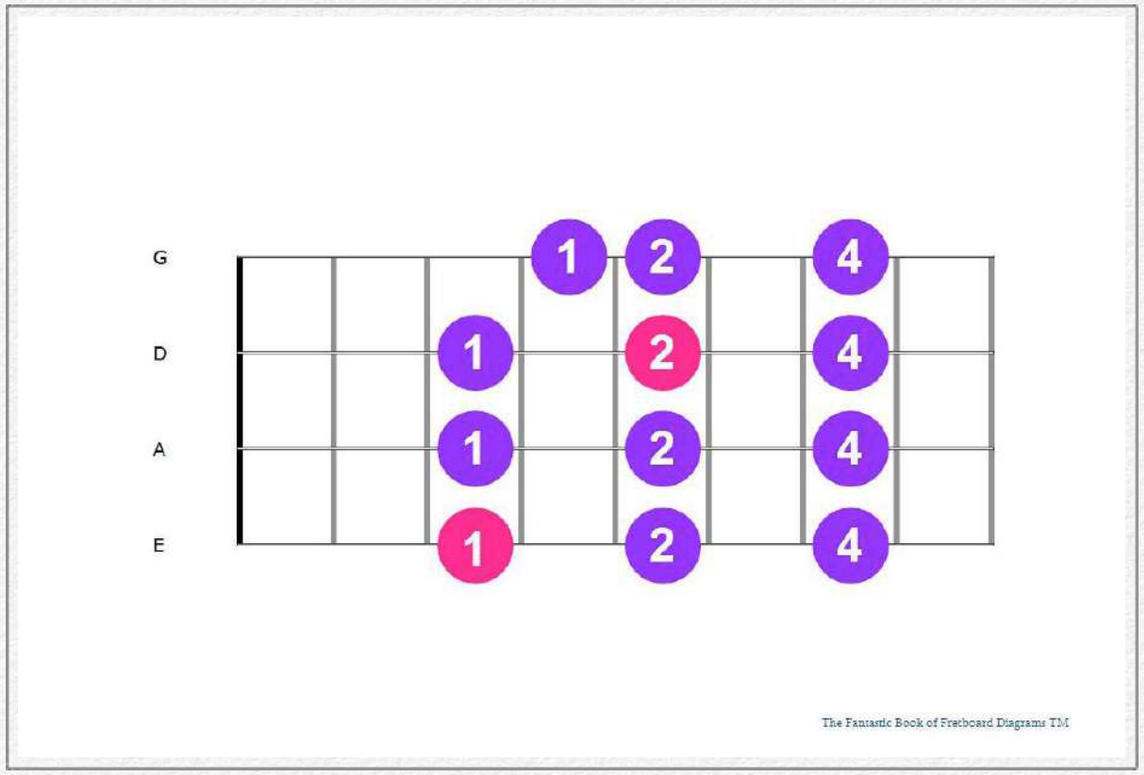
Modes



The Lydian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "four" or fourth note of the major scale. It fits with IV or IV^7 in major keys or VI or VI^7 in minor keys.

Mixolydian

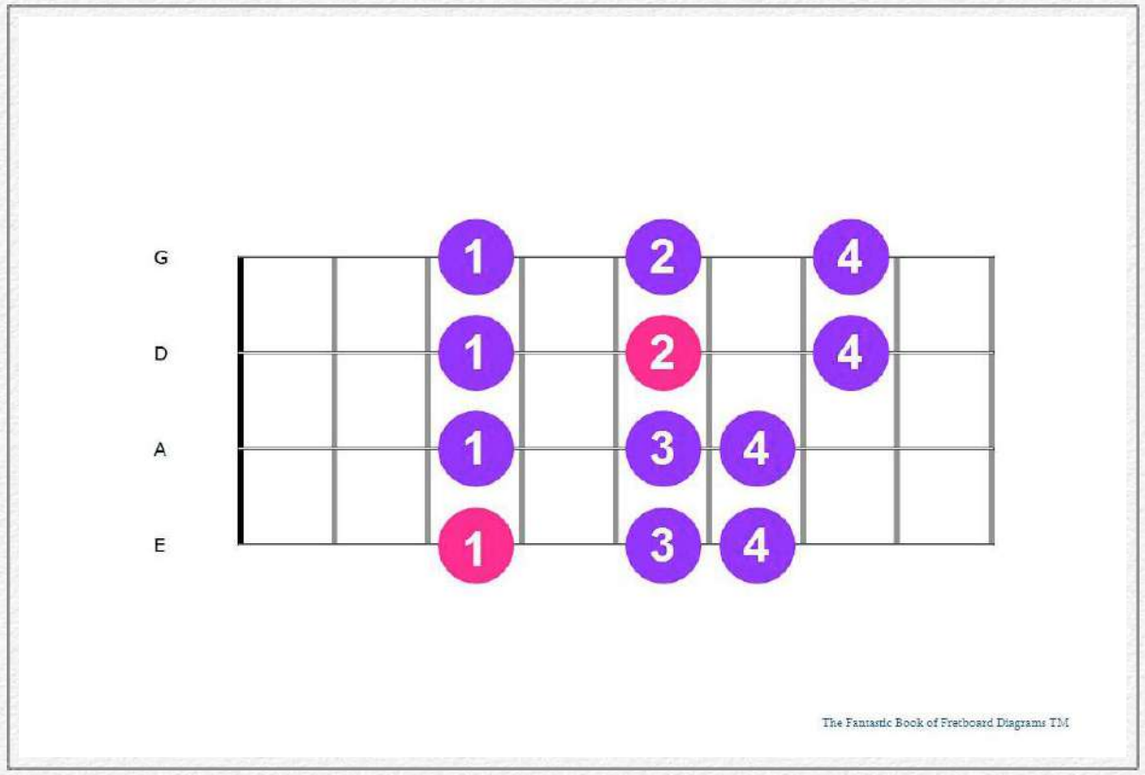
Modes



The Mixolydian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "five" or fifth note of the major scale. It fits with the V or V7 chord in major keys and under VII or VII7 in minor keys.

Aeolian

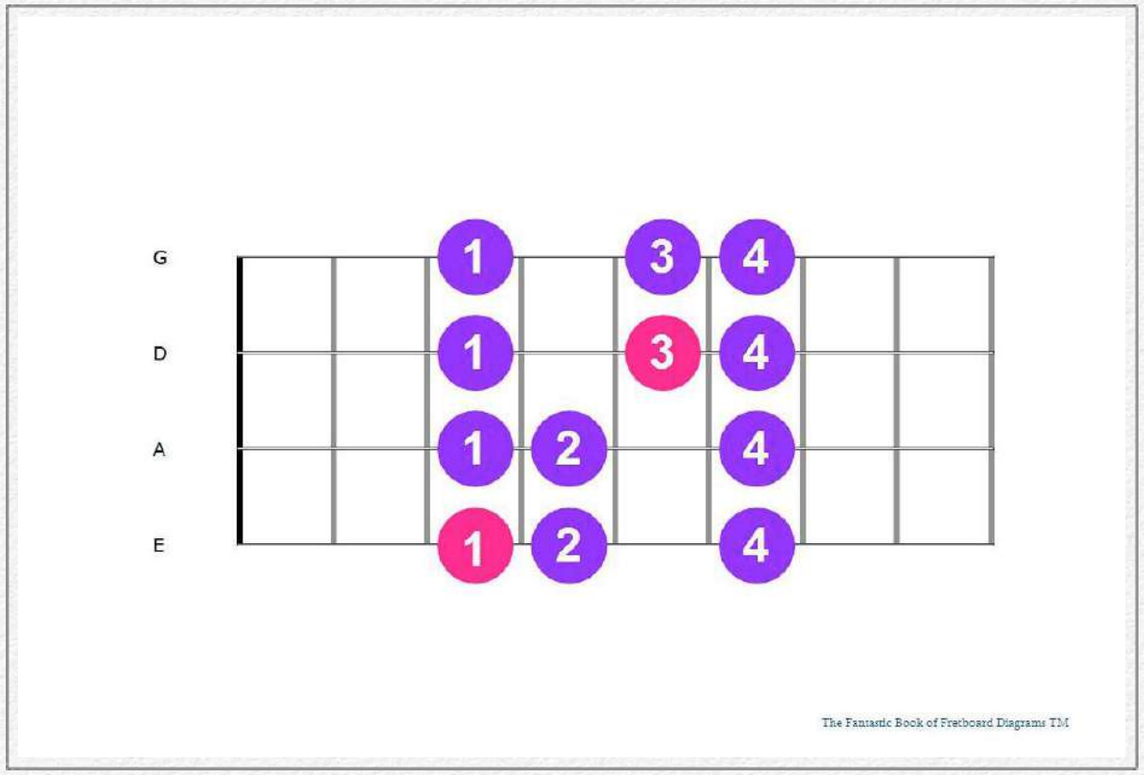
Modes



The Aeolian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "six" or sixth note of the major scale. It is another name for and way to look at the minor scale. It fits with the vi or vi^7 minor chords in major keys and under i or i^7 in minor keys.

Locrian

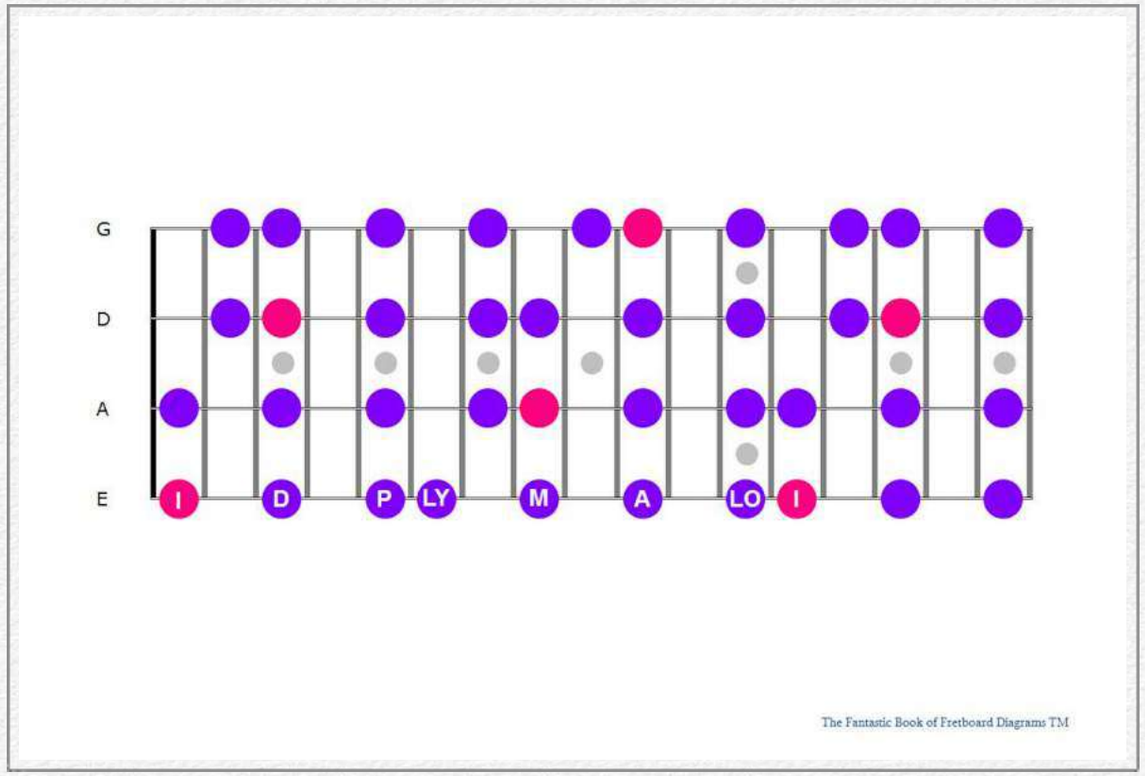
Modes



The Locrian Mode is built within the major scale starting on the "seven" or seventh note of the major scale. It fits under vii chords (the diminished triad or the minor 7 ♭5) in major keys and under ii dim or ii minor 7 ♭5 in minor keys.

Modes

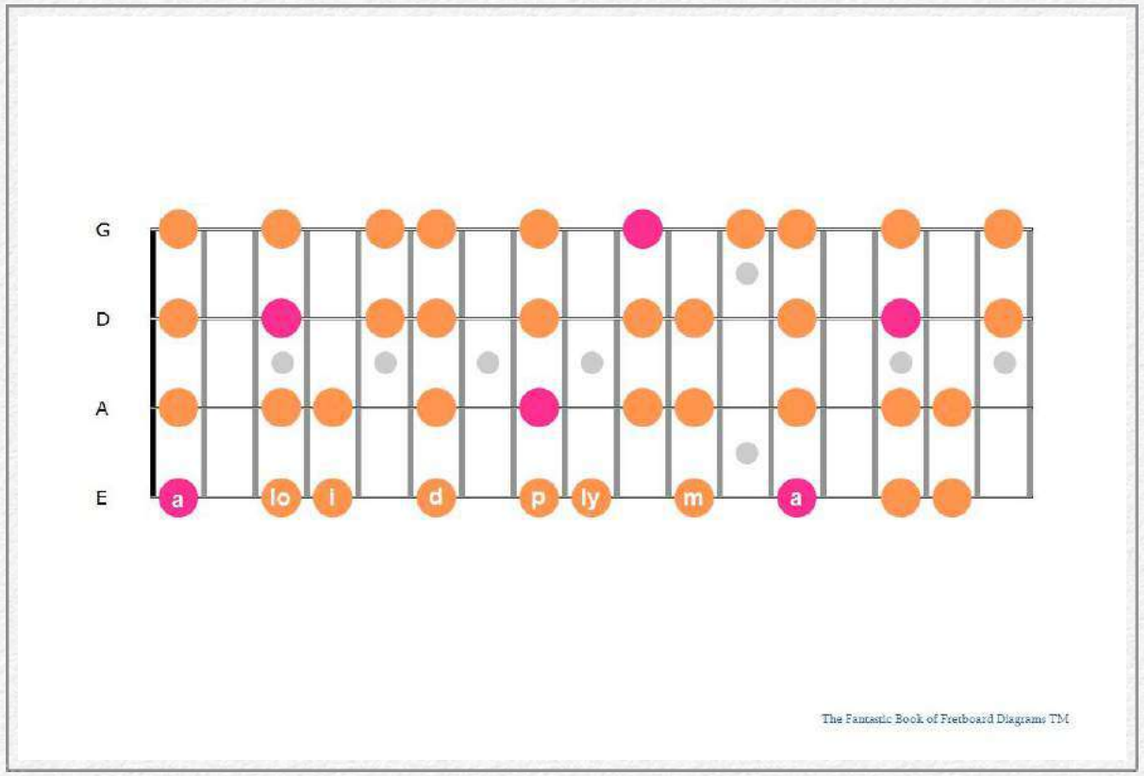
Complete



Here we can see how all of the modes fit together to provide total realization of the fretboard. This example has the root of Ionian on F, so this is F major. The notes in red indicate the F root. See it from at least two perspectives: 1) the connection of whole modes, and 2) the notes available around different root centres.

Modes

From the Minor Perspective



Here we have the modes built on the minor scale (the Aeolian mode) giving us a new perspective — applying the mode shapes to any minor key. This time, the minor root is in red. In this case, it's F minor.

To develop your own voice, look for and experiment with shapes within that you think are great.

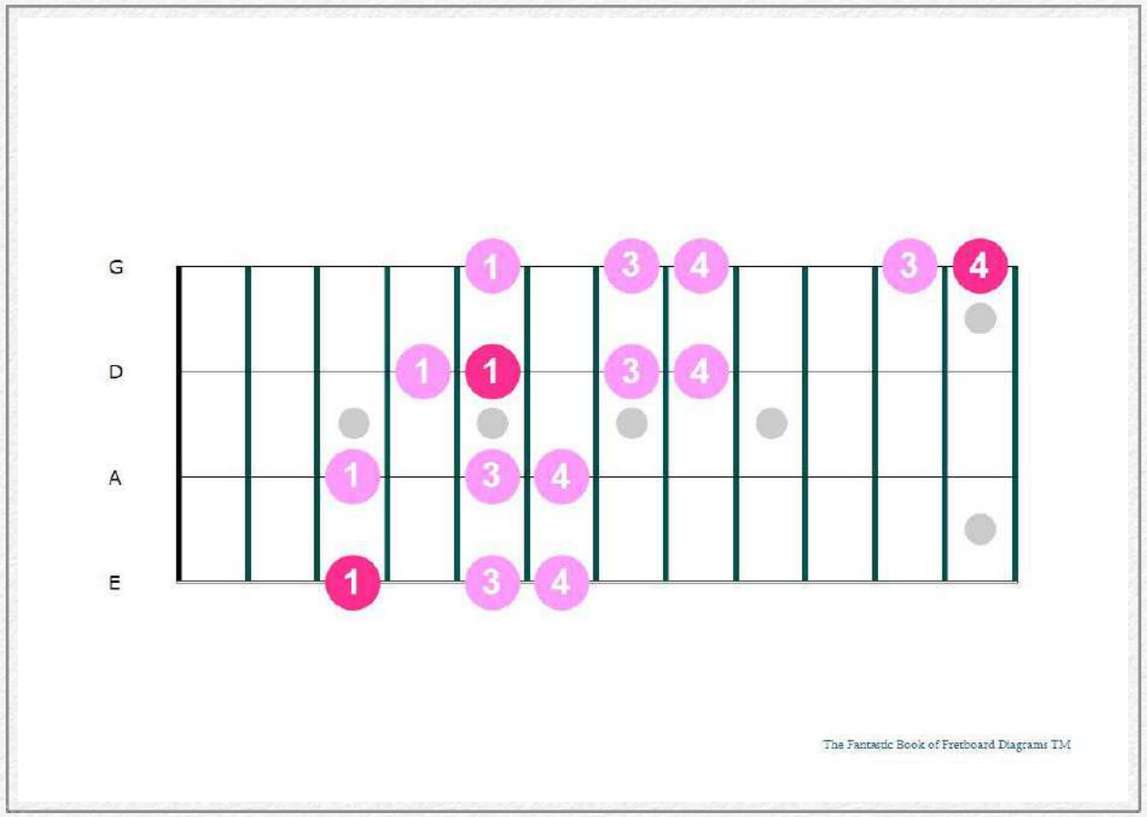
With any scale, or collection of scales, you can also experiment to find shapes that you think sound and feel the best. Perhaps you can find new shapes or pieces that combine over octaves or with slides or with some other way of phrasing the notes. Experiment creatively to develop your own sound and phrasing.

Test your time now with my Ten Time Signatures Practice Module.

Harmonic and Melodic Minor

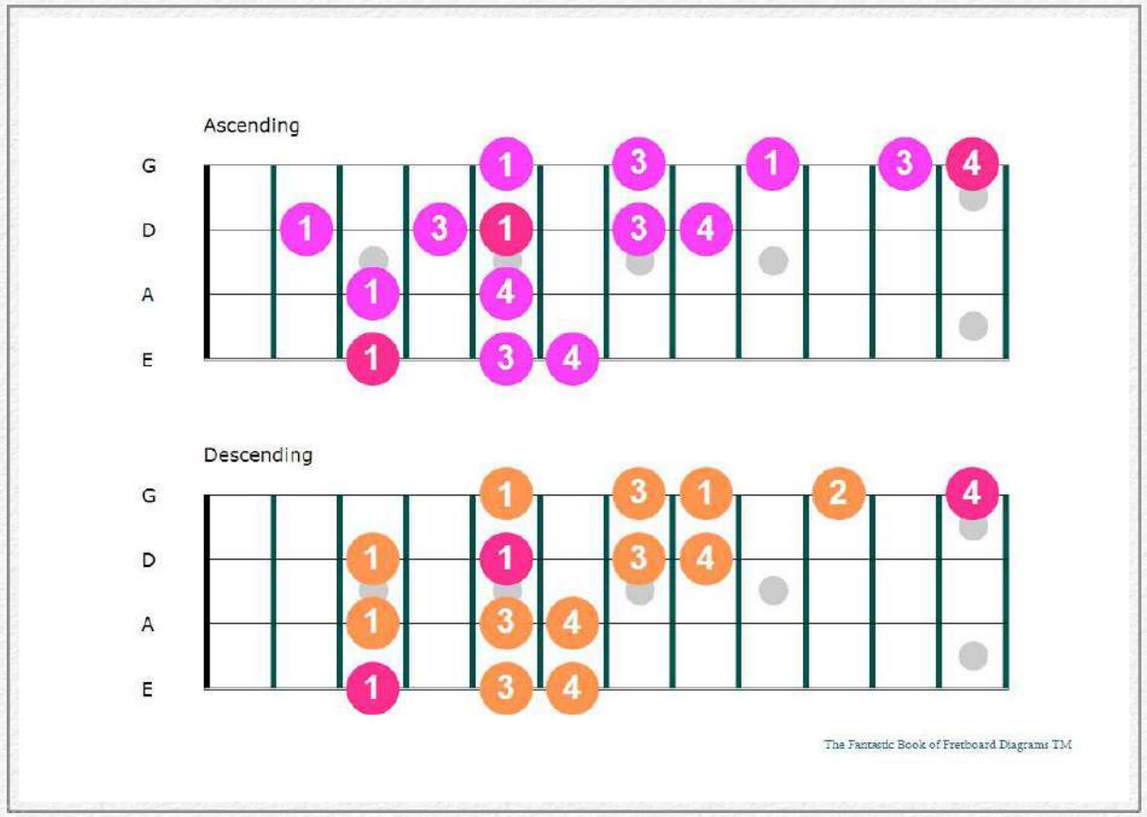
Harmonic and melodic minor scales are two modifications of the minor scale.

Harmonic Minor



Harmonic minor is a significant variation of the minor scale where the once minor 7th is made into a major 7th. This change allows for a new chord to be built in a minor key -- V major. This scale fits with a V major or V7 major to i minor. In A minor, if the fifth chord (normally minor) is E major or E7, this is a place for harmonic minor.

Melodic Minor



Melodic minor is a variation of the minor scale in which the ascending notes are different that the descending notes. As you go up, both the 6th and 7th intervals are sharped. As you come down, the scale returns to the natural minor. This scale allows for two new chords to be built in a minor key -- IV major and V major. In the key of A minor, D major and E major both fit with the ascending form of this scale.

Chords for the Bass

12

Bass chords add colour to bass lines. Learning chords increases the understanding of harmony and the ability to craft great bass lines.

Chord Construction

All chords are built on triads and variations of triads.

The following chart provides a reference for the construction of chords.

Explore chords from a different perspective to deepen your understanding even further with this best-selling course: Piano For All!

Chord Construction - The Fantastic Book of Fretboard Diagrams for Bass Guitar			
Chord	**Structure**	**Symbols**	**Notes with C as the Root**
Triads			
Major	1, 3, 5		C, E, G
Minor	1, ♭3, 5	min, mi, m, -	C, E♭, G
Diminished	1, ♭3, ♭5	dim, °	C, E♭, G♭
Augmented	1, 3, ♯5	aug, +	C, E, G♯
7th Chords			
Major 7th	1, 3, 5, 7	Maj7, Ma7, M7, △7	C, E, G, B
Minor 7th	1, ♭3, 5, ♭7	min7, mi7, m7, -7	C, E♭, G, B♭
Dominant 7th	1, 3, 5, ♭7	7	C, E, G, B♭
Minor 7 ♭5	1, ♭3, ♭5, ♭7	m7♭5, ø	C, E♭, G♭, B♭
Diminished 7th	1, ♭3, ♭5, ♭ ♭7	dim7, °7	C, E♭, G♭, B♭ ♭
Augmented Major 7th	1, 3, ♯5, 7	aug M7	C, E, G♯, B
Augmented 7th	1, 3, ♯5, ♭7	aug7	C, E, G♯, B♭
Minor major 7th	1, ♭3, 5, 7	min maj7, m(M7), m△7	C, E♭, G, B
6th Chords			
6th (Major)	1, 3, 5, 6	6	C, E, G, A
Minor 6th	1, ♭3, 5, 6	m6, -6	C, E♭, G, A
Suspended Chords			
Suspended 4th	1, 4, 5	sus4	C, F, G
Suspended 2nd	1, 2, 5	sus2	C, D, G
Extended Chords			
9th (Dominant)	1, 3, 5, ♭7, 9	9	C, E, G, B♭, D
Major 9th	1, 3, 5, 7, 9	maj9	C, E, G, B, D
Minor 9th	1, ♭3, 5, ♭7, 9	min9	C, E♭, G, B♭, D
Add 9	1, 3, 5, 9	add9	C, E, G, D
11th (Dominant)	1, 3, 5, ♭7, 9, 11	11	C, E, G, B♭, D, F
Major 11th	1, 3, 5, 7, 9, 11	maj11	C, E, G, B, D, F
Minor 11th	1, ♭3, 5, ♭7, 9, 11	min11	C, E♭, G, B♭, D, F
13th (Dominant)	1, 3, 5, ♭7, 9, 11, 13	13	C, E, G, B♭, D, F, A
Major 13th	1, 3, 5, 7, 9, 11, 13	maj13	C, E, G, B, D, F, A
Minor 13th	1, ♭3, 5, ♭7, 9, 11, 13	min13	C, E♭, G, B♭, D, F, A

Major Chords

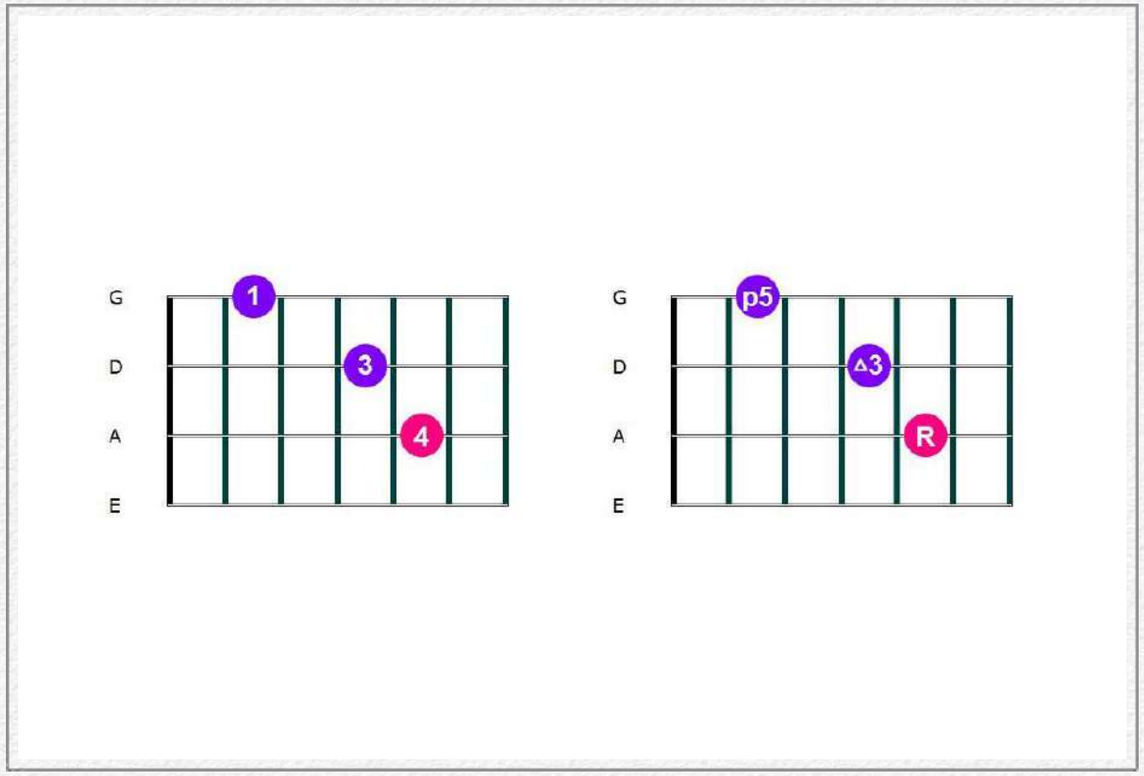
Major chords are 3 note chords that are based on a major triad.

They consist of a root, a major 3rd and a perfect 5th (1, 3, 5).

For Example, C major is built with the notes C, E, G.

The following chords are mobile and can be played anywhere on the neck including starting on the E string.

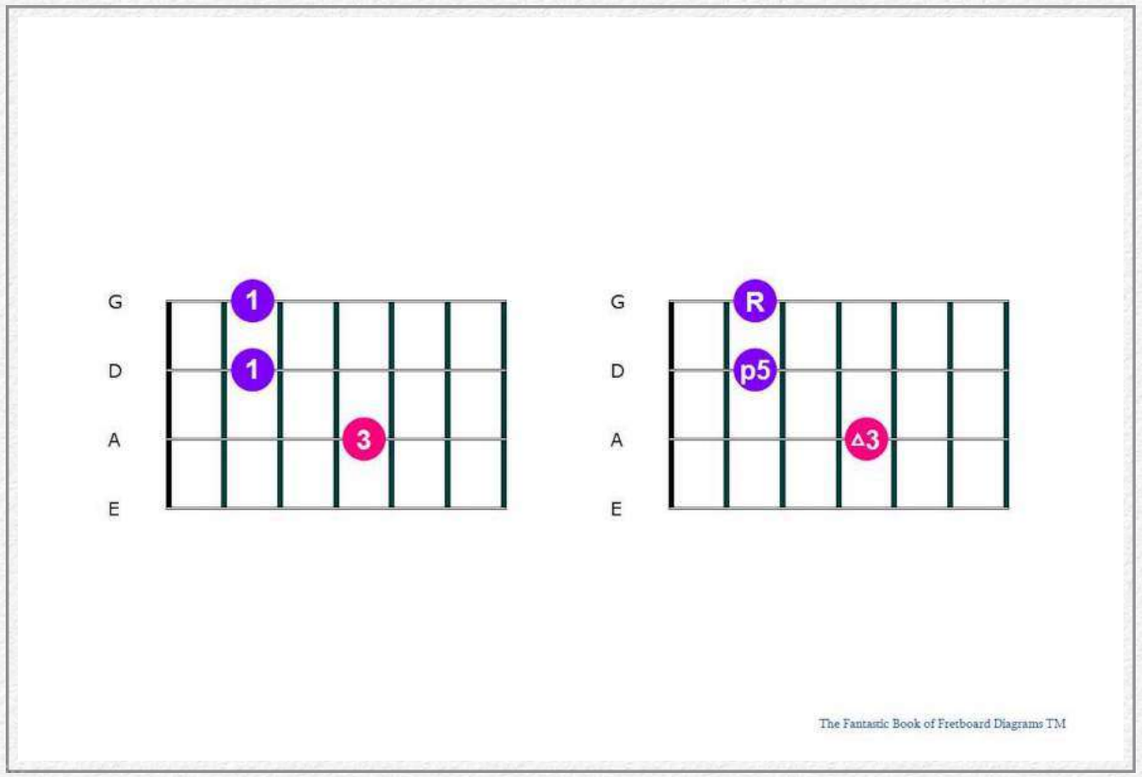
Major Chord



Here is a major chord in root position. The root is highlighted in red. The note this root is played on determines the chord letter name. For example, if the root where played on the 5th fret of the A string, which is a D, it becomes a D major chord.

Major Chord

1st Inversion

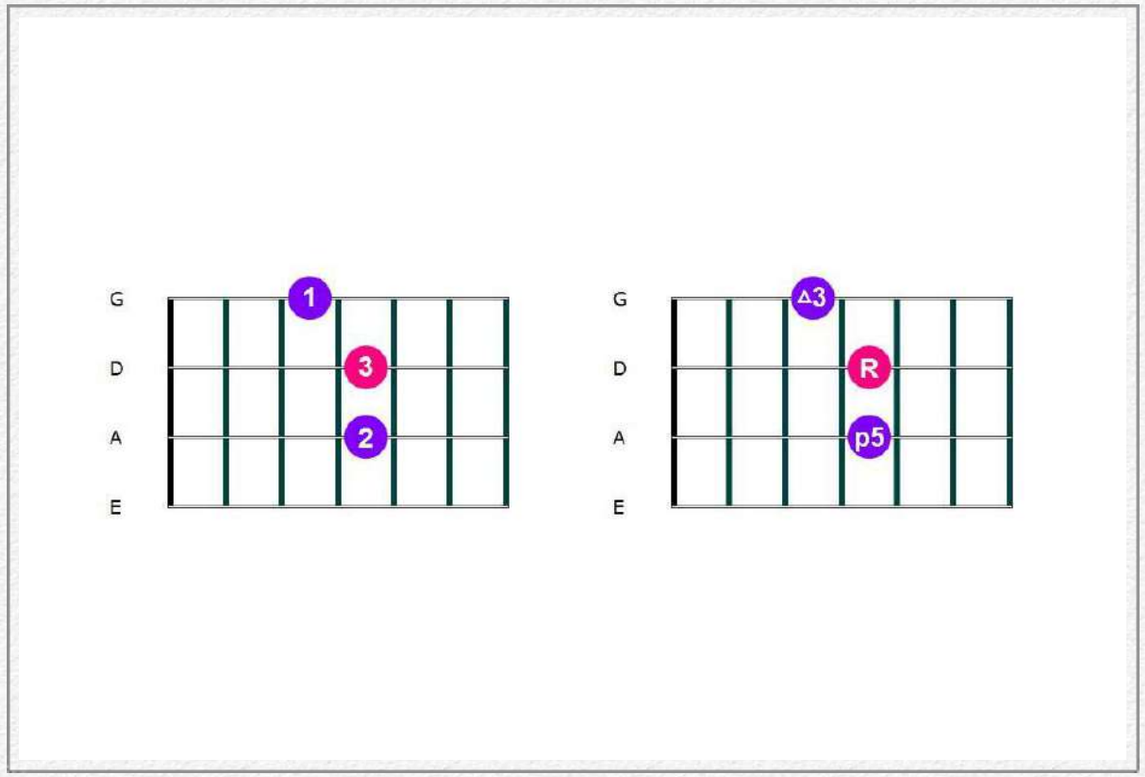


The 1st inversion of the major chord has the 3rd in the base (3, 5, 1). C major 1st inversion is built E, G, C.

Chord notation: C/E where the capital letter on the left indicates the chord and the capital letter on the right indicates the lowest note.

Major Chord

2nd Inversion

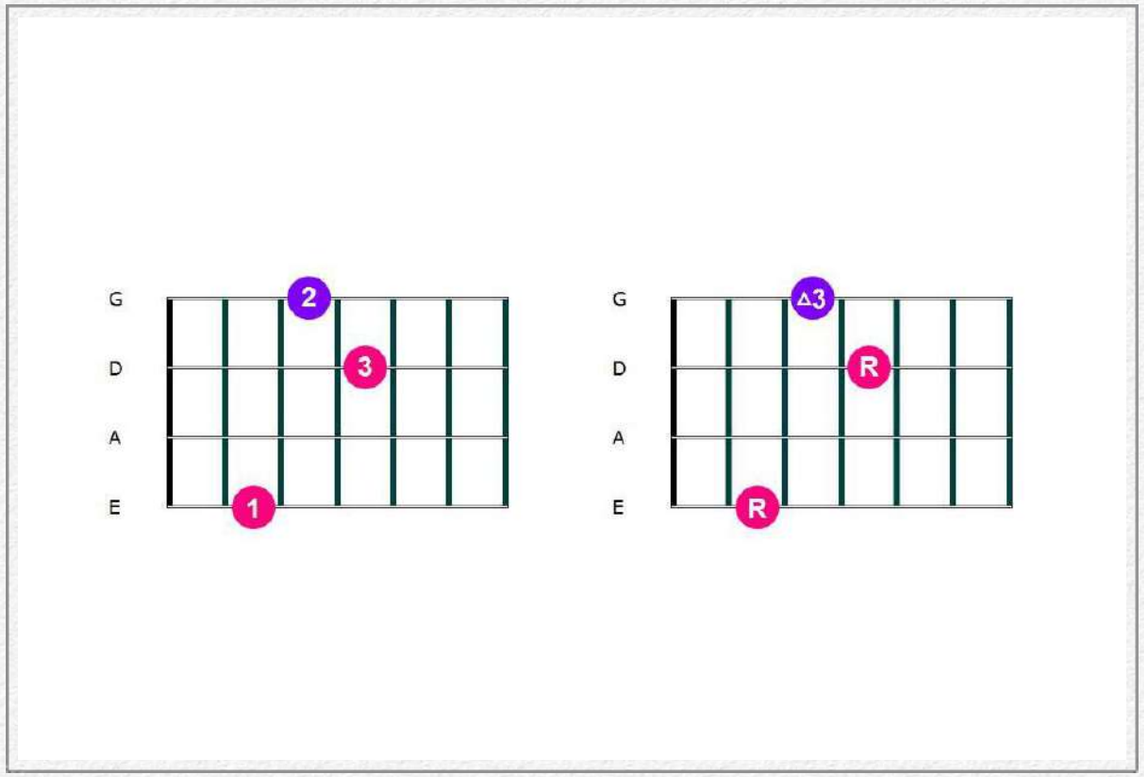


The 2nd inversion of the major chord has the 5th in the base (5, 1, 3). C major 2nd inversion is built G, C, E.

Cho rd notation: C/G where the capital letter on the left indicates the chord and the capital letter on the right indicates the lowest note.

Major Chord

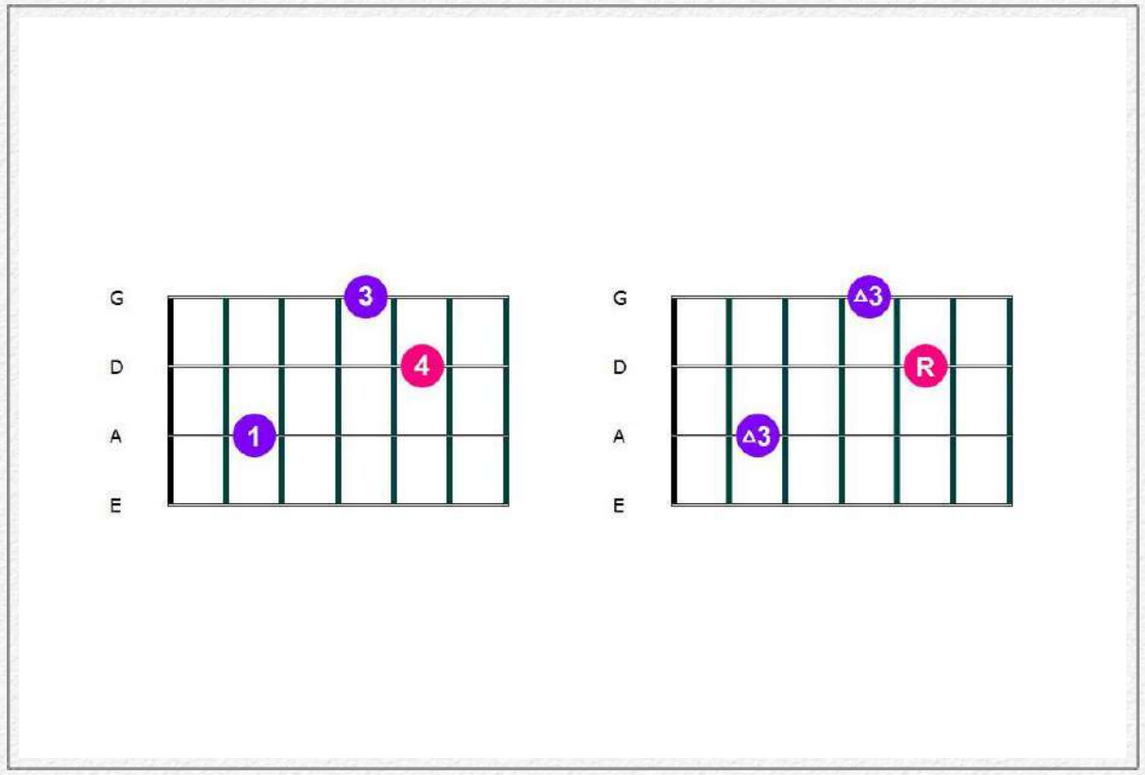
The Major Barre Chord



These chord shapes work well with all three notes or with either root note and the third. They are an excellent compliment to a “line” and provide beautiful colour.

Major Chord

1st Inversion - From the Barre



Here is another option for a major chord in 1st inversion.

Minor Chords

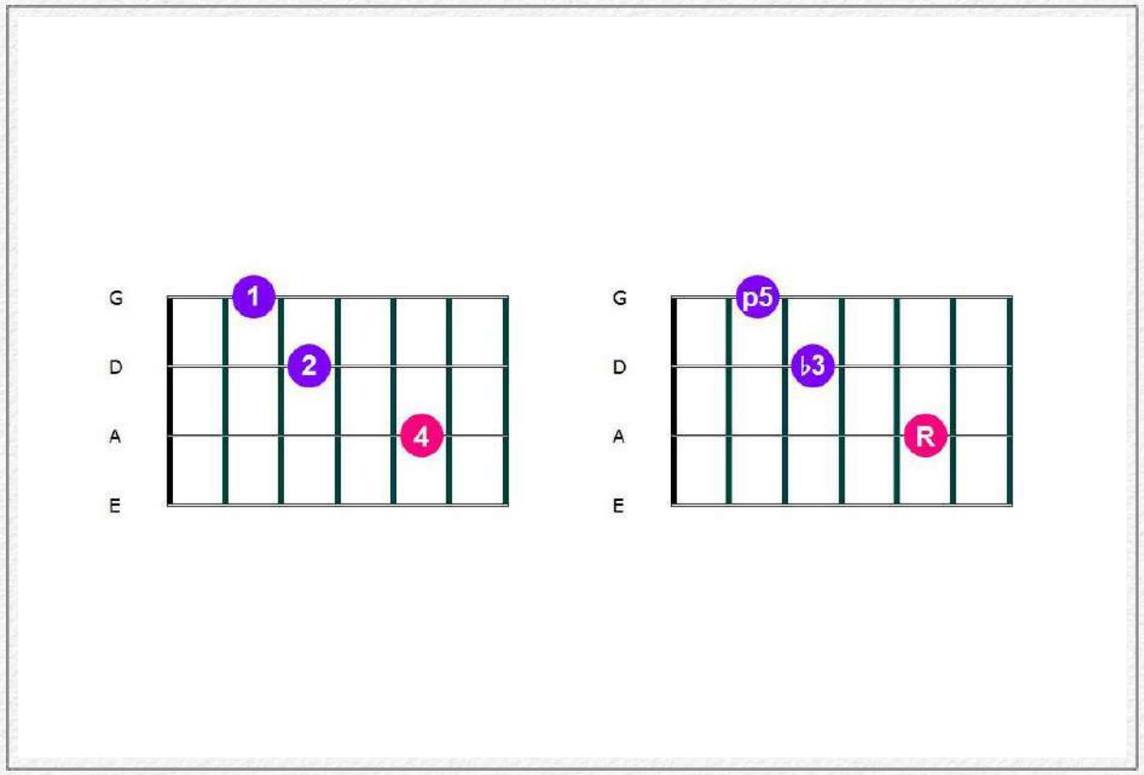
Minor chords are 3 note chords that are based on the notes of a minor triad.

They consist of a root, a minor 3rd and a 5th (1, ♭3, 5).

For example, C minor is built with the notes C, E♭, G.

The following chords are mobile and can be played anywhere on the neck including starting on the E string.

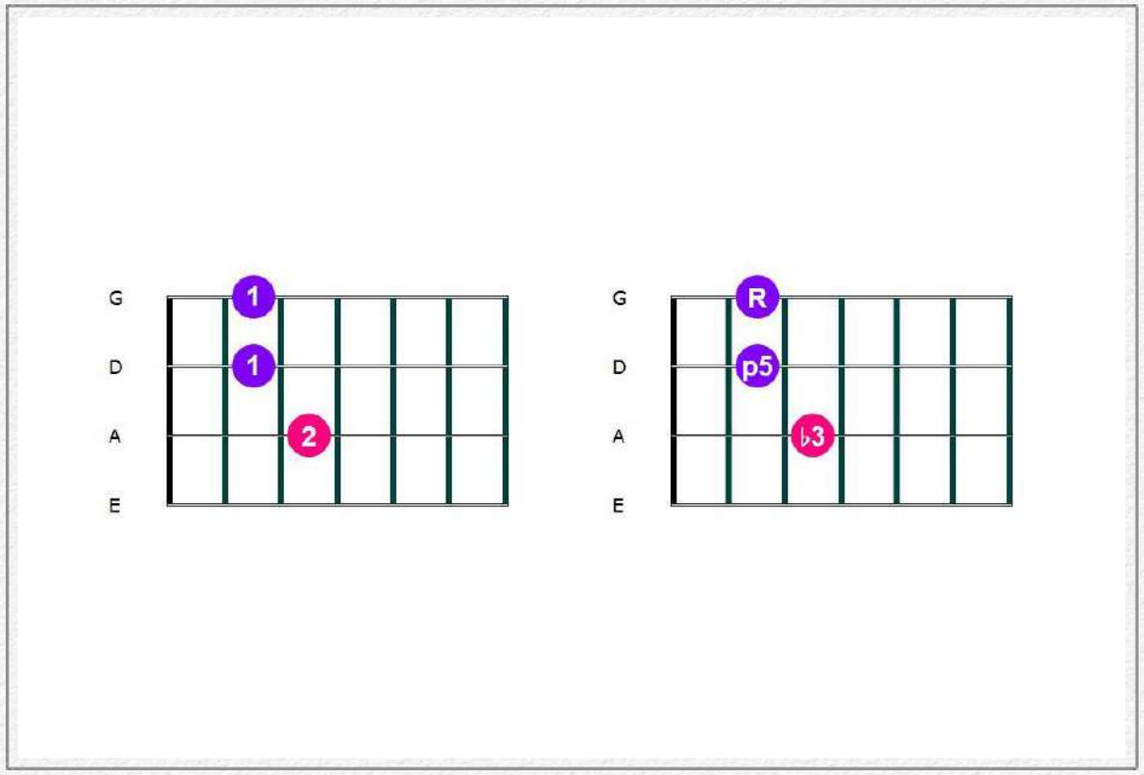
Minor Chord



Here is a minor chord in root position.

Minor Chord

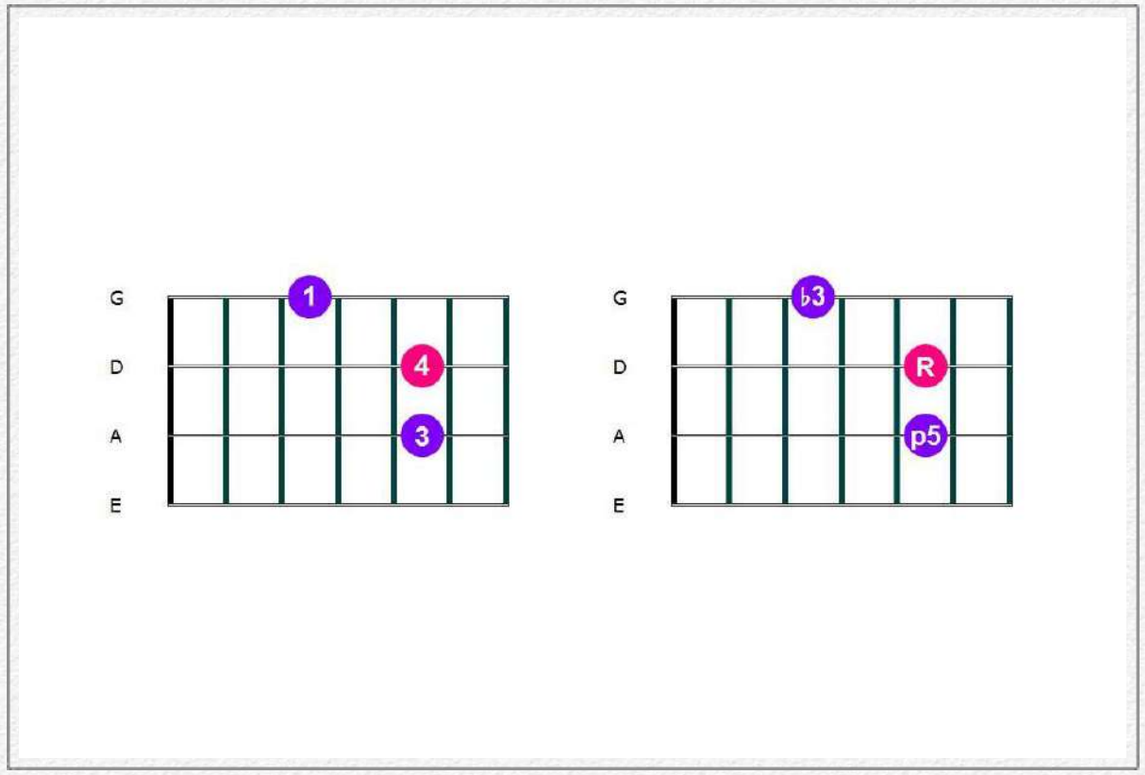
1st Inversion



This chord is formed from the minor triad (1,3,5) with the 3rd in the base (the lowest note). In A minor the notes are A, C, E with the C in the base (C, E, A). Chord notation: Am/C where the capital letter on the left indicates the chord and the capital letter on the right indicates the lowest note.

Minor Chord

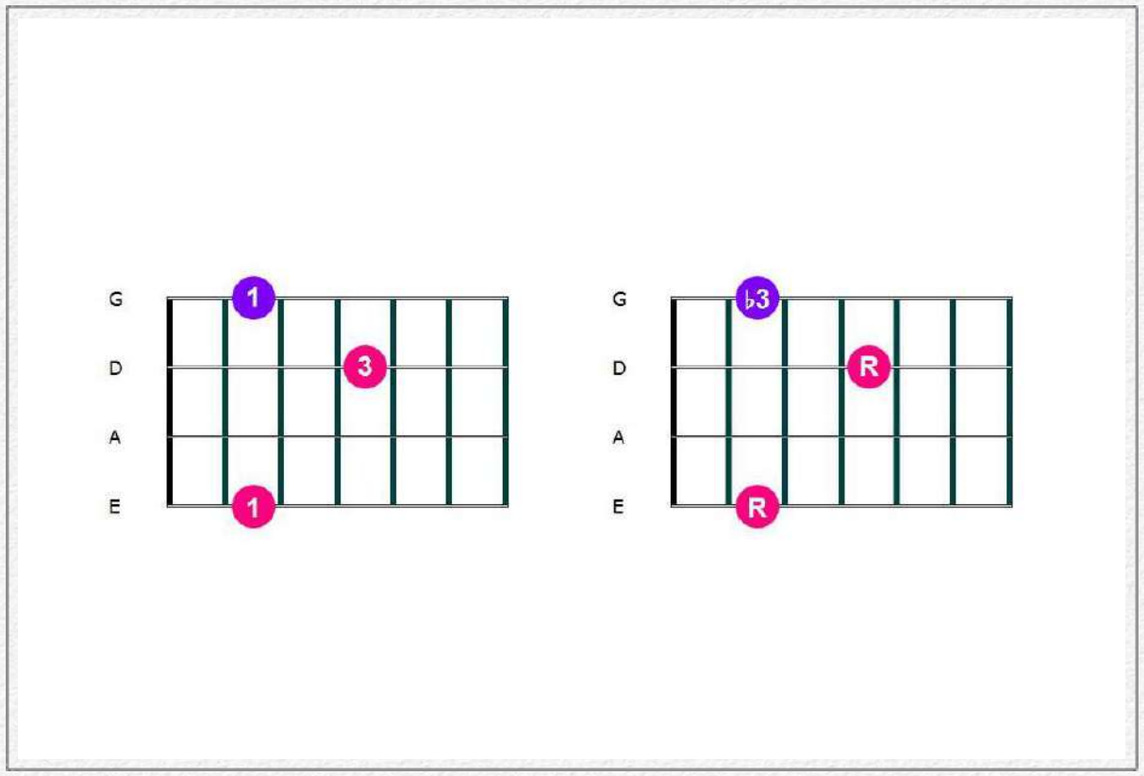
2nd Inversion



This chord is formed from the minor triad (1,3,5) with the 5th in the base (the lowest note). In E minor the notes are E, G, B with the B in the base (B, E, G). Chord notation: Em/B

Minor Chord

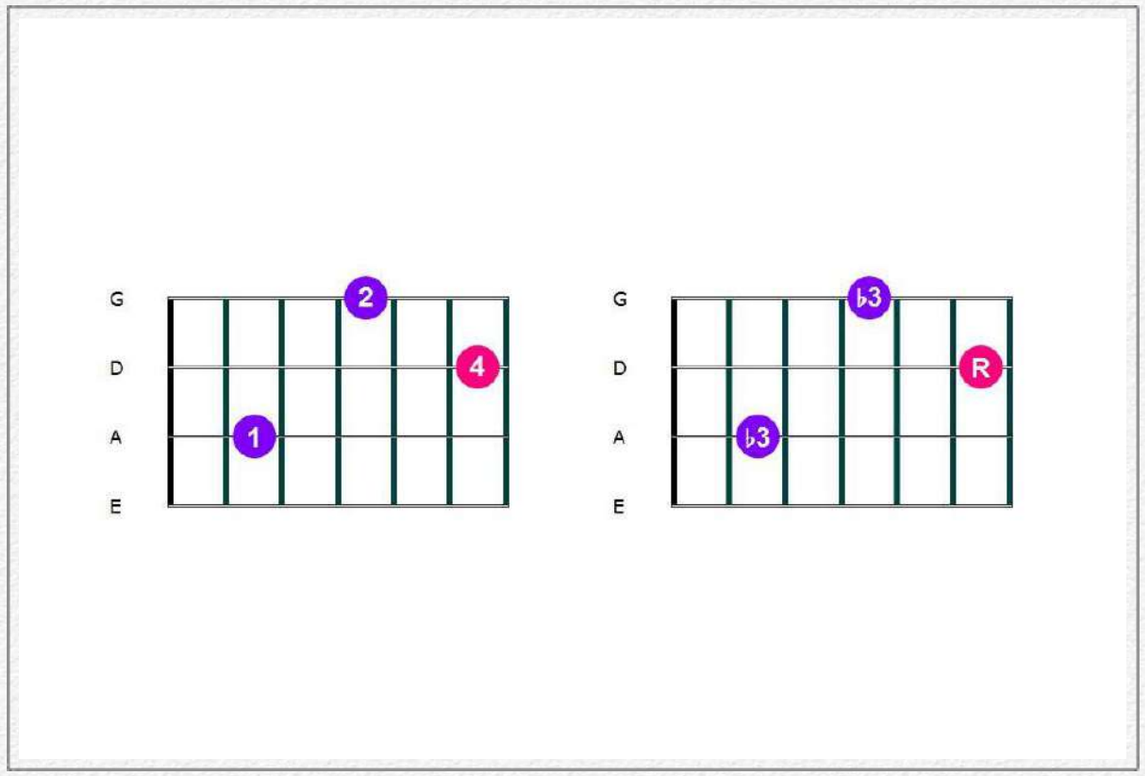
The Minor Barre Chord



You could substitute the fifth for the octave root note, though it doesn't ring as clear.

Minor Chord

1st Inversion - From the Barre



Here is another option for a minor chord in 1st inversion. To maintain some space in the sounding notes and avoid dissonance, the 3rd is doubled and there is no 5td.

Diminished and Augmented Chords

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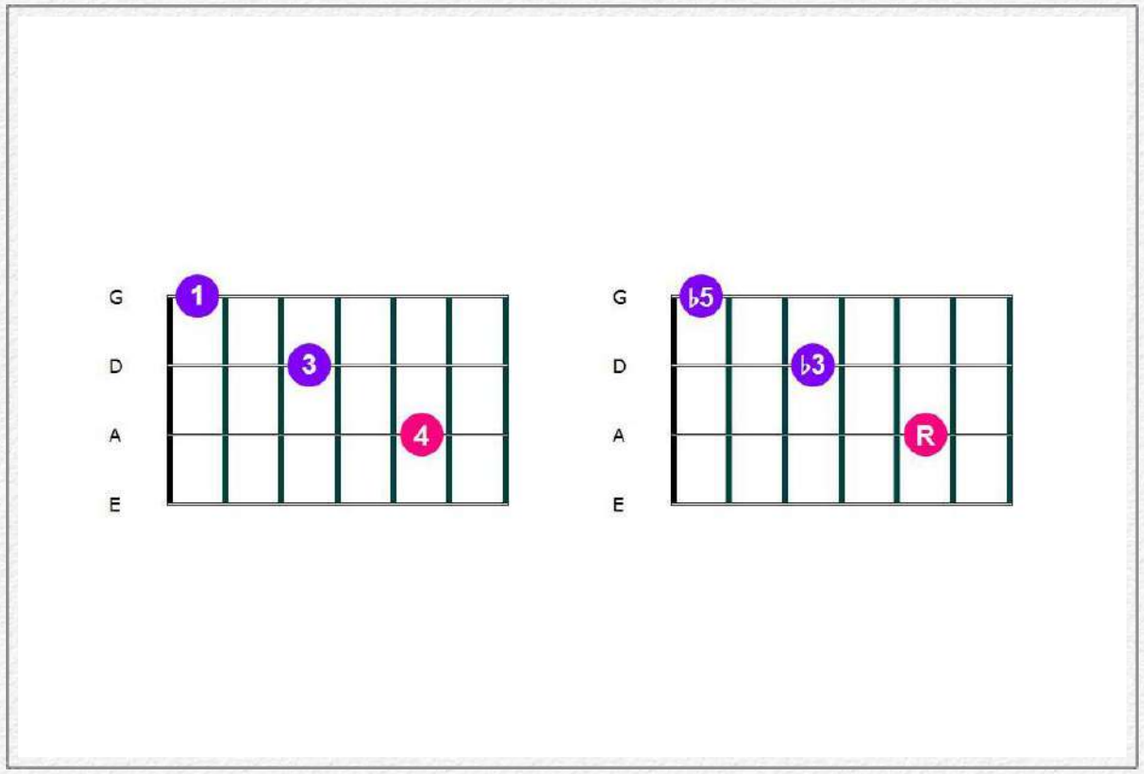
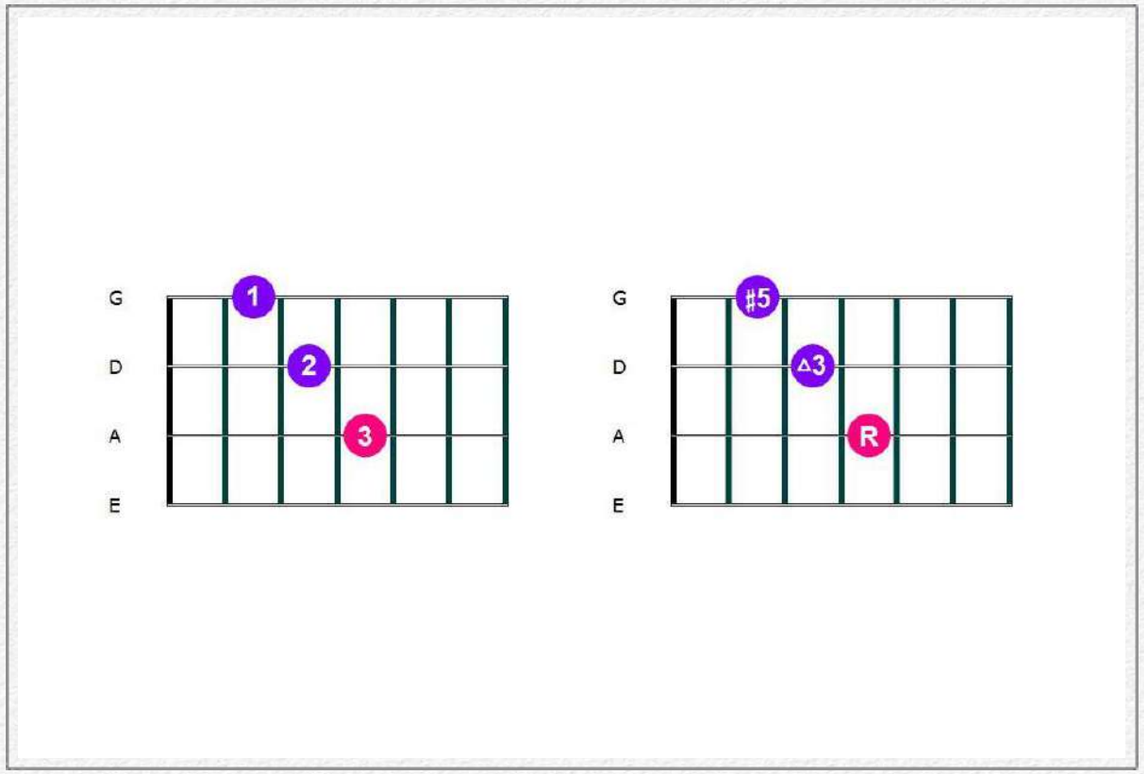
Diminished Chord



The diminished chord is formed by a diminished triad (1, ♭ 3, ♭ 5).

Cdim is built with the notes C, E ♭ , G ♭ .

Augmented Chord



The augmented chord is formed by an augmented triad (1, 3, #5). Gaug is built with the notes G, B, D#.

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Develop a complete understanding of chords and learn to recognize them instantly by ear by enrolling in my course The Elements of Music | Music Theory and Foundations now (discount code in this link).

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7th Chords

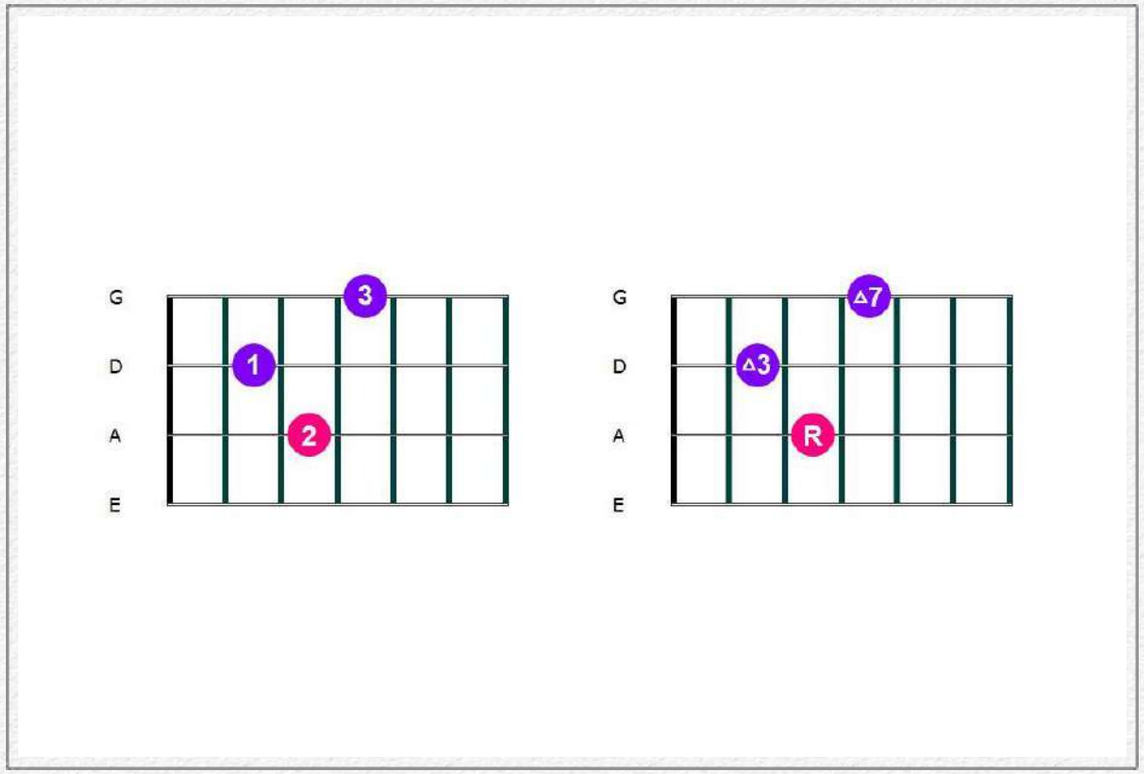
7th chords are four-note chords that add the interval of a 7th to a triad. Three types of 7th intervals are added to create these chords:

major 7th

minor 7th (♭7)

double-flat 7th (♭♭7).

Major 7th Chord

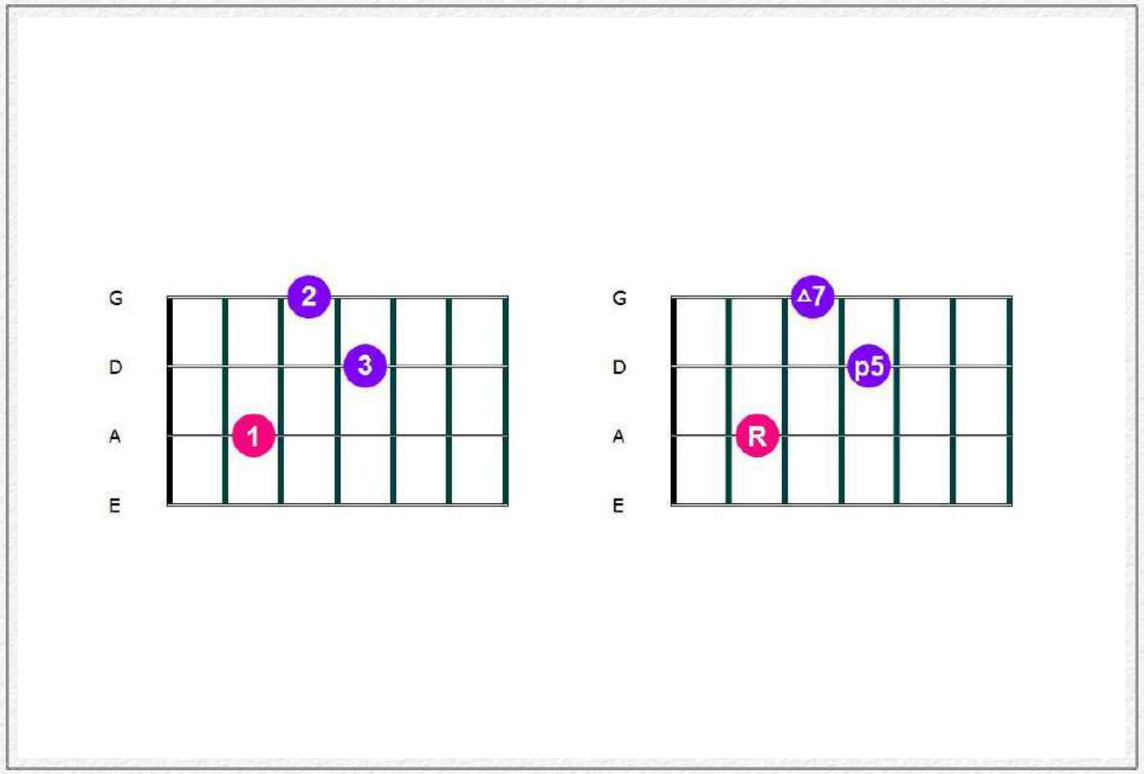


The major 7th chord is formed by the notes of the major triad (1, 3, 5) with the addition of a major 7th (1, 3, 5, 7). CMaj7 is built with the notes C, E, G, B.

In this bass chord, the fifth has been dropped for a cleaner sound.

Major 7th Chord

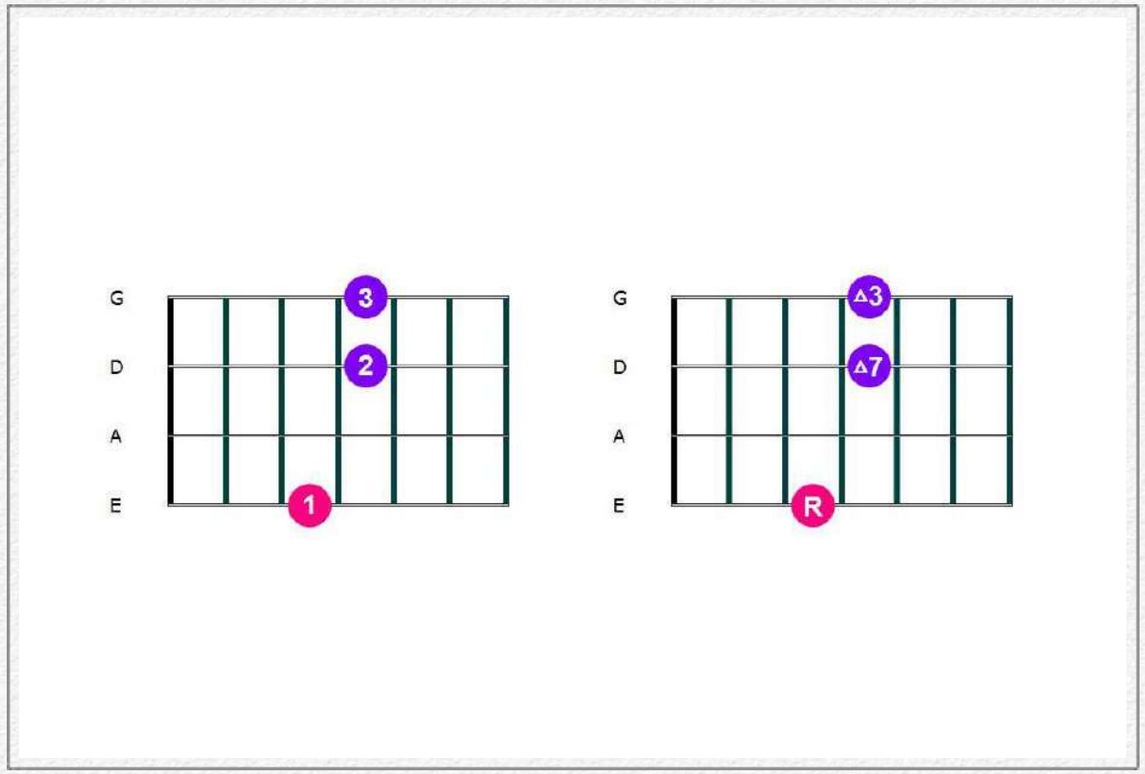
Option 2



In this option of a major 7th chord, there is no 3rd.

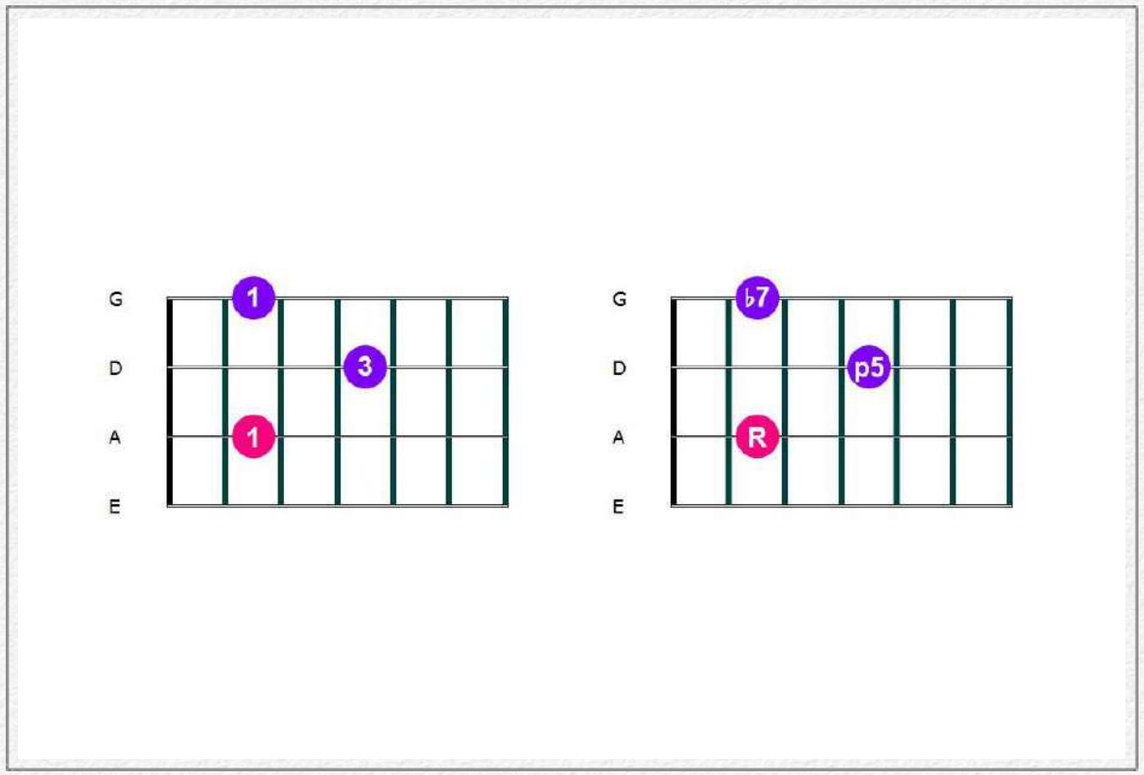
Major 7th Chord

The Major 7th Barre Chord



Here we have the barre chord option for a major 7th chord. Again, reducing the chord from four notes to three (usually done by dropping the third or the fifth) allows for space and clarity in the sound.

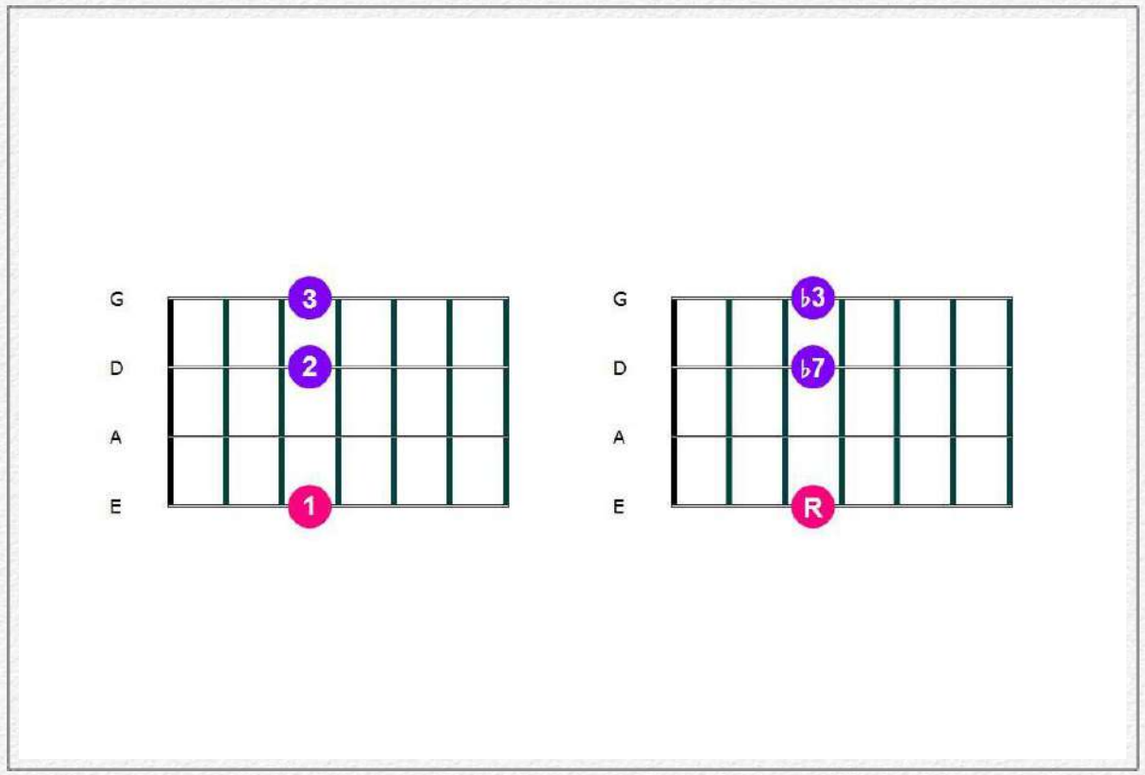
Minor 7th Chord



The minor 7th chord is formed by the notes of the minor triad (1, ♭ 3, 5) with the addition of a minor 7th (1, ♭ 3, 5, ♭ 7). Am7 is built with the notes A, C, E, G.
In this bass chord, the 3rd has been dropped for a cleaner sound.
Note that without the 3rd, this chord could also be a dominant 7th.

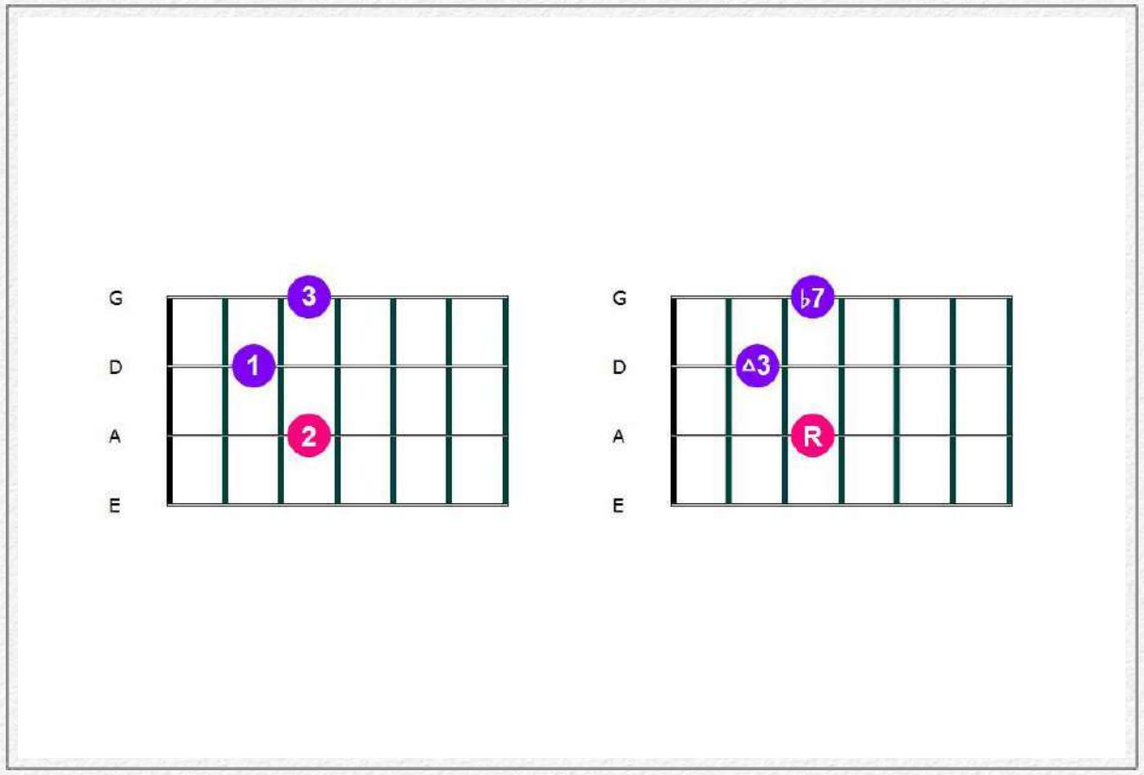
Minor 7th Chord

The Minor 7th Barre Chord



Here is a barre chord option for a minor 7th chord. The 5th has been dropped for clarity of sound.

Dominant 7th Chord

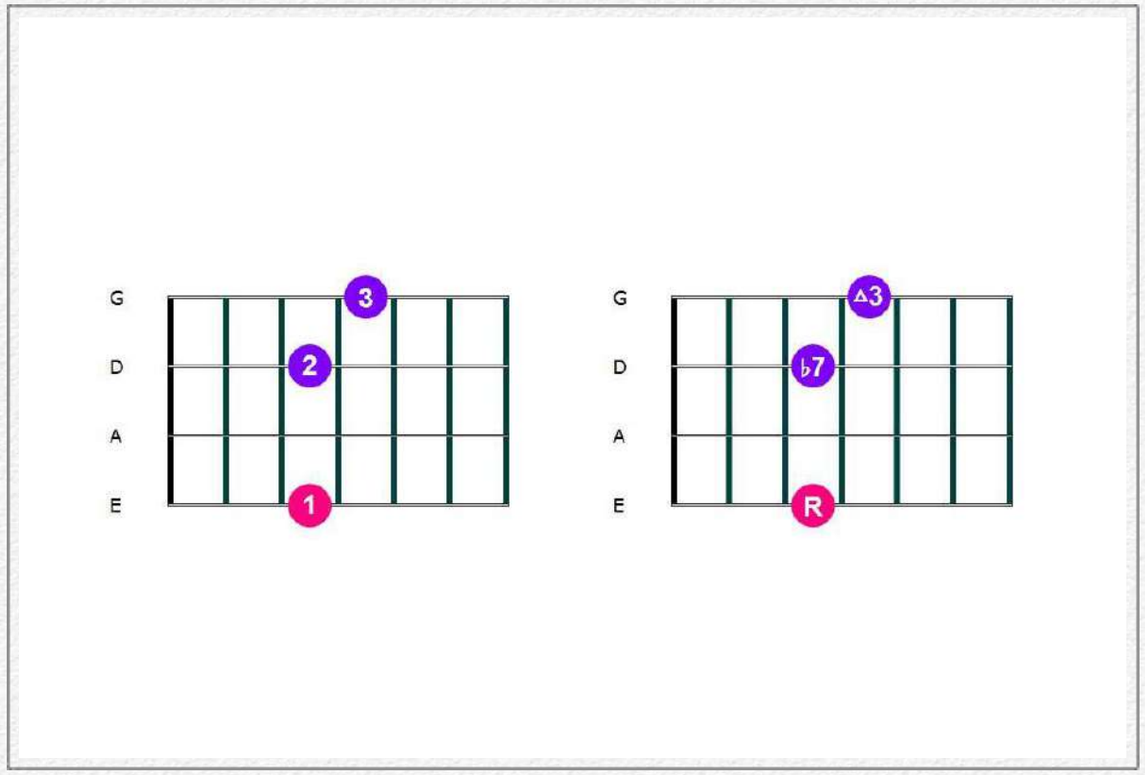


The dominant 7th chord is formed by a major triad with a minor 7th (1, 3, 5, ♭7). A C7 chord is built with C, E, G and B♭.

The dominant 7th chord is more commonly known as a 7th chord. People typically specify "major 7th" and "minor 7th," but if someone just says "7th chord," it generally means dominant 7th.

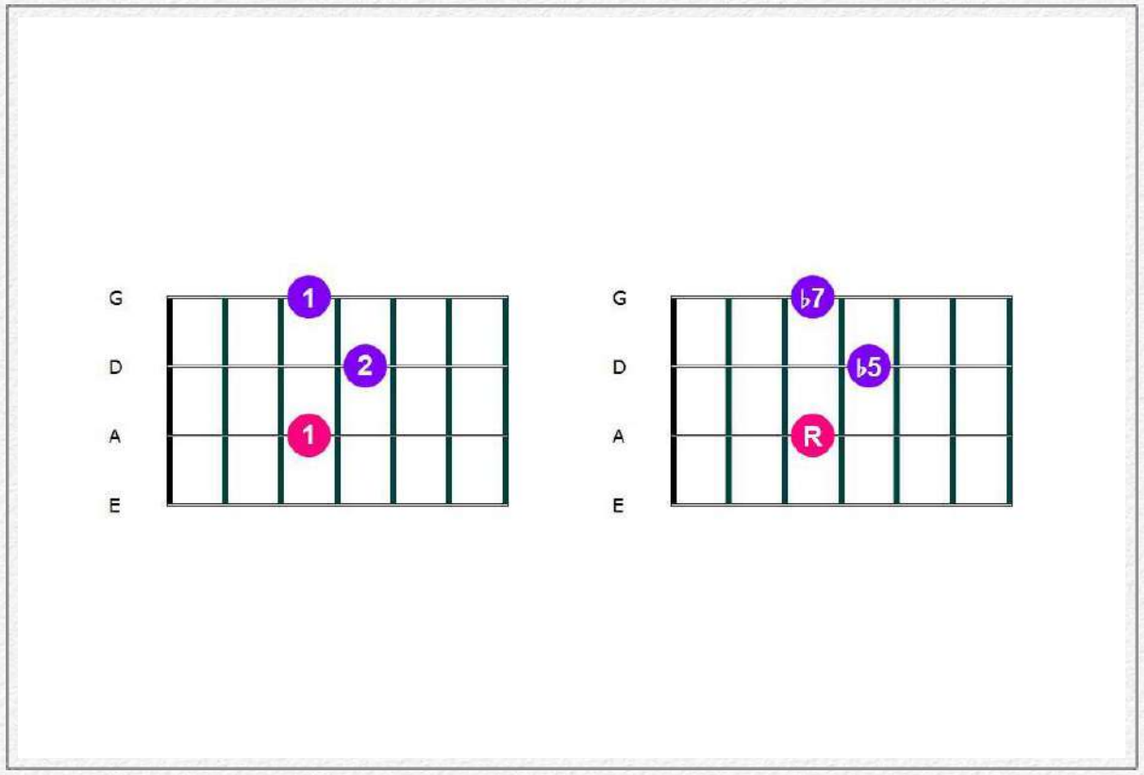
Dominant 7th Chord

The Dominant 7th Barre Chord



Here is a barre chord option for the Dominant 7th chord.

Minor 7 ♭ 5 Chord

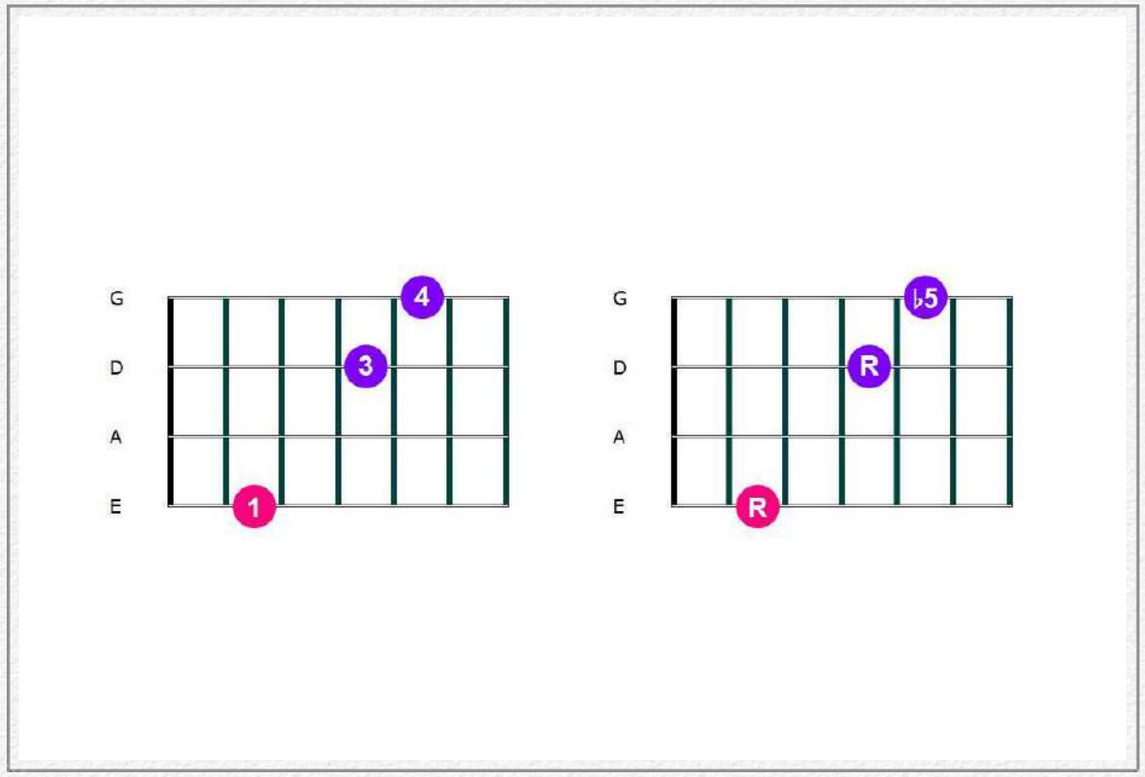


The Minor 7 ♭ 5 chord is formed by a diminished triad (1, ♭ 3, ♭ 5) with a minor 7th added (1, ♭ 3, ♭ 5, ♭ 7). Bm7 ♭ 5 is built with the notes B, D, F, A.

As the flatted 5th is a unique part of this chord, it remains. This is a diatonic chord (it is made from notes that naturally occur in any major or minor key). This chord is vii^7 in major keys and ii^7 in minor keys.

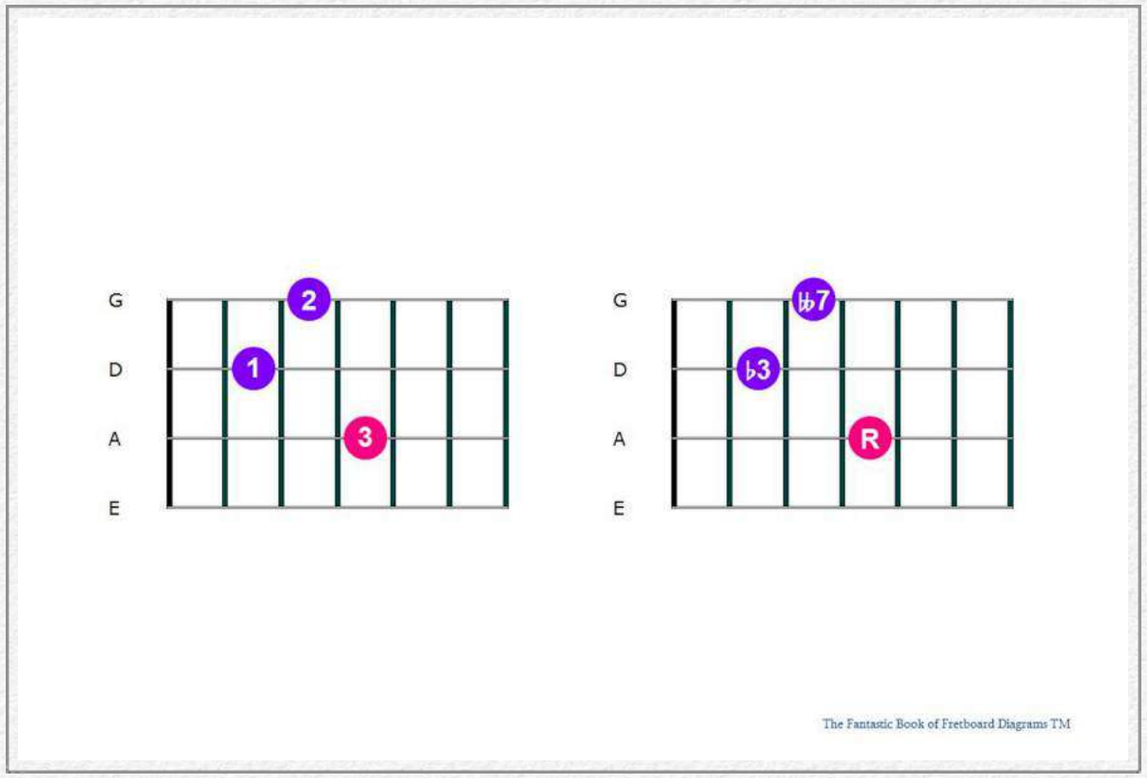
Minor 7 ♭ 5 Chord

The Minor 7 ♭ 5 Barre Chord



Here is another option for the Minor 7 ♭ 5 chord. Only the distinctive flatted 5th is played with the root and octave root.

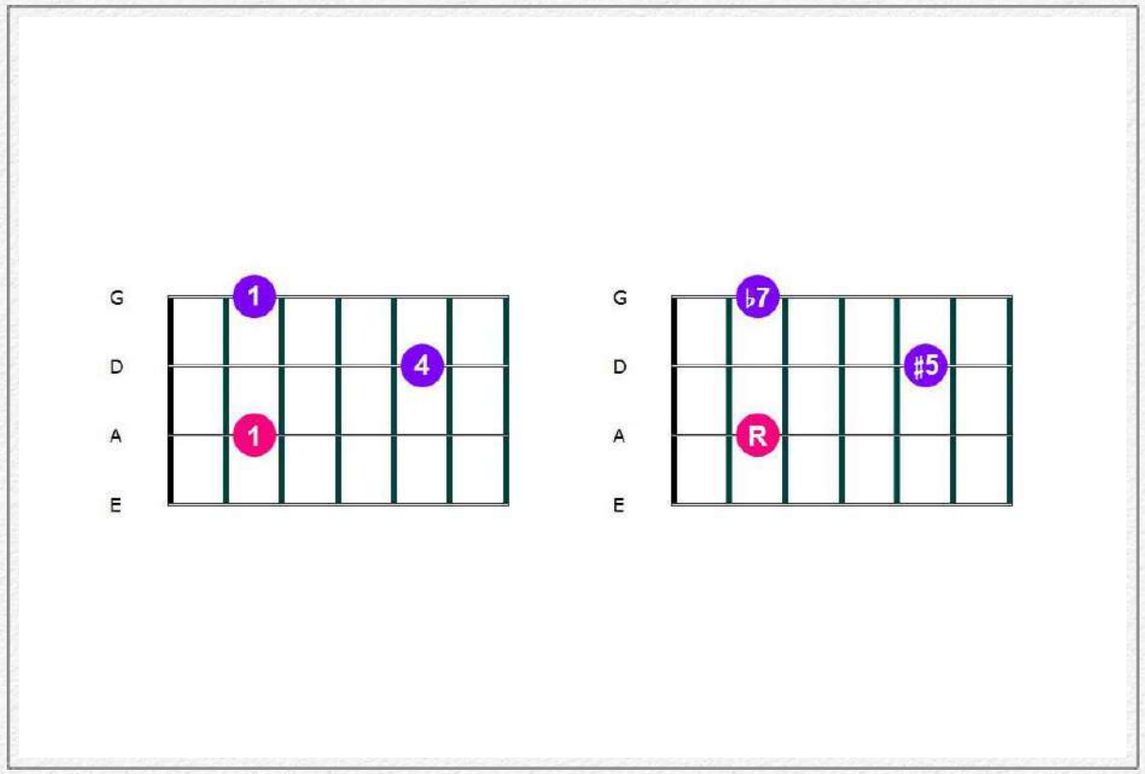
Diminished 7th



The Diminished 7th chord is formed by a diminished triad (1, ♭ 3, ♭ 5) with the addition of a double-flat 7th (1, ♭ 3, ♭ 5, ♭ ♭ 7). Cdim7 is built with the notes C, E ♭ , G ♭ , B ♭ ♭ .

Notice two things here. First, this chord is non-diatonic. Second, a double-flat 7th is the same as a 6th — a seventh is used for consistency in chord construction.

Augmented 7th



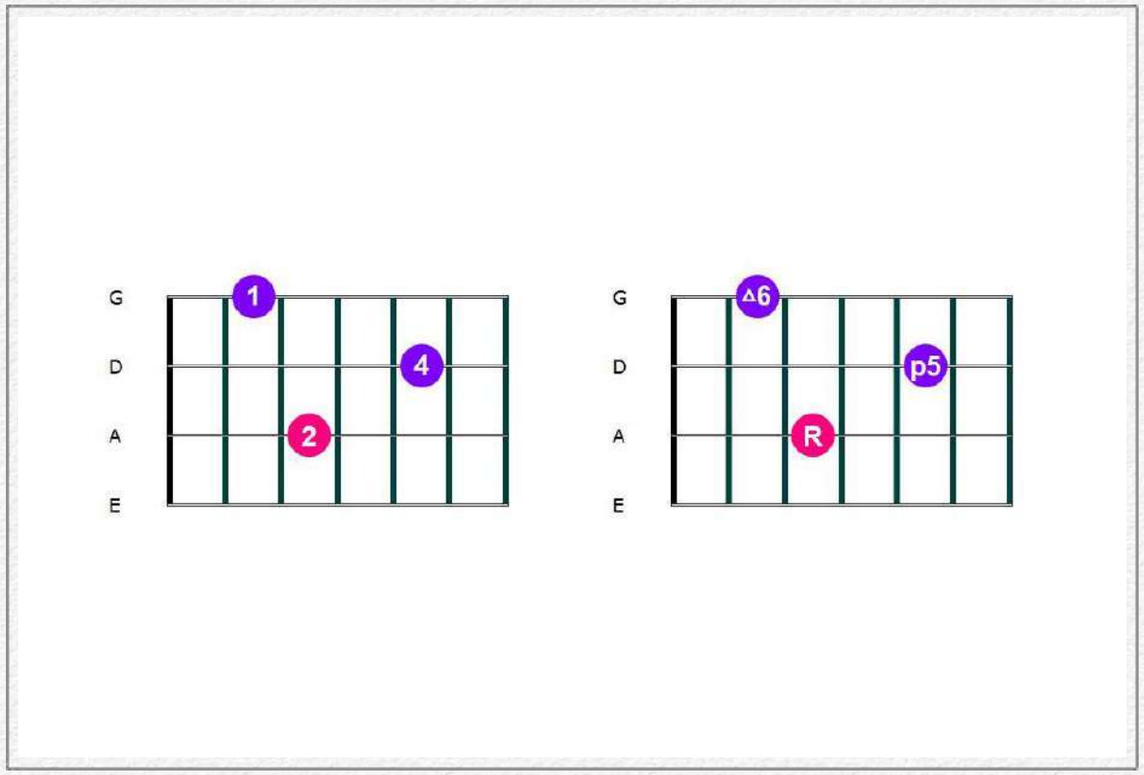
The augmented 7th chord is a dominant 7th chord with a sharped 5th (1, 3, #5, ♭ 7). C Aug7 is built with the notes C, E, G#, B ♭ .

6th Chords

A 6th chord is a four-note chord that add the interval of a major 6th to a major triad.

They consist of a root, a major 3rd, a perfect 5th, and a major 6th (1, 3, 5, 6).

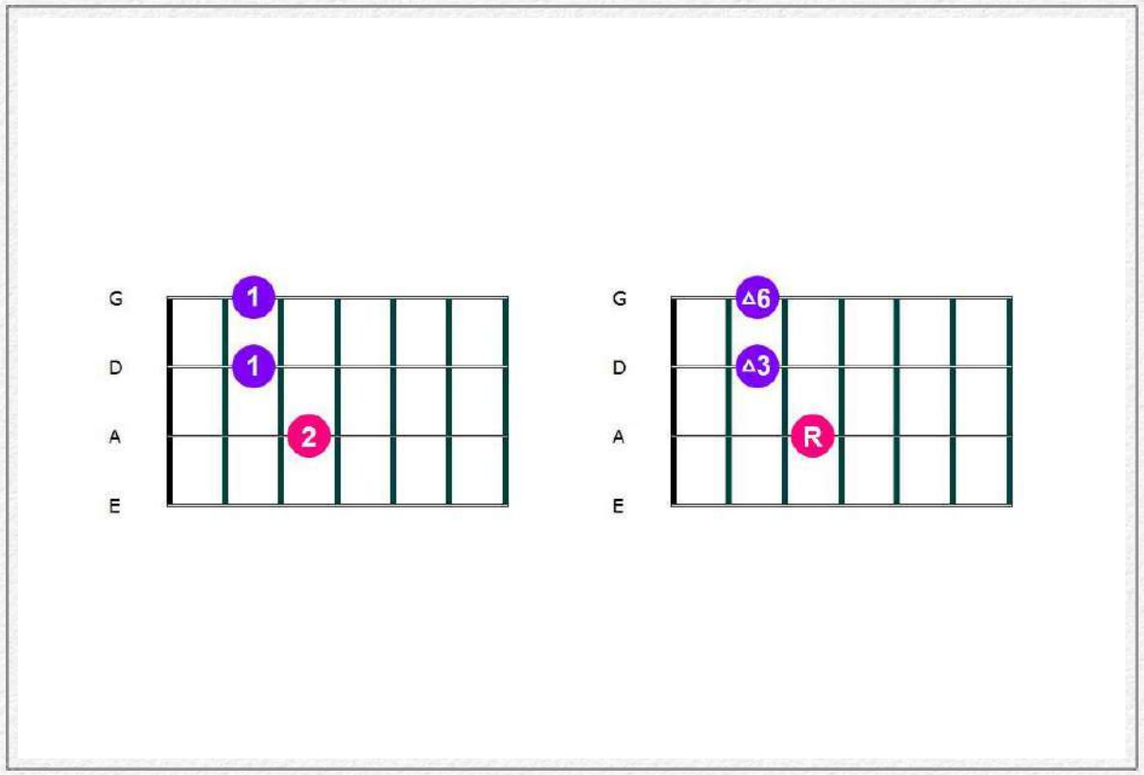
6th Chord



This option does not use the third. C6 is built with the notes C, E, G, A.

6th Chord

Option 2



Here is another option for a 6th chord. This option drops the 5th. Notice that this chord is enharmonic (uses the same notes but has a different name) to a major chord in 2nd inversion.

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Extended Chords

Extended chords are 7th chords with additional intervals added.

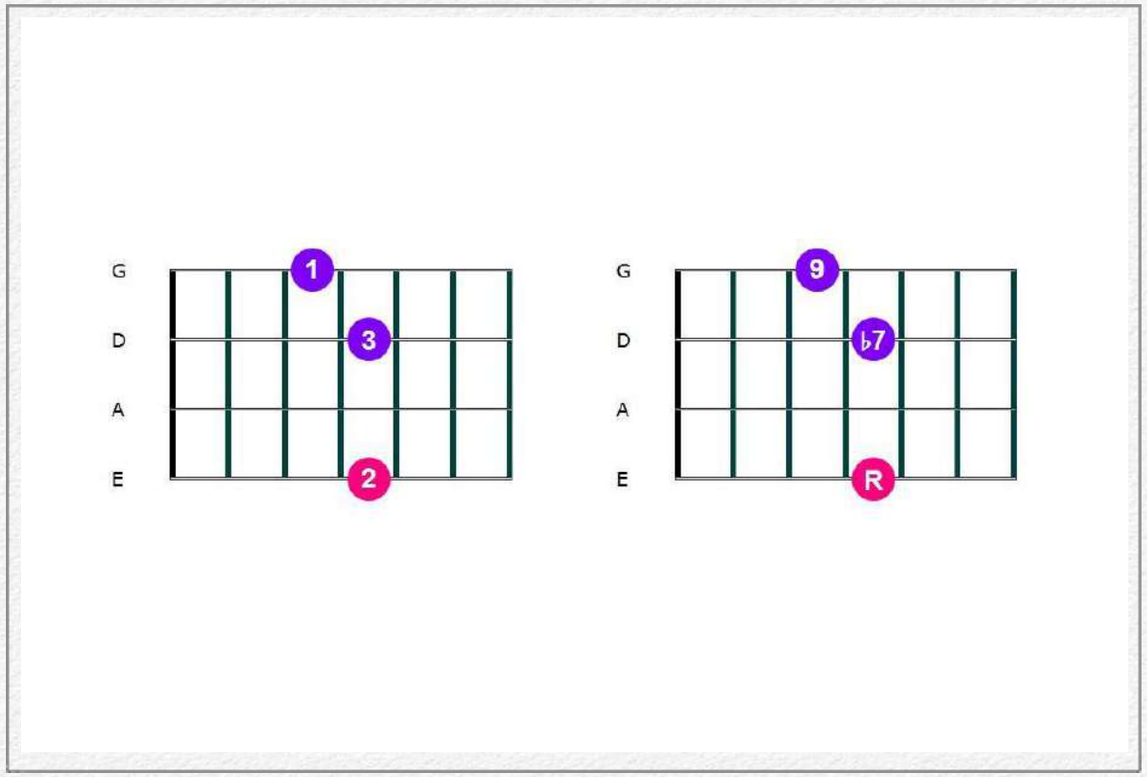
These types of chords include 9th, 11th, and 13th chords.

There are three types of each of these extended chords: dominant, major and minor.

9th chords are five-note chords. 11ths are six-note chords. 13ths are seven-note chords.

To play these chords on the bass, some notes must be left out. It helps the notes that remain ring more clearly.

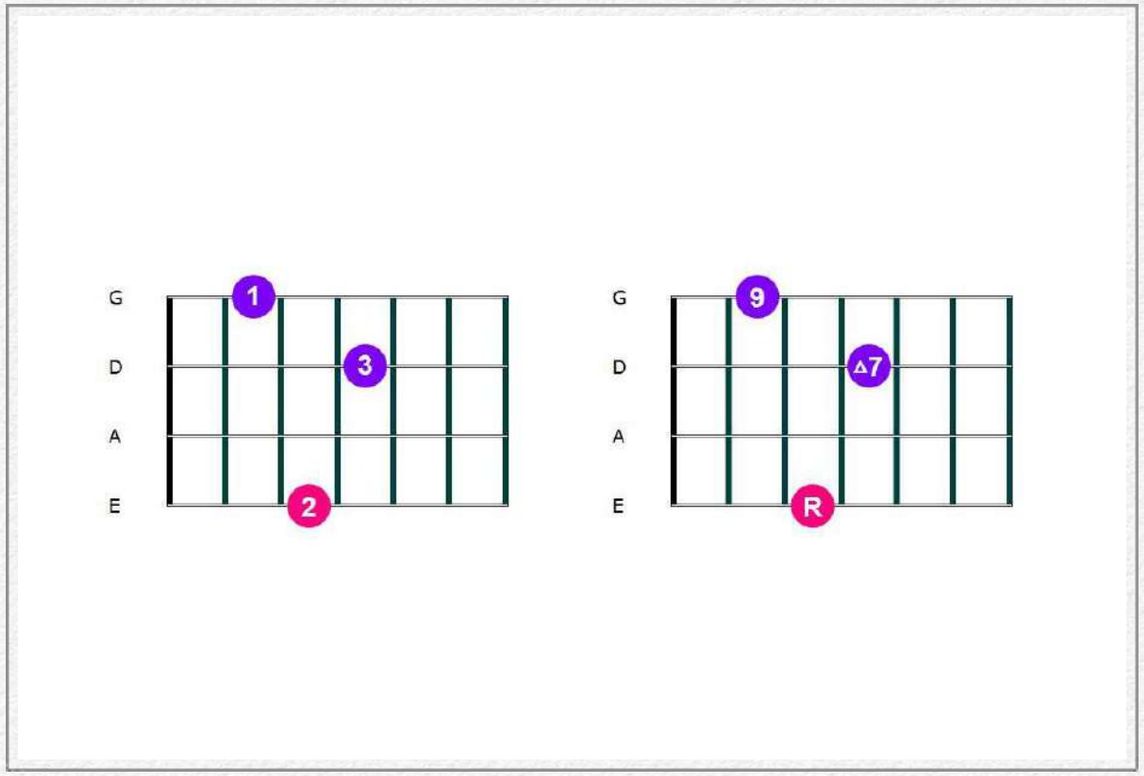
9th Chord



The 9th Chord is formed by a Dominant 7th chord (1, 3, 5, ♭7) with the addition of a 9th (a major 2nd above the octave - 1, 3, 5, ♭7, 9).

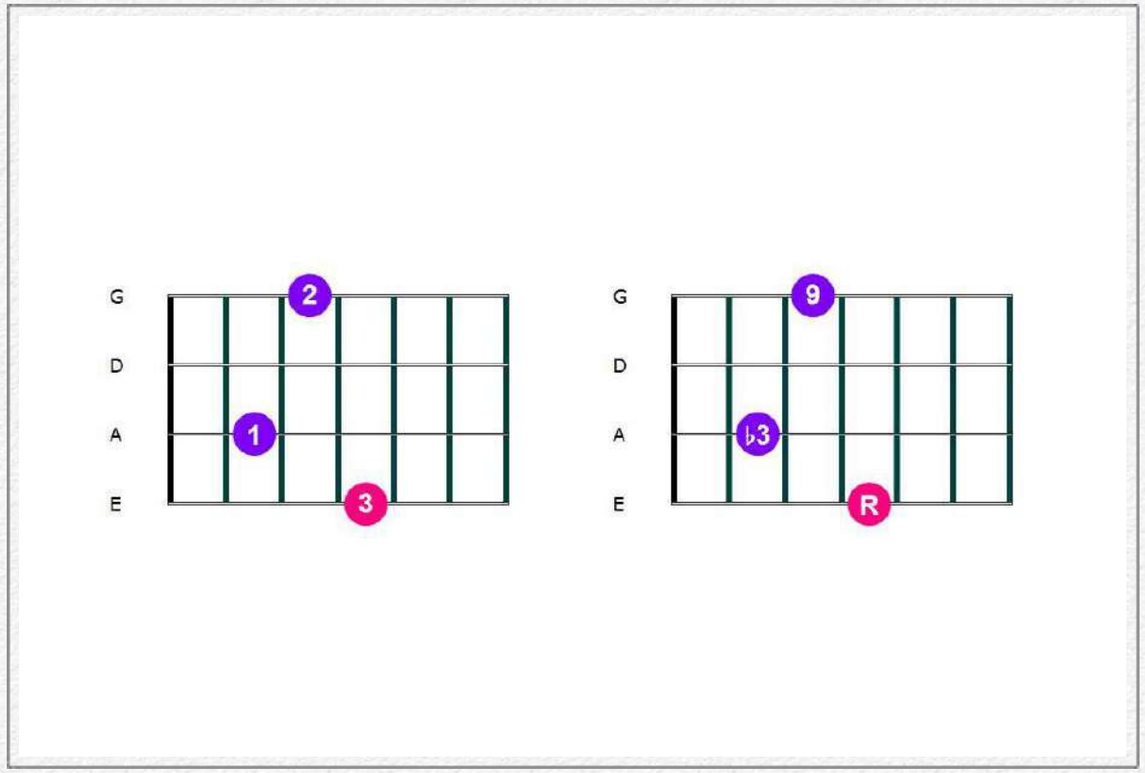
The 3rd or 5th are sometimes left out to change the sonic shape of the chord.

Major 9th Chord



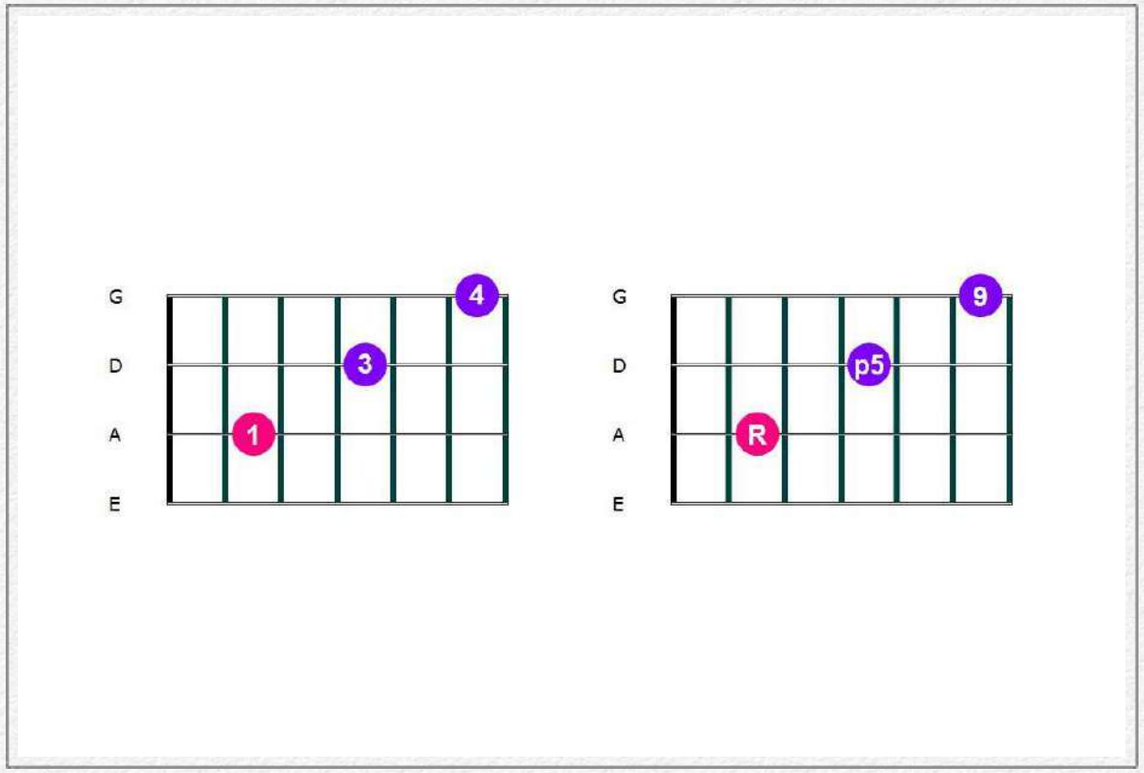
The major 9th chord is formed by a major 7th chord (1, 3, 5, 7) with the addition of a 9th (a major 2nd above the octave - 1, 3, 5, 7, 9).

Minor 9th Chord



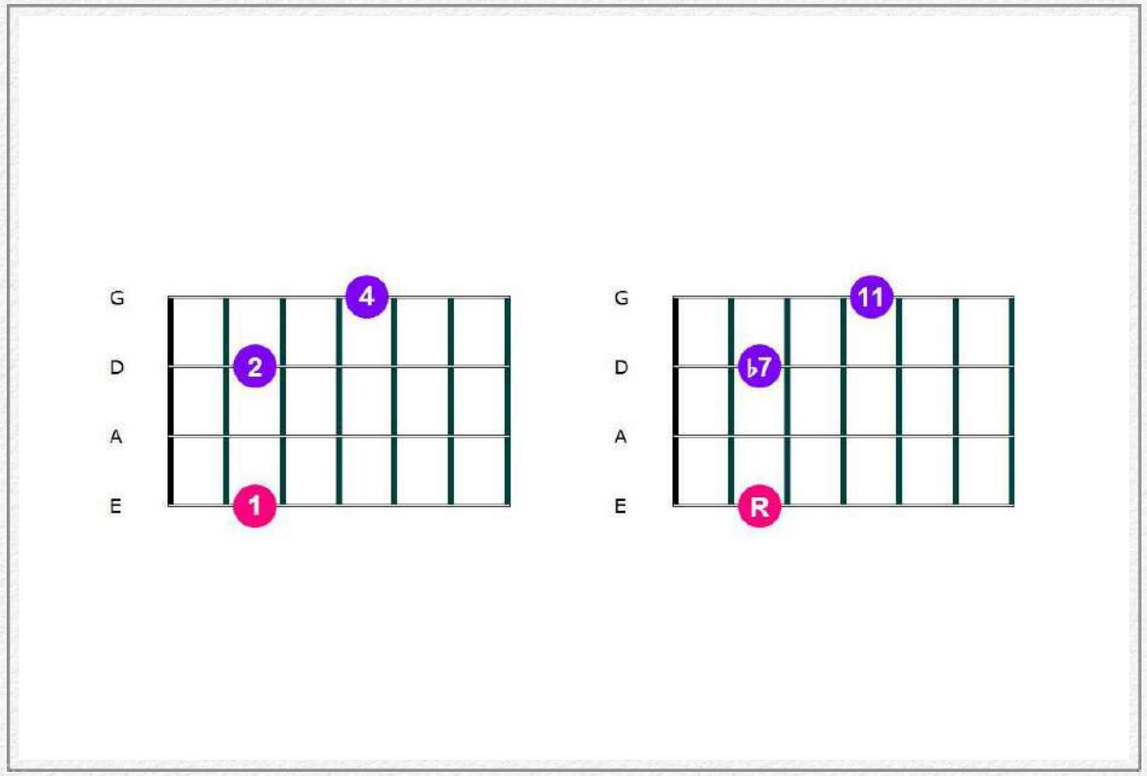
The minor 9th chord is formed by a minor 7th chord with an additional 9th (1, ♭ 3, 5, ♭ 7, 9).

Add 9 Chord



The Add 9 chord is formed by a major triad with an additional 9th (1, 3, 5, 9). There is no 7th.

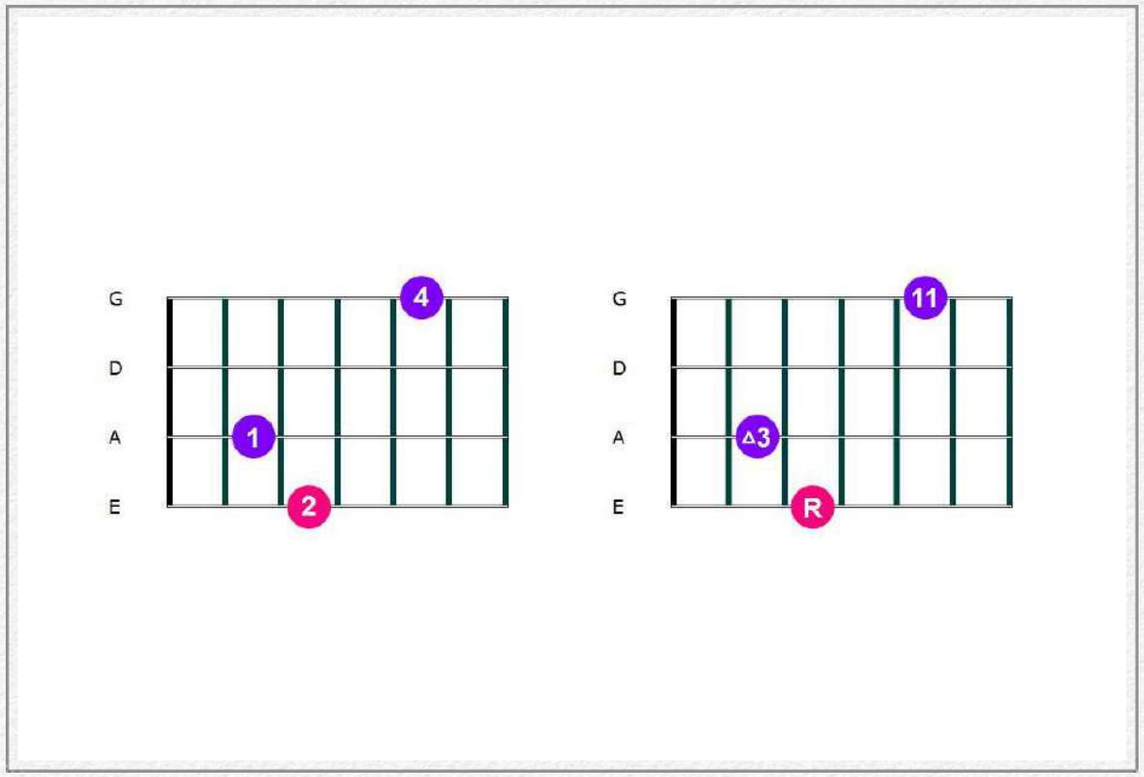
11th Chord



The 11th chord (also called the Dominant 11th chord) is formed by a dominant 9th chord with an additional 11th (1, 3, 5, ♭ 7, 9, 11).

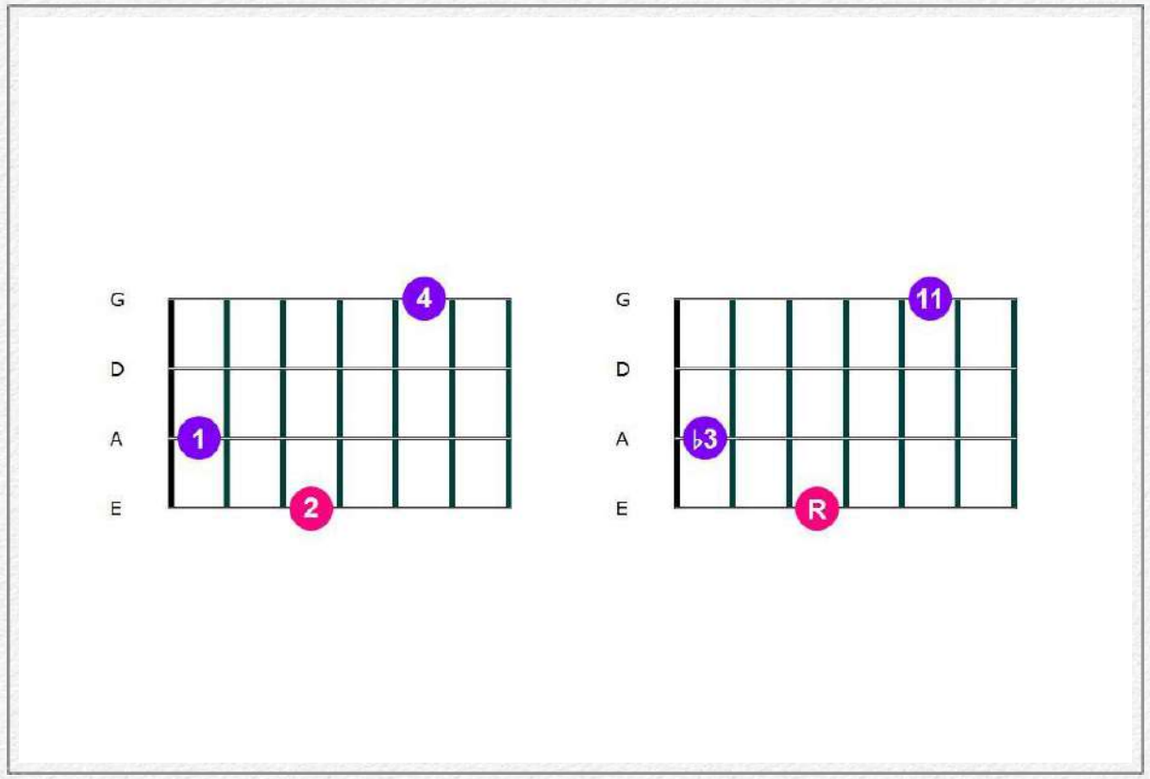
Notice in the case above that the third has been dropped. This means this chord could also be called a suspended chord. For example, if this were a C11th it could also be called C7sus4.

Major 11th Chord



The major 11th chord is formed by a major 9th chord (1, 3, 5, 7, 9) with the addition of an 11th (1, 3, 5, 7, 9, 11).

Minor 11th



The Minor 11th chord is formed by a Minor 9th chord (1, ♭ 3, 5, ♭ 7, 9) with the addition of an 11th (1, ♭ 3, 5, ♭ 7, 9, 11).

Suspended Chords

Suspended chords are formed by replacing the 3rd of a major or minor triad, usually with a 4th and sometimes with a 2nd.

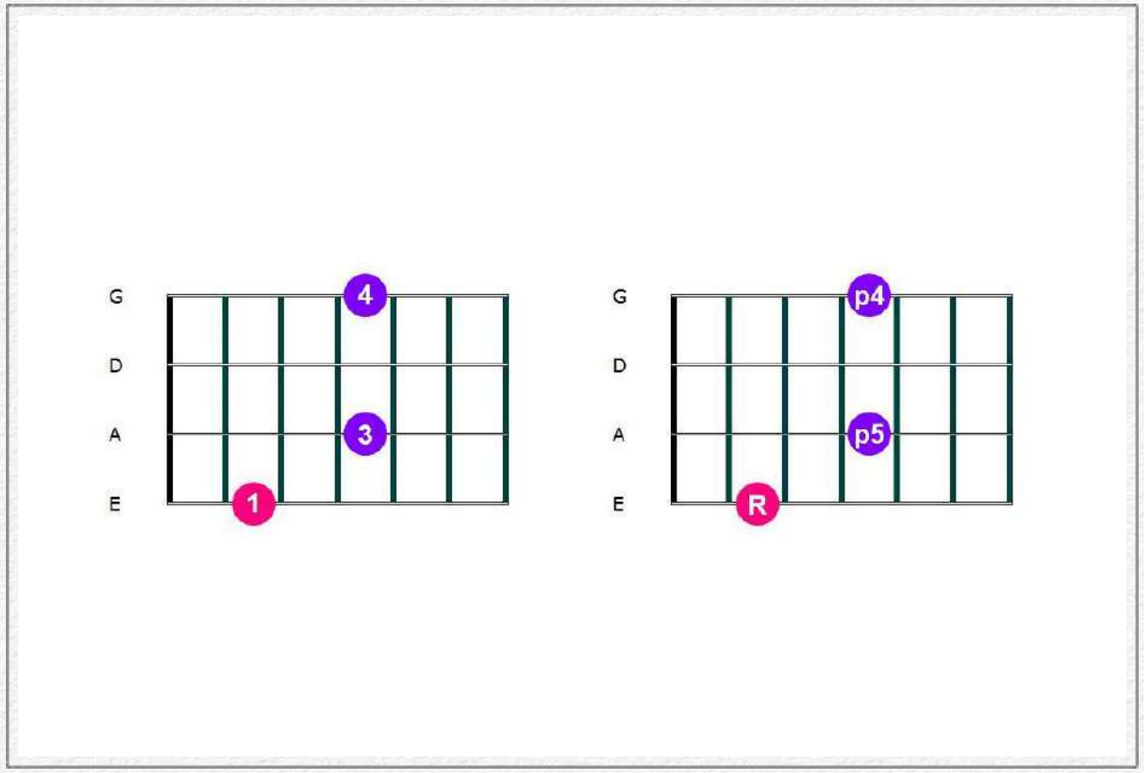
This gives us two types of suspended chords: the suspended 4th and the suspended 2nd.

The Sus4 chord is formed by a root, a perfect 4th, and a perfect 5th (1, 4, 5)

The Sus2 chord is formed by a root, a major 2nd, and a perfect 5th (1, 2, 5)

Since there is no 3rd in a suspended chord it transcends classification as a major or minor chord.

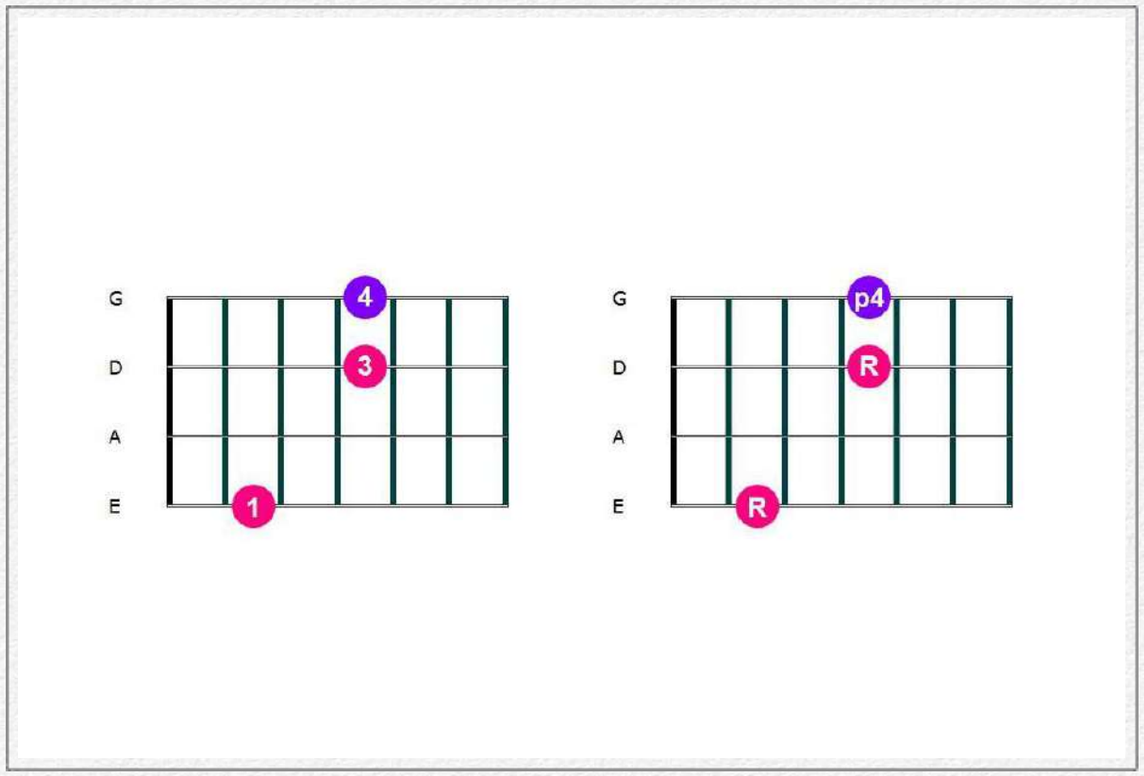
Suspended 4th



The Sus4 is the more common type of suspended chord. If you see a notation that just reads “sus” as in Csus. Play it as a Sus4.

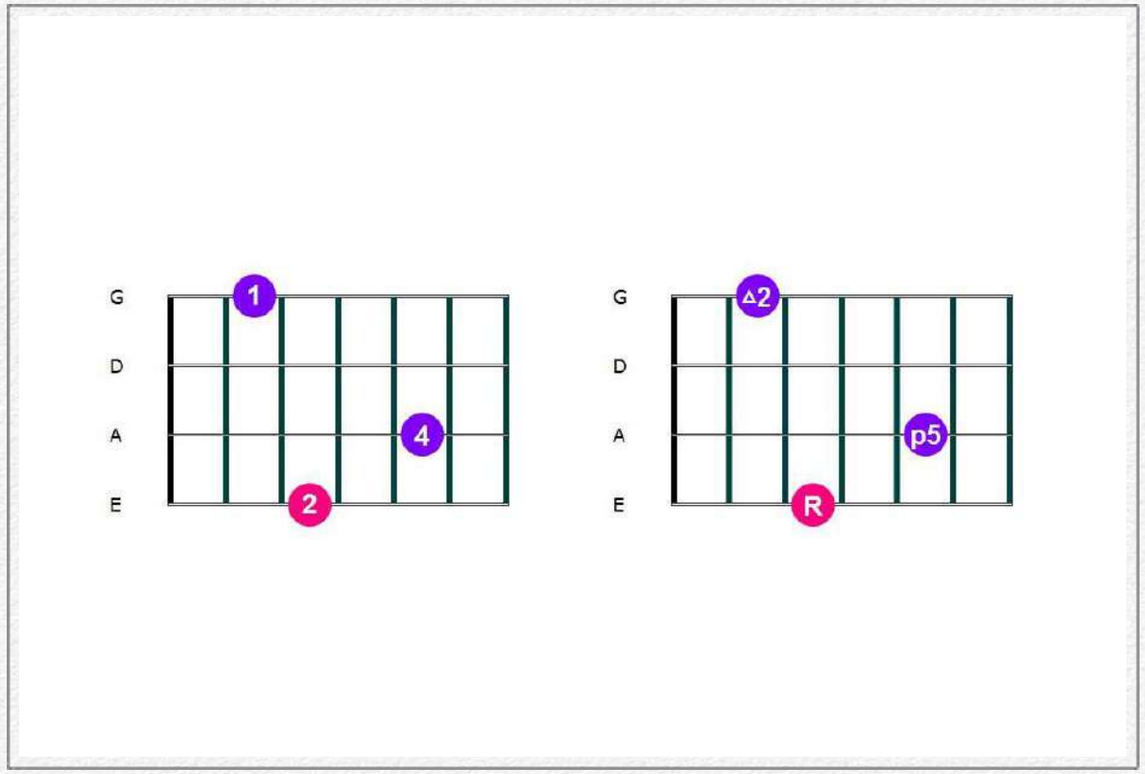
Suspended 4th

Option 2



Here we have another option for a Sus4 chord.

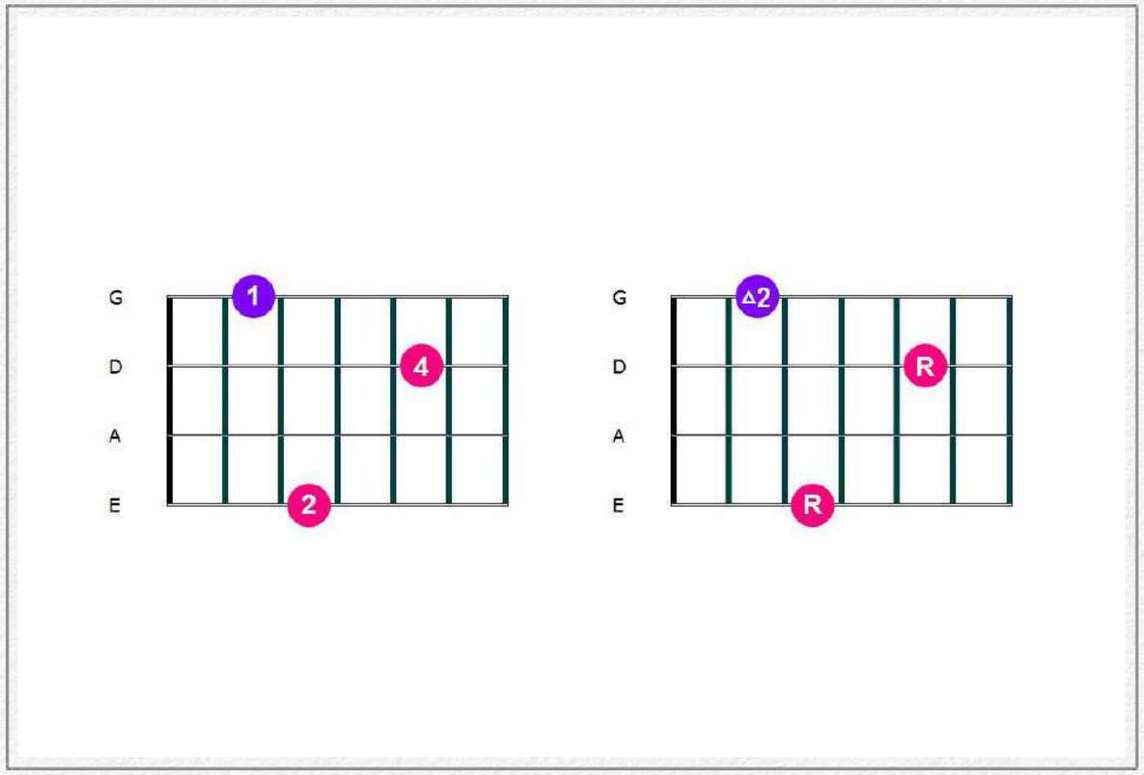
Suspended 2nd



The Sus2 is another form of suspended chord. In this case the third is replaced by a major second (1, 2, 5).

Suspended 2nd

Option 2



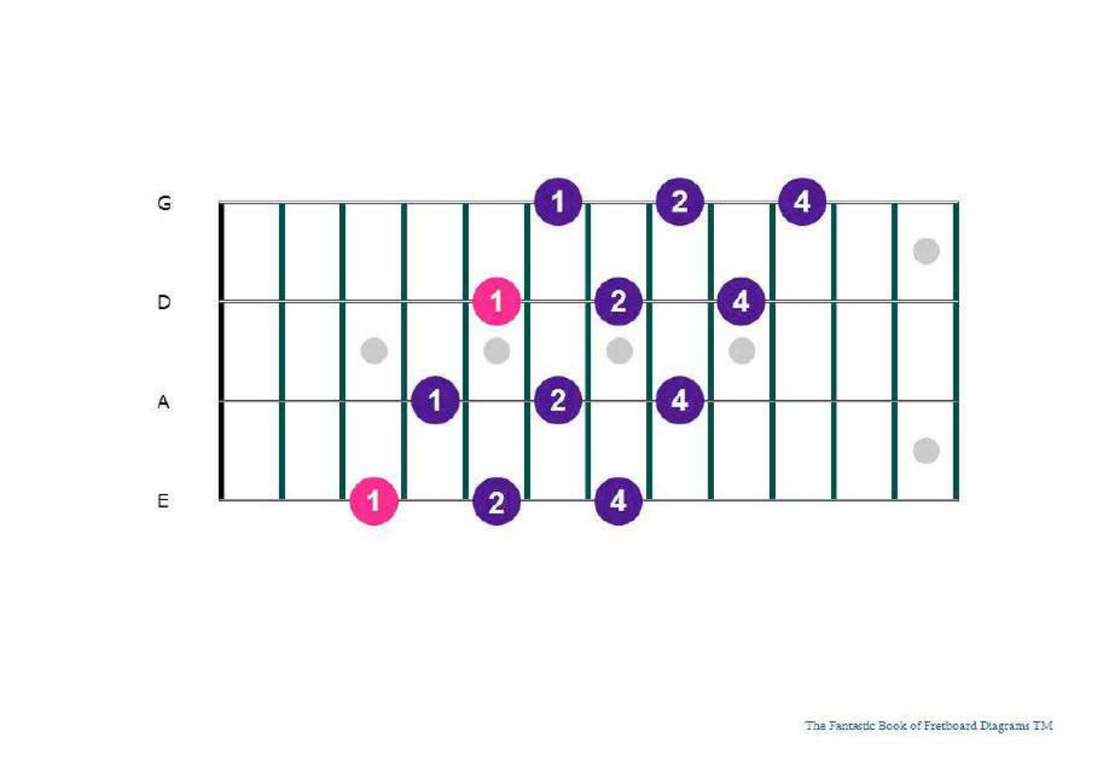
Here is another option for a Sus2 chord.

Whole Tone Scale

13

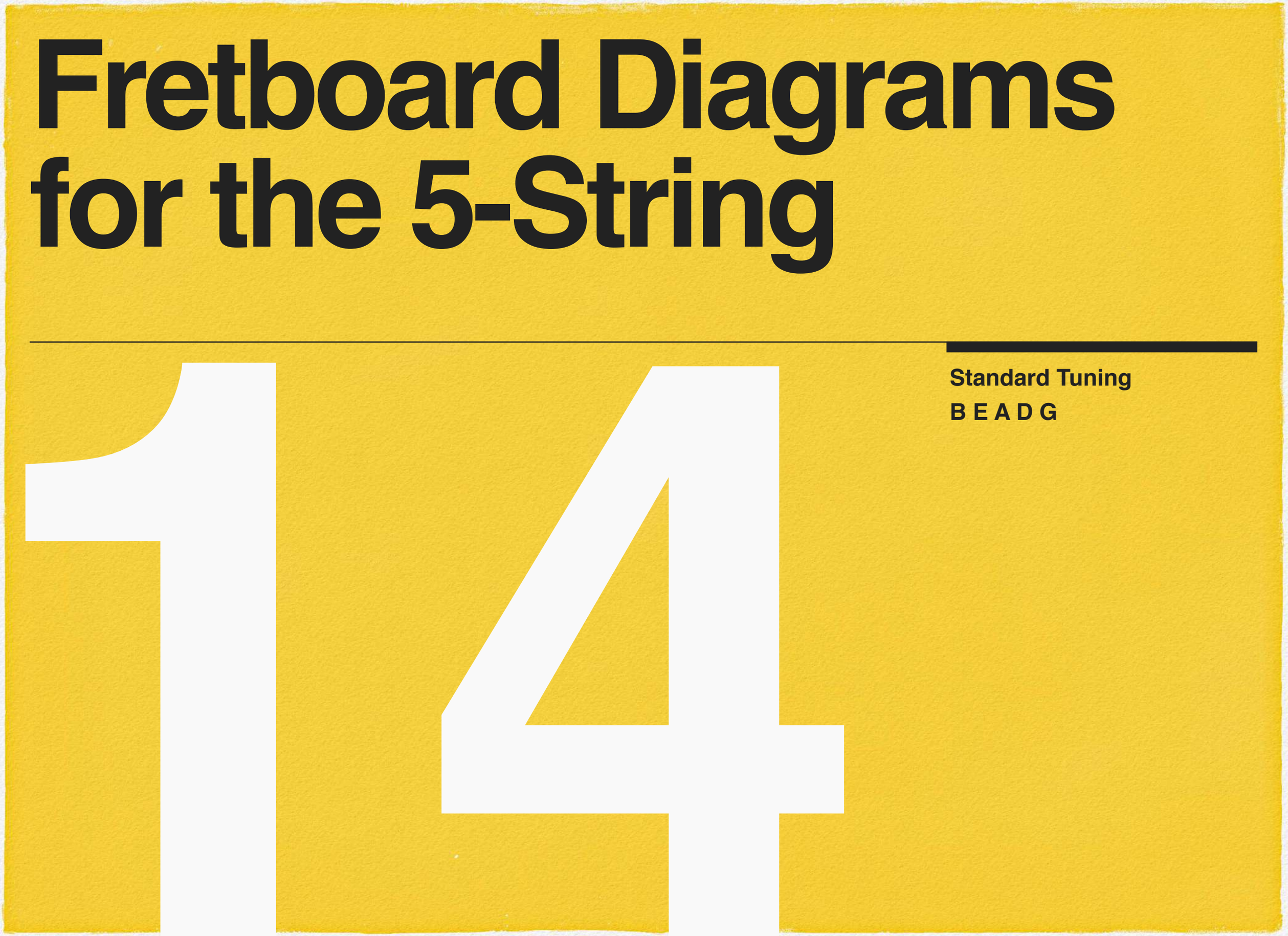
The whole tone scale is a hexatonic (six note scale) consisting only of whole tones. This scale contains no semitones and, therefore, it has no leading tones (a note a half-step away from a second note to which the leading note often resolves).

Whole Tone Scale



The whole tone scale is usually played with an augmented chord or a dominant 7th chord. For example, the D whole tone scale fits with a D augmented chord.

Fretboard Diagrams for the 5-String

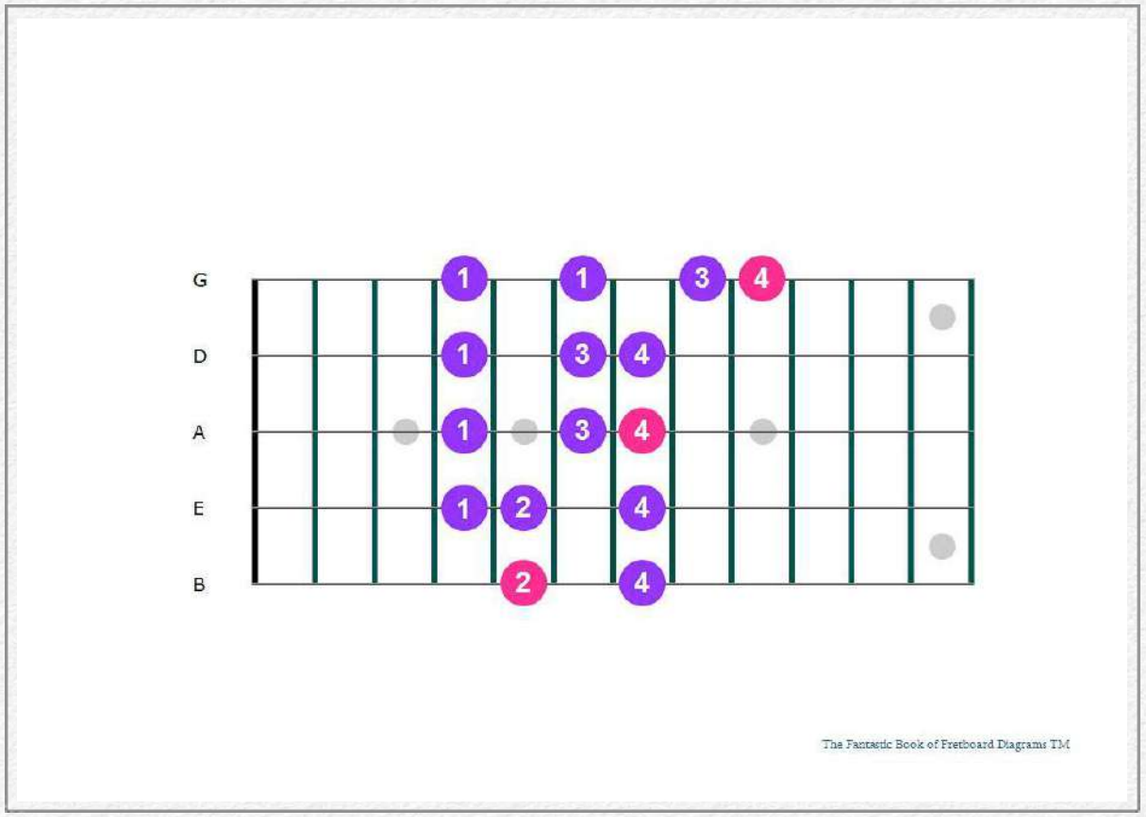


Standard Tuning

B E A D G

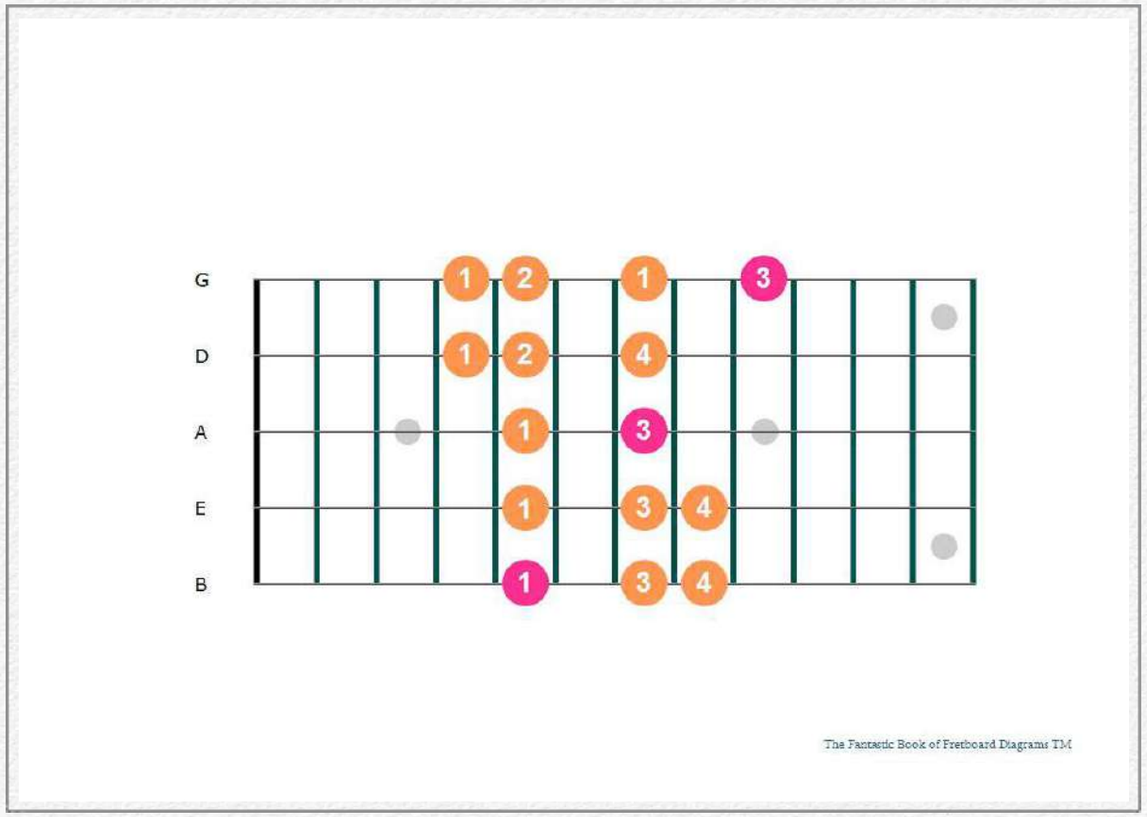
The Major Scale

Two Octaves



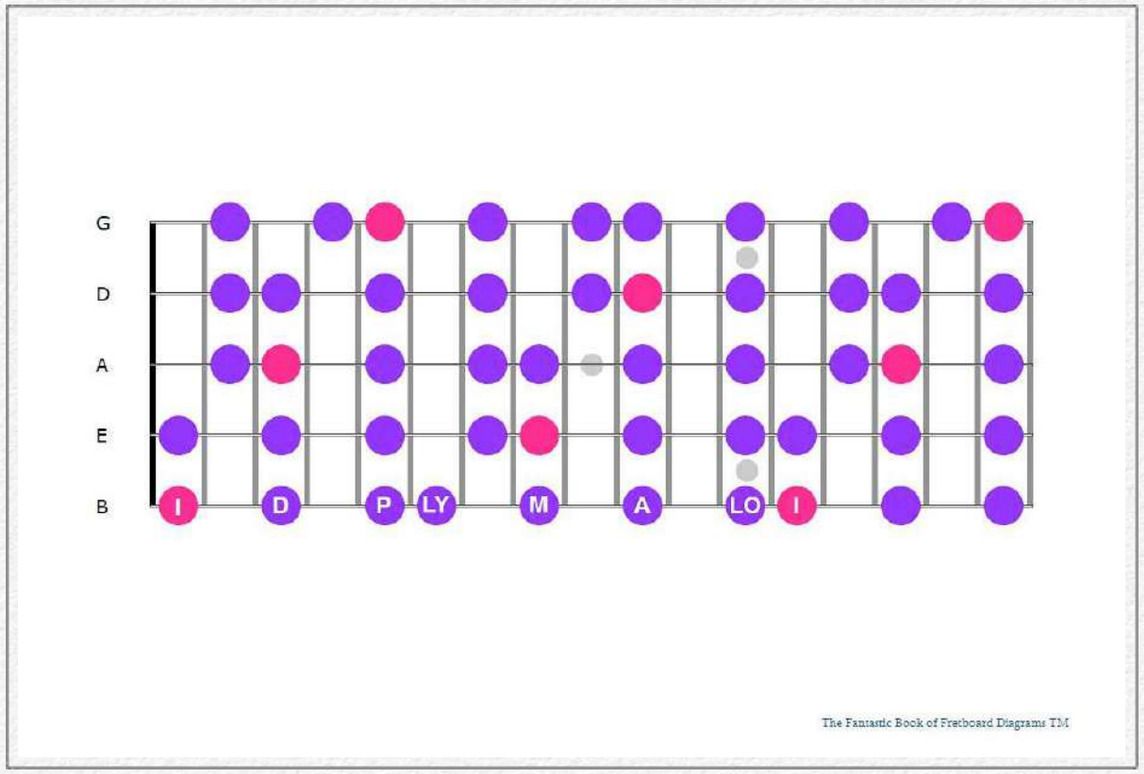
The Minor Scale

Two Octaves



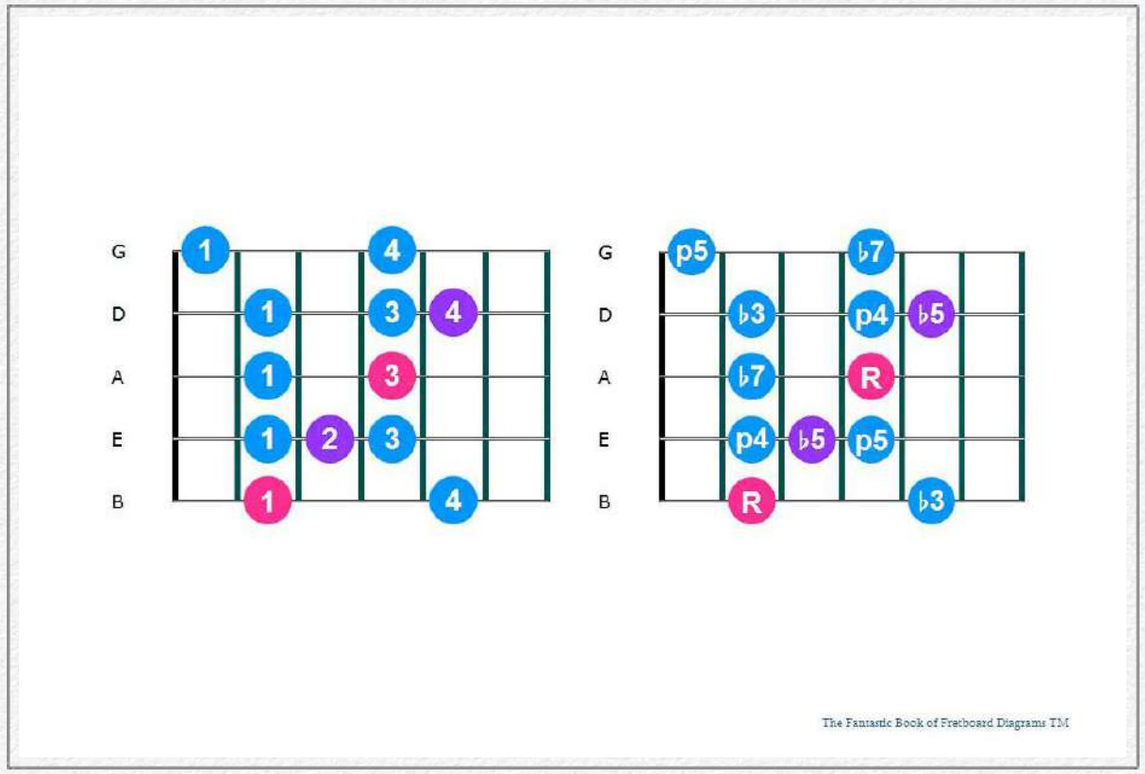
Modes Together

for the Five String



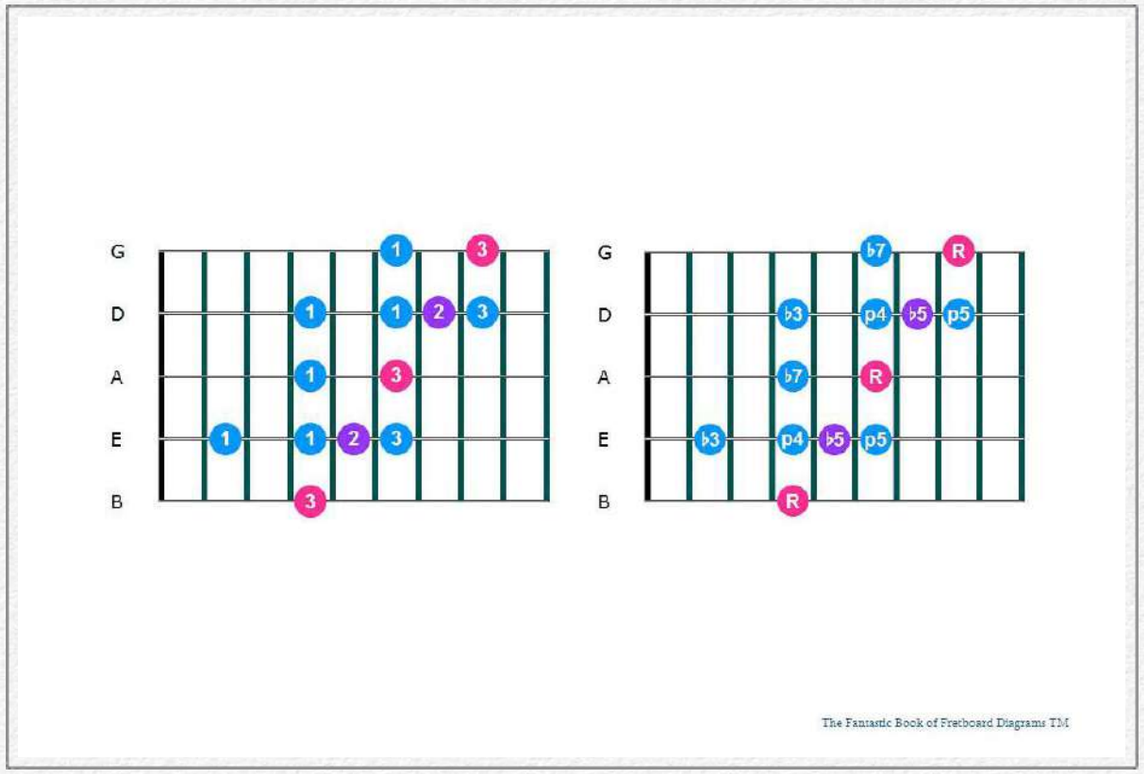
Blues Scale

Five String - Option One



Blues Scale

Five String - Option 2



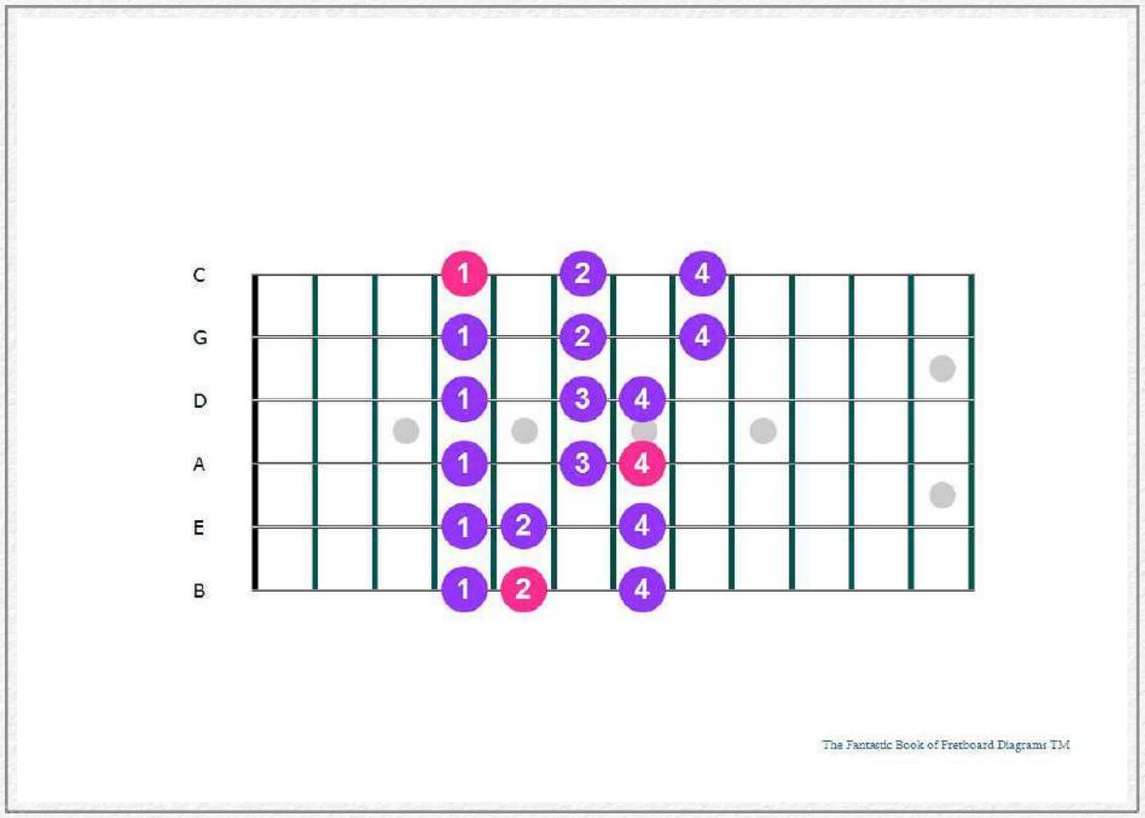
Fretboard Diagrams for the 6-String

Standard Tuning

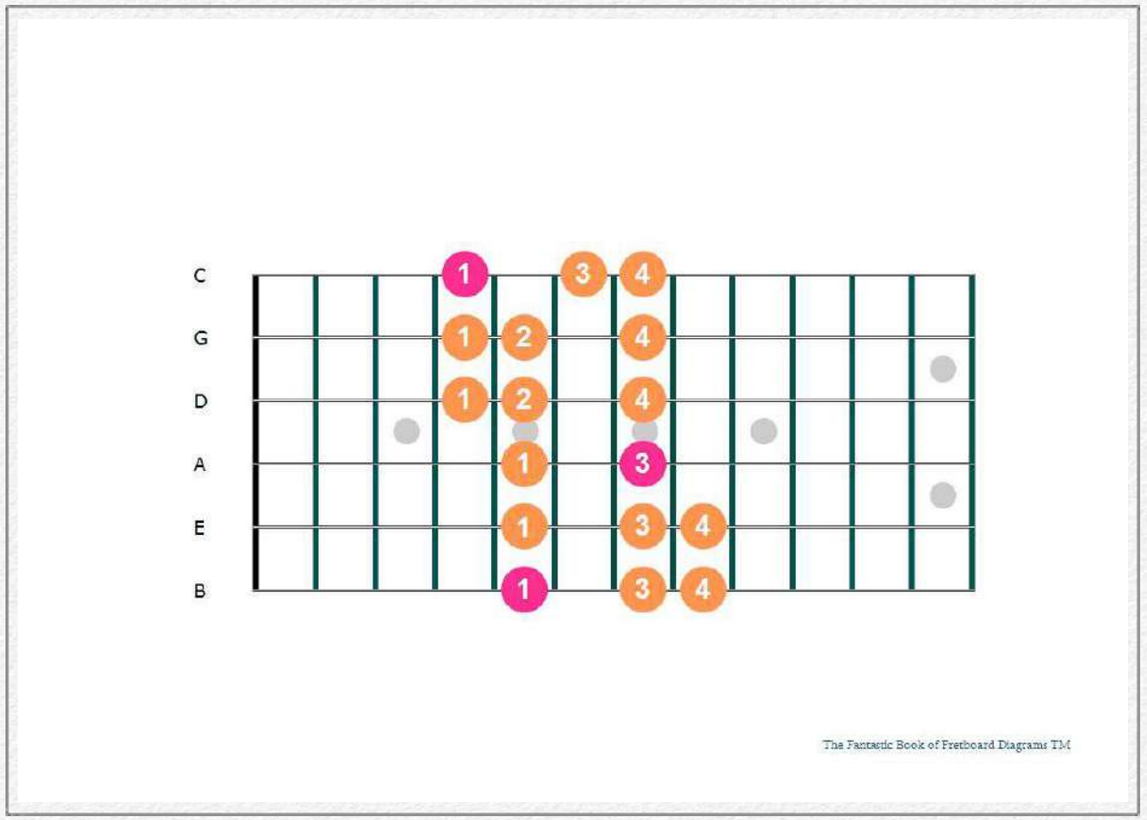
B E A D G C

15

The Major Scale

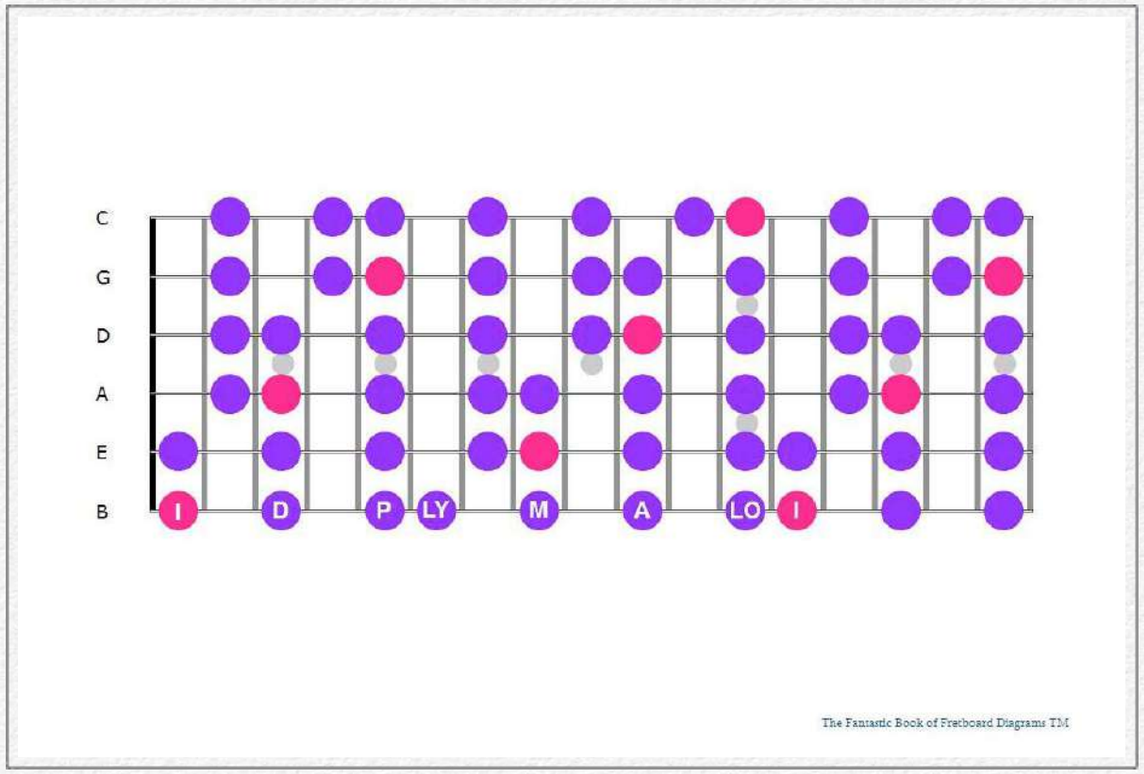


The Minor Scale



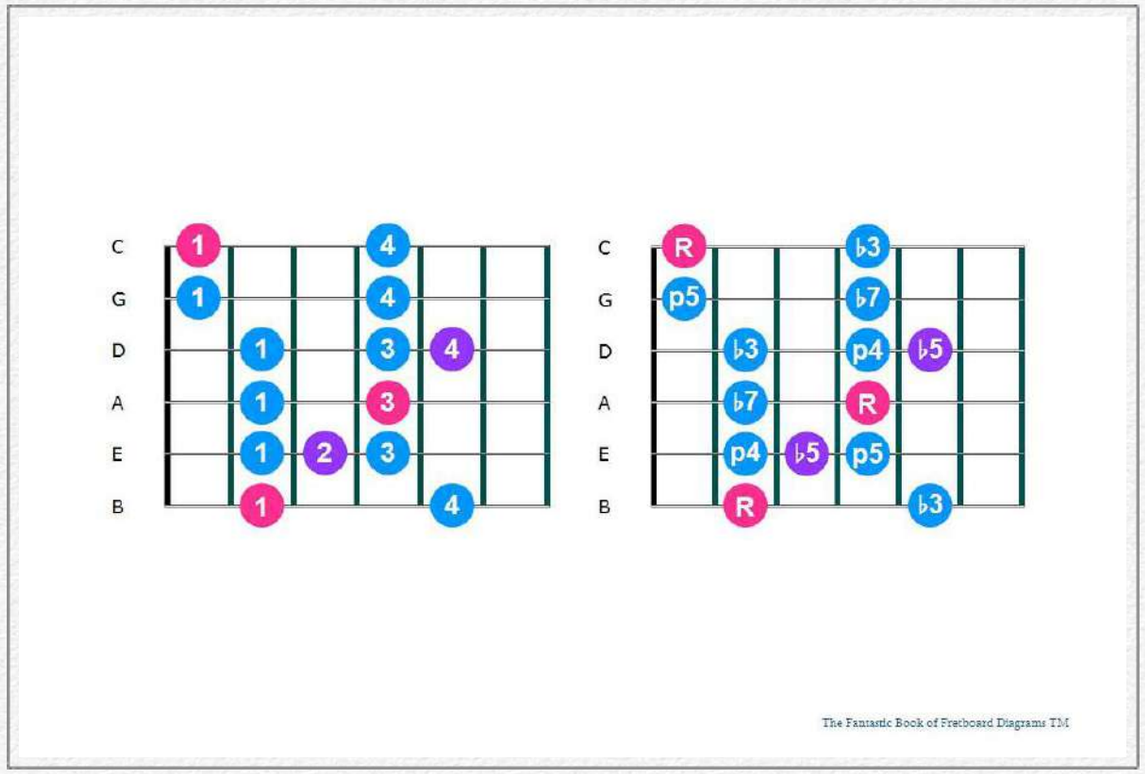
Modes Together

for the Six String



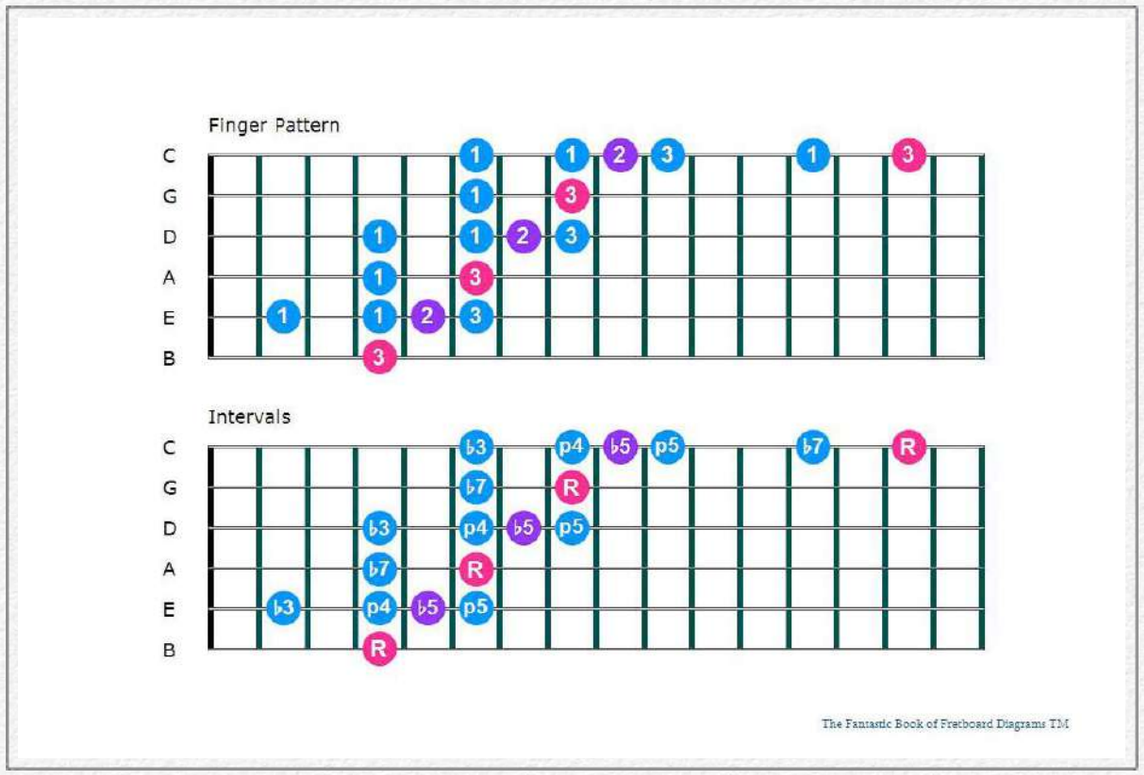
Blues Scale

Six String - Option One



Blues Scale

Six String - Option 2



From the Book's Creator

This book is dedicated to you, the artist, with every best wish for carrying your music forward.

Best regards,
Rajiv

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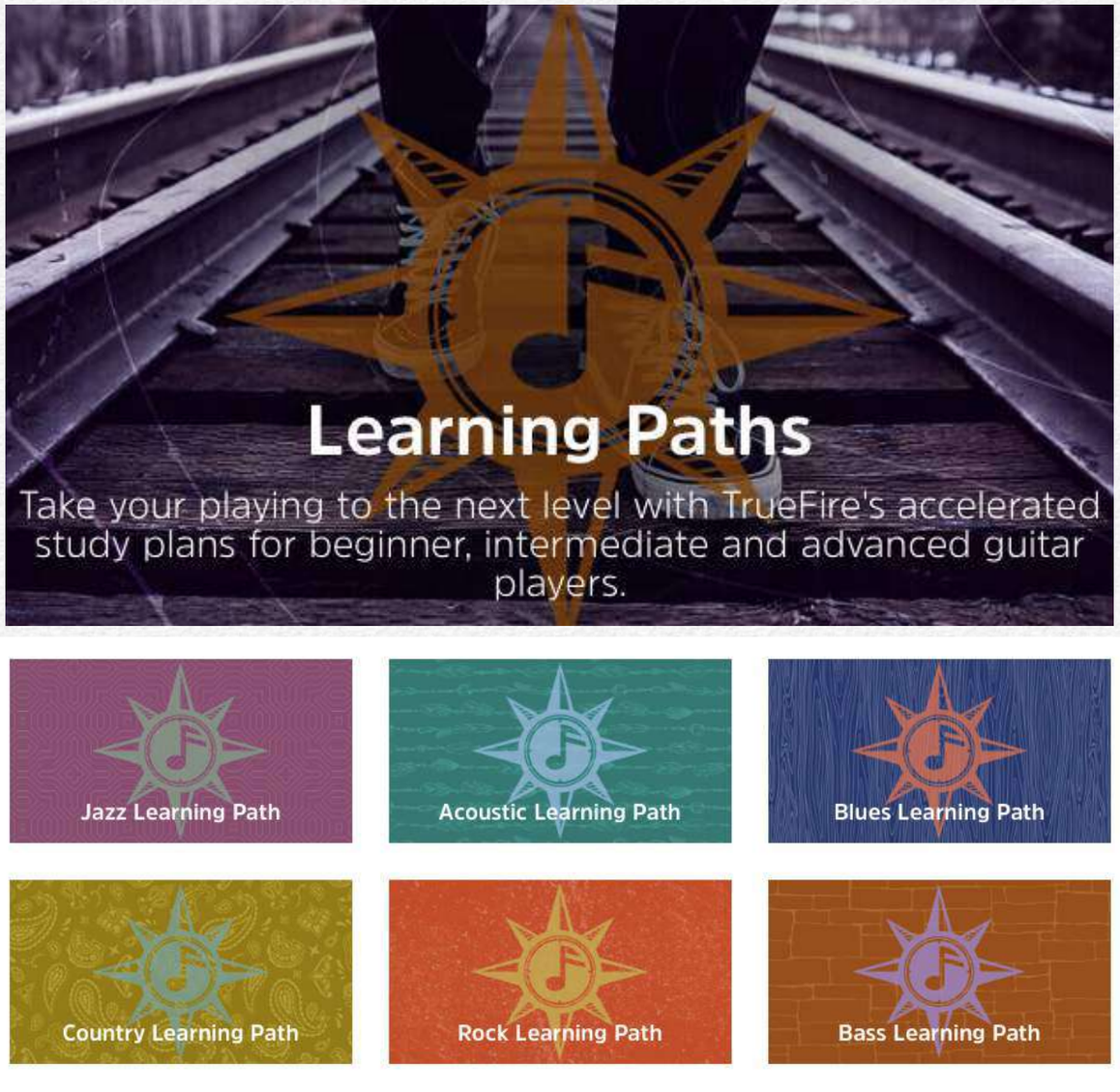

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